

HOW PHOTOGRAPHY CHANGED PHILOSOPHY

ROUTLEDGE



ROUTLEDGE HISTORY OF PHOTOGRAPHY

DANIEL RUBINSTEIN

How Photography Changed Philosophy

By analysing the philosophical lineage of notions of representation, time, being, light, exposure, image, and truth, this book argues that photography is the visual manifestation of the philosophical account of how humans encounter beings in the present.

Daniel Rubinstein argues that traditional understandings of photography are determined by the notions of verisimilitude and representation, and this limits our understanding of photographic materiality. It is suggested that the photographic image must be closely read not for the objects, events and situations represented in it, but for the insights it affords into the structure of contemporary consciousness.

The book will be of interest to scholars working in photography, media studies, philosophy, fine art, and art history.

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How Photography Changed Philosophy

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How Photography Changed Philosophy

Daniel Rubinstein

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Routledge Companion to Photography Theory, eds. Mark Durden and Jane Tormey, Routledge, 2019.

The Handbook of Photography Studies, ed. Gil Pasternak, Bloomsbury Press, 2019.

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Preface: the emergence of photo-philosophy

I. A monstrous child of the Enlightenment

There are two ways in which the invention of photography marks a watershed moment in the history of Western societies, and specifically in the history of the Enlightenment. The first is that a threshold is reached with photography that enunciates the emergence of a new form of technologically rather than humanly determined consciousness. The photograph created a virtual reality, both similar and distinct from the organic world. This new reality borrowed something from the internal world of memories, dreams and fantasy and fused it with the operations of a machine. And second, photography challenged the centuries-old distinction between originals and copies and the hierarchical relationship between them. If aesthetic theory since Plato begins by assuming that a thing is a representation of an idea and an image is a representation of a thing, then what follows from it is a strictly binary logic in which the thing is primary and authentic, and the image is a clone of the thing, secondary and inauthentic. What photography enabled was a way of thinking beyond the reductive logic of binary opposites such as subject/object, image/copy and mind/body, which are the foundational principles of enlightenment thinking.

Enlightenment has its historical roots in the scientific revolution of the seventeenth century and in the belief that human intellect can explain nature and operate as an independent and autonomous force in the world. Some of the critical ingredients of the Enlightenment can be found in Descartes' (1970) idea of mental representations, in Hobbes' (2017) claim that reasoning is calculating and in Leibniz's (1998) notion that all knowledge could be expressed through a set of primitives. These aspirations to grasp the world rationally and scientifically were succinctly summarised by Kant in a famous essay, 'What is Enlightenment'. Kant proclaimed that Enlightenment is humankind's release from its self-incurred immaturity. 'Immaturity is the inability to use one's own understanding without the guidance of another' (Kant 1959). For Kant, as for many others, Enlightenment signals a break with the world order established on the foundations of a religious and feudal worldview. Kant's challenge for the new era was for humanity to abandon its reliance on external validation and become self-directing and autonomous.

The basic premise of Enlightenment thinking is summed up by the Cartesian 'Cogito ergo sum', which speaks to a particular understanding of what it is to be human. Descartes grounds truth and knowledge in the logic of the subject (cogito) and posits the world as an object that can be comprehended only through a symbolic representational schema. Descartes's method of radical doubt leads to a theory of knowledge based on the mind-body dichotomy and institutes subjectivity as the basic unit of existence. The philosophy of Descartes equipped Enlightenment with two of its foundational chasms: the ontological distinction between mind and body and the

epistemological distinction between subject and object. The critical point to bear in mind is that Enlightenment thinking is founded on the assumption that body and mind are two fundamental substances that have nothing in common. Matter came to be defined in scientific and mathematical terms as something that can be measured and rationally explained. The seventeenth century produced a schema for grasping the world scientifically by reducing it to an abstraction that can be represented by force of reason alone. The success of this approach cemented the dichotomy of matter and mind in which matter can be known by its space–time coordinates, and the mind is posited against matter as the reasoning, knowing substance that is opposed to matter. (Whitehead 2010, p. 70)

One consequence that followed from the scientific revolution is that the finite cosmos of the middle-ages was replaced with the infinite space of the modern period. This shift from the closed and predetermined feudal system to the open-ended world picture of early capitalism and humanism necessitated the invention of new political institutions and new ways of looking at the world. The invention of photo-mechanical image-making in the first half of the nineteenth century fitted perfectly with the Enlightenment's concern with the problem of indexing, cataloguing, mapping and categorising the world as the main means of achieving mastery and control over it. The form of knowledge that Enlightenment put forward was fundamentally visual and focused on the human eye as the medium for a rational exploration of the world. For a time at least, photography contributed to realising the enlightenment program of a world order centred around human vision in which representation was the guarantor of knowledge and truth.

Because photography literally means *writing with light*, it is very difficult to get beyond the notion that photography is fundamentally something other than a representational mechanism capable of delivering precise, repeatable and trustworthy results. According to the oculo-centric approach to photography championed by the Enlightenment, the artist or the person operating the camera is responsible for the emergence, production, and dissemination of the photographic image (Jay 2004). The enlightenment project brought forward the notion that knowledge is no longer the province of God, but it is rooted in the human and in his ability to picture the world so that the picture can deliver verifiable and accurate knowledge. Within the enlightenment way of thinking, the photographic image can be understood only as a human endeavour and therefore as a depiction of the reality that is external to it, and it can only be conceived as a story about the world, an illustration, a representation or in other words as a stream of information.

In a certain sense, photography is the poster child of the Enlightenment, embodying, as it were, all the critical characteristics of a way of thinking that places the human eye at the centre of the world. There is, of course, no denying that photography can indeed perform the role allocated to it by the Enlightenment. But equally – and crucially for this book – it does not have to be so. While the representational paradigm is deeply ingrained in the way photography is conceptualised and generally perceived, this book explores another way of thinking about photography that takes seriously the paradigmatic shift away from Enlightenment thinking that is ushered in by the information age.

2. From representation to emergence

Rather than considering photography as an extension of the Enlightenment that stubbornly persists into the twenty-first century, this book understands photography as a challenge to enlightenment thinking. The argument put forward in the following chapters is that the photographic image established a new reality, in which memory, knowledge, and perception are no longer the domain of specialised human activity but the outcome of mechanical operations. The photographic process has shown that the cognitive function of image-making can be embodied

in mechanical procedures. Out of this situation, a new paradigm emerged that overturned the enlightenment belief in the primacy of human consciousness. The invention of photography brought the industrial revolution into the sphere of identity, subjectivity, representation, and aesthetics. In this way, the photographic revolution can be said to follow in the footsteps of the Copernican and the Darwinian in dismantling the faith in human supremacy. Copernicus has shown that the Earth is not at the centre of the world but a satellite of the sun, Darwin taught that the human is not the pinnacle of creation, but the descendant of other species and photography introduced the possibility of image-making and the acquisition of knowledge by means not of human intelligence but that of a machine.

The Enlightenment freed the human from the shackles of the Middle Ages and from the subordination to the authority of the king / priest / God by giving humans the ability to think for themselves. However, this freedom was bought at a price. The enlightenment model was based on a counterfactual, on not being able to occupy the present, because the rational model of inquiry required that the present will always be re-presented, or in other words, inscribed into a logical, calculable schema in such a way that it could be accessed as information.

We need to examine the foundational enlightenment distinction between the image and factual, objective reality. Not because this distinction is invalid but because this distinction is much more limited than was previously thought. In this regard, it is helpful to draw an analogy with Newtonian physics – the discoveries of quantum field theory do not cancel out classical physics, but they limit its applicability. In their separate ways, Kant and Hegel changed the meaning of truth from the bible to rational representation. What photography is doing is allowing us to move beyond Kant and Hegel in showing that representation does not mean something that was given previously and is now re-presented; Instead, representation implies something that is emerging through the act of being represented. Rather than pointing at something that is outside of it, photography shows that meaning is produced in a feedback loop, foreshadowing the way algorithms operate on data. Photography produces meaning by repetition, but it is not a repetition of identity or sameness; it is a repetition of difference.

Photography does not exist on its own; it only exists as an emergent phenomenon. What is being repeated in photography is not the identity between the image and the object but the difference that emerges through repetition. Here again, it is important to point out a fundamental trait of Enlightenment thinking that photography helps to overcome. For the enlightenment mindset, every copy made from a negative is identical or very similar to the original and all the other copies. For the post-enlightenment thinking, every copy is different. In photography, existence is predicated on internal referentiality set up within the propulsion of the photograph through repetition in which each fragment refers to all the fragments that already happened and to all the fragments that will. The photograph, therefore, both represents the world and within the same movement projects itself over and takes over the entire span of all that is possible for it. As a fragment in a sequence of repetitions, the photograph is self-referential; it does not represent anything besides itself; it forgoes meaning, totality and unity.

The significance of photography to post-enlightenment thinking is in showing and enlarging the mind/matter problem that was always within Enlightenment. Photography shows how the mind/matter can be overcome because, in photography, the image and the thing are not separate; they are fused in a strange way that combines an iconic inscription with material ephemera, giving us the readymade – a thing and an image merged into one in such a way that the subject/object relationship is dissolved, and meaning is inscribed not in what it represents but in the fact of it's being there.

Photography works not only as a representational medium but also as the insight that representation itself is not static, but it is generative. This generative meaning is important

because it is getting rid of the division between subject and object, a division that is so much a part of both the old metaphysics and the new ones. So, photography not only shows how an art object (or any kind of object) emerges, but it also shows that any kind of object is an emergence. And that emergence is not like a floating signifier that will then finally attach itself to something; it just is. This is not the 'is' of the Enlightenment, which was understood as attached to a signifying system of some sort and, for that reason, subject to the hierarchical order of original and copy. Rather, this 'is' is simultaneously the difference between signifiers and the repetition of that difference.

3. Emergence

Because the photograph can be interpreted through an idealist framework as an extension of Plato's cave into the modern age or as the visual counterpart to Hegelian dialectics, it tends to be understood through the lens of enlightenment philosophy. The main point of this book is that it does not have to be so. Because we keep looking at the photograph as a representation, we keep understanding it through a static framework of identity and subjectivity. But in so doing, we take up the photograph as a signifier, as a fixed symbolic entity. If we proceed in this way, we ignore the dynamism and the emergence that are inherent in the photograph. So far, the photograph has been understood as a symbolic thing that stood up for something, firmly lodged within the enlightenment paradigm of representation. But this prevents us from considering the photograph not as a message or information but as the manifestation of emergence. Whatever it is the emergence of, before there can be an image of any kind, there has to be a point of view for which this entity is given as an image. Representation, therefore, is not a mechanical re-inscription of something already there but the emergence of a point of view for which this 'something' is given as an image. The point of view can be of a human or a non-human origin, what matters is that there is a potential for an image that is being realised through self-organisation of a biological organism or another system of organisation such as an algorithm. This point of view is not prior to the representation, rather it is engendered by it, by the very laws of representation. The act of representation is an event that is happening through a network of shared coordinates, through an implicit acceptance that there is a shared reality that is making a representation possible. But at the same time, as this shared reality is being established, it is also shattered by the act of representation that announces its independence from it. Rather than being a paragon of truth, as enlightenment thinking wants to believe, photography shows representation for what it is: a paradox that simultaneously belongs to the world and tears itself away from it.

While the signifying side of the photograph is standing for something that has happened in the past, the emergent side is standing in for the present; the 'now' of the technological age. In other words, the photograph names the emergence of an assemblage that is recognisable not because it is standing in for the present but because it is the present. The photograph is not a representation but an alive version of this emergent reality. This is a vastly different move to the move initiated by enlightenment thinking. This book will show that photography is not an archive or a remembrance of things past, but the alive version of the emergent reality of the technological age. Not a recording of something that already exists but something that is produced through the act of recording.

When photography is understood through the enlightenment paradigm, it is denied its realness; it is always considered as a copy of something, and in becoming a copy, photography loses its own actuality, its own acuteness, as it is not a real thing, it is always a copy of itself. But then again, this is all part of the enlightenment argument of what it means to be human. And

the enlightenment answer to this question is that to be human is to make rational representations of the world in such a way as to increase the amount of verifiable and quantifiable knowledge. According to the enlightenment model, the human is to be found in the documentation, in the archive, in the museum – those institutions that collect, catalogue and preserve knowledge. But the age of information, of machine learning and of artificial intelligence makes these kinds of questions appear quaint if not outright redundant because now the question is not where the human is to be found, but what are the conditions under which the human is emerging. Photography is the embodiment of the encounter. It allows one to have a different form of an encounter with the encounter itself. Photography names this emergence of the age of technology, and it names it as something that is both tangible and immaterial simultaneously.

4. From picturing reality to inventing the everyday

Age of technology here means that *technē* become the primary organisational feature of society, which is not to say that advances in technology such as the radio, the photograph, the atomic bomb, computers, and so on, do not have meaning or do not have an impact, it is to say that what that does is that *technē* is the foremost organisational principle of society. What this means is that everything that is ‘out there’ is being grabbed and brought towards us. As this book will show, photography names this ‘grab’; it names the emergence of a kind of reality in which the real is that which is being grabbed as a photograph.

What makes the photograph so fascinating is that it is the expression of the logic of the *technē*, and therefore, as *technē*, it could be theoretically anywhere on the timescale of history, but at the same time, it is really quite specific to the advanced technology of the nineteenth century forward. So, what is interesting about photography is not that it can make accurate and precise representations, and not that it is good at documenting. No, what is interesting about photography is that not only can it do all those things as a technological advance and an invention, but it does so by reclaiming the importance of an encounter and emergence. The reason this is interesting is because photography is making graspable in all the senses of the term that which is making meaning possible. As technology, photography was always the sensible sibling of the arts, the one that is making sense, doing useful work by way of recording, collecting, disseminating and archiving. The argument that is put forward in this book is that photography is not only making sense, but it is also sense in the making; it is how sense is coming to be, how sensing is emerging out of the technological grasping of the world.

The enduring challenge of photography is that it can and does create an image that one can see and that looks like something and therefore can be seen as standing in for it. The problem is that in a certain sense, photography is the victim of its own success, as much as it allows for this different type of entity to emerge that no longer has to have the shackles of either the subject or objectivity and yet, this entity is obscured by the visual surface that always resembles something and triggers the representational reflex. That is, in a nutshell, the photographic paradox.

Photography can perform this leap out of Enlightenment thinking into the non-binary realm of emergence because it is the expression of a different form of intelligence, one that provisionally can be called artificial. This expression is not conceptual; it is not being signified by the photograph, rather it is being expressed in a way that can be not only visually ‘seen’, as in seeing a photograph, but it can also be repeated as code. The introduction of difference to photography makes it clear how photography can act not only as an archivist’s tool, but fundamentally also can (and does) create the very reality it is ‘picturing’. In this sense, not only does contemporary photography invent the everyday at every moment of the day, but it also invents philosophy itself, neatly imaged away from its western metaphysical roots.

Introduction

I. Transition to after-photography

This book takes issue with the long tradition that considers the mechanical image as an imprint of a pre-existing reality. Even before the invention of photography many thought that the *camera obscura* produces an exact and automatic copy of the real. It is evident for instance in the notes for the *Confessions* by Jean Jacques Rousseau: ‘It is a question of my portrait and not of a book. I am going to work, so to speak, in a *camera obscura*, and will need no other art but that of exactly tracing what I see’ (quoted in Strong 2002, p. 16).

In contrast to the theoretical investigations that consider photography to be ‘a type of icon or a form of visual likeness, which bear an indexical relationship to its object’ (Krauss 1985, p. 203), this book will propose that photography is not only a description of an object, but is itself an object which, as the product of specific technological processes, erases and creates subjectivity: It erases a static, anthropocentric subjectivity and replaces it with multiple and divergent notion of the subject which emerges not out of repetition, and copying but out of difference.

Difference here means nothing more to begin with than that there is always an excess to the visual which is expressive, singular, dynamic, and non-identical. This excess cannot be accounted for from within those theories that begin from taking as a given that photographs are representational images and proceed by situating them within linear space and chronological time. For this reason, one of the central arguments of this book is that there is an excess to photography that transcends and exceeds visibility and representation. On the pages of this book photography is put forward not as a regime of representation, but as the specific interlacing of technology of repetition and visibility which produces an image of difference that is central to an ontological account of the way thought is embodied in an image.

Underpinning this expansion of conventional photography into a photo-philosophy open to the multitude of forms that visibility assumes in the contemporary world is the conviction that images not only stand for, but also actively reveal, bring forth and shape the world that we inhabit. These understandings evolved out of Heidegger’s (1977a, p.13) examination of technology as a ‘realm where revealing and unconcealment take place, where *alētheia*, truth happens’. This grasp of technology as a site where subjectivity is formed (and deformed) is indebted to Gilles Deleuze’s (1992, 1989) books on cinema and to Giorgio Agamben’s observation that it is not I, the subject, who is using technology, rather it is technology that is producing me as a subject.

Here lies the vanity of the well-meaning discourse on technology, which asserts that the problem with apparatuses can be reduced to the question of their correct use. Those who

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make such claims seem to ignore a simple fact: if a certain process of subjectification [...] corresponds to every apparatus, then it is impossible for the subject of an apparatus to use it ‘in the right way’.

(Agamben 2009, p. 21)

Thinking outside representation

As Barbara Bolt (2000) put it, ‘In western philosophy and western art, it is very difficult to think outside the paradigm of representation and posit a non-representational principle’. There are two sides to this difficulty: the first is that there is a whole foundational myth of philosophy that is taking its bearings from the idea that light and light-writing are privileged conduits of truth and knowledge. The origin of this legend is located in the biblical ‘let there be light’ (Gen. 1:3) and in the Allegory of the Cave (Plato 1997a, pp. 514a–520a), and it is manifested most fully in the ocular-centric cultures and the spectatorial gaze of the Enlightenment (Jay 2004). And even though the perspectival view of the world we have inherited from the Renaissance is being replaced by the flat topology of the computer screen, we are carrying the baggage of this photo-logo-centric tradition to this day, as indicated by *theory* being derived from the Greek *theōros* ‘spectator’. What this means is that a serious engagement with photo-graphy (literally: light-writing) is not possible without a radical critique of theory that locates the practices of knowledge in spectatorship and looks to light as the source of ultimate truth.

Theory that is born out of an image created by light, whether it is a shadow in a cave, a silhouette on a wall (as in the story of Butades told by Pliny), or a reflection in a lake (as in the myth of Narcissus) cannot hope to produce a thorough examination of photography because the critical tools at its disposal are permeated with the metaphysical notion that light is a source of reason and knowledge. Reflecting on this problem, Heidegger laments that ‘the ordinary intellect fails to see the world for all the entities’ (Käufel 2005, p. 484). Transposed to the sphere of visual culture, Heidegger’s insight suggests that the error of Western metaphysical tradition is its excessive focus on the visible at the expense of that which makes the visible possible. Photography theory that does not examine its own metaphysical presuppositions commits a similar error by failing to look beyond the surface of the photographs into the flows, processes, mutations and bifurcations that operate outside the visual field. What is left out by systems that turn to light as their source of truth is all the dark, messy, carnal and sensual experience that is not making any universal and absolute claims but is never-the-less capable of producing forms of knowledge that sit outside of logical and rational frameworks.

This leads to the second side of the problem: most standard theories of photography consider it as a form of visual communication: a memory prosthetic, an archive, or a document, and due to this excessive focus on the visual they do not notice that the image is invested in a complex relationship with the real world through processes of technological production, dissemination, and storage. In the age of New Media technologies do not only organise and present information, they also organise and structure experience (Elo and Miika 2014, p. 7). In the twenty-first century, ‘things that go bump in the dark’ are the physical embodiments of processes that fuse human perception with computer networks, apps and smartphones. Photo-graphic images are the products of multi-disciplinary technological procedures, and the systemic cohesion of technology with desire, the way it comes to be legible and to make sense, is what we came to call *photography*.

Stated succinctly, philosophical thought and photography are both invested in light as a form of intelligence. The problem is how to understand photography not as a collection of light-

drawings but as an image of thought that works in a specific way that is inseparable from the way technology produces, recycles and re-writes images. The image of thought that is being put forward by photography is not specifically about visual communication, nor is it about representation as such and it is certainly not about making pretty or shocking pictures, and it is also not about the history of photography, and yet, this image of thought pinches something from all these categories. Because in the end of the day, some images move us while some others do not. The reason it is so is because ‘photography’ names not another form of visual representation, rather, photography is the visual figuration of a new layer of consciousness – in which new relationship to space and time, and therefore new categories of thought, play, art, and agency are emerging.

II. Deconstructing the index

This book takes issue with the conjecture that considers photographs to be indexical traces. The concept of the index is drawing on the writings of C.S. Peirce. In view of the fact that the index became fundamental to a certain way to theorising photography, it is important to notice Peirce’s own words:

Photographs, especially instantaneous photographs, are very instructive, because we know that they are in certain respects exactly like the objects they represent. But this resemblance is due to the photographs having been produced under such circumstances that they were physically forced to correspond point by point to nature. In that aspect, then, they belong to the second class of signs [indices], those by physical connection.

(Peirce 1955, p. 106)

Following Peirce, Rosalind Krauss claims the index as central to photography:

Every photograph is the result of a physical imprint transferred by light reflections onto a sensitive surface. The photograph is thus a type of icon, or visual likeness, which bears an indexical relationship to its object. Its separation from true icons is felt through the absoluteness of this physical genesis, one that seem to short-circuit or disallow those processes of schematization of symbolic intervention that operate within the graphic representations of most paintings.

(Krauss 1985, p. 203)

A similar claim is put forward by Roland Barthes in his definition of photography as ‘That-has-been’ which is based on a related assertion: ‘The photograph is literally an emanation of the referent. From a real body, which was there, proceed radiations which ultimately touch me, who am here [...]’ (Barthes 1981, p. 80). One of the difficulties with Krauss’ argument is that ‘the physical imprint transferred by light’ is totally unknowable, for prior to its chemical development, the image produced by light is contained within the sealed film canister and therefore unavailable for examination. The image can only become visible through later development and a rigorous adherence to a protocol of prescribed operations needed to produce the ‘physical imprint’. In this sense, the photographic image was always algorithmic; subject to a series of processes performed within the ‘black box’ of the darkroom.

Even the smallest error by the laboratory technician – in the constitution of chemical solutions for instance, or in the temperature of the developer – will result in something that has no ‘visual likeness’. In this context it is instructive to note that in the opening pages of *Camera Lucida*, Barthes declares that his project of discovering the ‘genius’ of photography does not

4 Introduction

include an examination of the photographic process: ‘One of these practices was barred to me and I was not to investigate it: I am not a photographer, not even an amateur photographer: too impatient for that: I must see right away what I have produced [...]’ (Barthes 1981, p. 3). For this reason, Barthes’ analysis of photography in *Camera Lucida* is focused on connoisseurship, as it proceeds only from the perspective of the viewer of photographs. Barthes’ refusal to consider the conditions of production of the photograph allows him to assume an uninterrupted transition of light from ‘a real body’: ‘a sort of umbilical cord links the body of the photographed thing to my gaze’ (1981, p. 81). What is being excluded from Barthes’ analysis is precisely the conditions, operations and processes required to produce the image. For this reason, Barthes is unable to consider the photograph as a manufactured commodity and so he is impervious to questions of process, reproduction, multiplication and duplication. Barthes’ most famous statement about photography, ‘message without a code’ is perhaps the clearest sign of his refusal to acknowledge the materiality of the photographic process (1977, p. 17).

It is due to the evacuation of the question of production from photography that Barthes and Krauss (among many others) see photography as transcendent and photographs as images of external things. Because Barthes and Krauss focus their attentions on the image rather than on the process involved in its production, they consider photography purely in terms of content, focusing on the subjective experience of the image as meaningful and symbolic. Against such understandings this book argues that photography must be considered as a process of production because the technological process that brings photography into being puts forward questions of mechanical repetition and difference between copies. Only as a process of reproduction, copying, dissemination and distribution can photography be considered as an ontology of production. (Nishida 2012).

Two dimensions of mechanical reproduction

As a remedy to the indexical interpretations of photography, this book proposes to take seriously Walter Benjamin’s pronouncements around the mechanical reproduction of art (Benjamin 2008). When the emphasis shifts from signification to reproduction, what comes into focus is our very ability to understand the subjective moves within a philosophy of difference which, as it turns out, becomes the *sine qua non* of photography. The introduction of difference into photography allows us to view it not as the sensible sibling of art, or something that is simply understood in relation to its own technology, but as the visual expression of a post-philosophical situation in which mechanical reproduction approximates thinking and logic.

Mechanical reproduction should not be understood as a simple duplication that produces identical results, but as a creative force capable of creating difference through repetition. The quality that makes photography highly conducive for a discourse on difference is its ability to repeat through mechanical means that which happened only once. Following Deleuze’s (2004) understanding of repetition as the productive force of difference, photographic reproduction does not need to be grasped in terms of producing identical copies. Like the Difference Engine designed by Charles Babbage in 1822, photography is using the repetition function $n + 1$ not in order to copy n but to produce a new value. Each photographic reproduction creates a new result, setting up difference, rather than identity, as the fundamental principle of reproduction.

To explain this point further, it is important to underscore that photographic reproduction has two dimensions to it: there is the replication of a situation that photography repeats by making it into an image and there is the repetition inherent in the photographic process itself which allows the photograph to be endlessly proliferated through duplication and dissemination. In this context especially remarkable is Deleuze’s distinction between two regimes of the

cinematic image: an organic regime and a crystalline regime. One of the key differences between the two is that with the organic regime ‘the real that is assumed is recognizable by its continuity’ while in the crystalline regime ‘the virtual [...] detaches itself from its actualisations, starts to be valid for itself’ (Deleuze 1989, pp. 126–127). While the former expresses that which already happened, the latter is an expression of the ability of the image to disrupt linearity through serial replication and of its power to throw into confusion notions of identity and coherence by generating difference through repetition. The ability of photography to create images of *objects* could be seen as related to the linearity of chronological time and to the rationality of representation, but its ability to reproduce *itself* through dissemination implies a possibility of time that is not restricted to a linear progression from the past to the future but is a kind of becoming in which repetition takes the place of linear chronology. What photography endlessly repeats is the power of difference. These two modes of reproduction define what will be called here the ‘double articulation’ of photography. This double action, towards the world on the one hand and towards its own mode of production on the other allows conceiving of photography not as a form of representation of some immutable and pre-determined origin, but as a recurring process of transformation in which the very force of reproduction is being imaged. To look at life photographically does not mean to see it as a collection of decisive moments frozen and framed as black and white or colour snapshots, it means to see the process of repetition as a perpetual becoming through reproduction. This allows to think of photography not as an image but as an event of becoming through reproduction.

The non-identical image

Theory that takes as its starting point the assumption that the image is there to be looked at falls at once under the auspice of the western eye. The problem is that whenever the eye is evoked as the means of comprehension, the image becomes managed by vision and ceases to exist outside the visible spectrum, and it becomes impossible to apprehend the image as anything other than a legible sign. As Barbara Bolt (2000) explains, a number of contemporary philosophers took issue with the way light and vision are being considered within the Western philosophical cannon, most notably Merleau-Ponty, Levinas and Irigaray. Bolt draws on her own experience of painting in the Australian desert to suggest that light and vision are historically determined and form the basis of subjectivity within the western philosophical canon. Within this tradition representation is understood as the transformation of matter into something that can be calculated and grasped in a rational manner. Bolt mentions two strategies to overcome the representational paradigm, the first, drawn from the work of Irigaray, is taking account of sexual difference to propose that it is difference, rather than identity that forms the foundation of vision. The second strategy is drawing on Deleuze, and Deleuze and Guattari’s concepts of faciality (*visagéité*) and deterritorialisation. These strategies make it possible to think of the photograph not in terms of the hierarchical relationship with a point of origin in the real world, but as a form of ‘play’ with no original, that is characterised by the undecidability of the image.

The performative element of photography is in the dual trajectories of the undecidability of the image on the one hand and repetition (and difference) on the other. It is further significant that Bolt says that in the desert ‘One always kept one’s eyes to the ground in order to be sensitive to and aware of the folds, the contours, the inclines, and the mess of the landscape’ (Bolt 2000, p. 208), this suggests that vision ceases to be connected with the consumption of the horizon line, with the surveillance of the territory and with the translation of the idea of a landscape into legible form, rather, vision becomes connected with a different way of mapping the world through ‘attention to the patterns and rhythms of the ground’ (ibid).

The point about rhythms and patterns is important because it allows one to glimpse the way meanings emerge not only out of significations, representations and totalizing systems of signs but from the effects of repetition and from the properties of marks, impressions and imprints that bodies make when they come in contact with other bodies. When repetition, reproduction and dissemination are examined as fundamental properties of the photograph, differences between copies acquire primacy over identity and representation. Repetition is intrinsic to the mechanically produced image, but it is not a symbol or a sign, it is an effect of force, a mark left by impact. By drawing attention to repetition and dissemination as the primary photographic operations, this book seeks to argue that there is no underlying identity which gives meaning to images as representations of objects, rather identity is a false effect of representation, and photographic repetition is a non-signifying mark that does not point to anything outside of itself. When the photographic image is considered from the perspective of repetition, and not of light and representation, its original form is not a legible mark, it is unknowable dark matter, the very image of otherness and inscrutability. It is nevertheless a mark that is expressive of the dimension of sense because it is made when one body makes an impression on another body (Khalip and Mitchell 2011).

It is only when identity becomes the foundational worldview and the basic ideological presumption of aesthetics that photographs acquire the status of representation as signifying surfaces and as signs that stand in for the absent presence of an object or a thing.

Contesting the representational model

As Cathryn Vasseleu suggests, western metaphysical tradition is grounded in representation as the model of knowledge (Vasseleu 1998, p. 12). It posits a human subject as an observer who surveys the world, understands it with the power of the intellect and finally inscribes it in images. Photography is used by this conceptual model as a visual manifestation of the universal power of the principle of identity. According to this logic, images are in some ways identical to the objects they stand for. For instance, a photograph of a house suggests that a house is of a certain shape and colour. It further suggests that there is a temporal relation between the photograph and the house that places both within a single timeframe with the image referring to a point in the past, archiving it for the present. The photograph and the house are bound together by the logic of representation that presupposes the existence of discrete beings that can be symbolised.

However, following recent research into the nature of light it is possible to contest the representational model outlined in the previous paragraph. First, as Vasseleu observes: '[t]he shift from emission and corpuscular optics to the wave theory of light. [...] The most significant changes claimed for the wave theory of light are, first, that linear perspectival modes of representation no longer have a basis in optical verisimilitude and, second, the "action at a distance" world view is drastically altered.' This suggests that 'light loses its ontological privilege' which allows one to contest the logic of representation (Vasseleu 1998, p. 42).

Second, it is possible to employ photography in another way, by emphasizing its potential for creating difference through reproduction, so that each image becomes a collection of non-representational singularities that are sustained not by the way they reflect an ideal original but by the way they are different in every instance. In 'Immanence: A life' Deleuze uses the following example to explain how singularity precedes individualisation: '[V]ery small children all resemble one another and have hardly any individuality, but they have singularities: a smile, a gesture, a funny face – not subjective qualities' (Deleuze 2005a, p. 30). Deleuze here points to a pre-individual state of being that is not determined by memory and personal identity. The thing that sets one child apart from another can be usefully compared to the 'noise' that can help

distinguish one iteration of an image from another. No two copies are identical, every image contains singularities that make it different. To copy is to produce difference.

Instead of considering photography as the power to represent objects, Deleuze's model allows to conceive of the (virtual) potential to move from surface to surface. For example, when one is looking for a certain image through an image search engine (for instance by searching for 'Mona Lisa'), one is faced with a screen-full of images, but these are not reproductions of an original; each image is a variation that does not emerge from a single point of origin. In a direct and unambiguous way what one is facing is the power to differ. Like Deleuze's small children, the iterations of the Mona Lisa are not copies from an original. The singularity of the image is not due to the way it is reproducing something that is pre-existing, but due to the elements of each image being arranged in a way that is different from all other images.

Viewed through an image search algorithm, photography is not a mode of representation but an expression of the possibility of variation and difference that happens through repetition. In the example of the online image search, photography communicates not only through semiotic signs and signification but also through the rhythm, the stammering and the silences of repetition (Lingis 2000). The difference that arose out of repetition in the image search is the result of an interaction between images that does not depend on any underlying representation or 'ground'. Yet it is not 'nothing', it is not meaningless, but it suggests a kind of vision that is free from the ocular-centric Cartesian perspective. This multiplicity of repetitions suggests not a hierarchy of representations – with some closer to the original than the others – rather, it suggests that there are only repetitions without ground and without foundation (Deleuze 1990, p. 403). As the product of mechanical reproduction, photography is considered here as a process of differentiation which creates a visible image of that which otherwise can be only sensed.

The blindness of theory

In order to be able to criticise representation, we must conceive of it as a conceptual totality rather than a collection of disconnected facts of perception. In other words, we must learn to see representation as a particularly pervasive and persuasive form of ideology. The existence of this ideology is not immediately apparent, and indeed, following Adorno, it can be argued that there are political investments in making sure that representation remains invisible (O'Connor 2012, pp. 27–8). It is precisely because the totality of representation is concealed that we tend to look at photography as a mediation of an objectively given reality, which delivers an accurate likeness. For photographs to acquire their status as precise and fateful impressions, representation has to make itself invisible and recede from view. Conversely, for representation to cease being imperceptible and to come into view, requires reconsidering photographs not as precise and fateful impressions but as sites of social interaction in which representation is making itself visible in the form of an image. The ideological deceit of representation is to insist that there is a world 'out there' that is waiting to be recorded in an image. It is precisely this suggestion, that there is an organic and natural real that exists independently of us and of our agency, that constitutes the essence of the representational swindle.

How can we accommodate the possibility that 'seeing' relates not only to the image but also to something ungraspable, invisible, and yet strangely present? Theory of photography that assumes that everyone knows what it means to look at a photograph, that everyone knows what it means to see cannot account for something that is invisible. Yet, it is possible to argue, as Bolt (2000) and Vasseleu (1998) have done, that the apparent immediacy of vision is an ideological construction that obscures its historical underpinnings. The story of this deception begins with Plato's argument that light and vision are the primary instruments of reason,

knowledge and truth. It is difficult, if not impossible, to question the centrality of light from within a theoretical discourse that is making light its founding principle. The blind trust we place in the visible overwhelms theory to such an extent that the visible becomes the only determining factor in a photograph.

Whether considered as a fateful representation or an illusionistic spectacle, the underpinning assumption is that the photographic image is a representation of an external reality. As Judovitz explains, since Descartes' visuality operates as guarantor of knowledge and rationality and to the extent that this model still underwrites the position of theory towards the photographic image it is bound to fit with the conceptual model that posits the subject as defined by rational visuality (Judovitz 1988a). The emphasis on the visuality of photography, on its legibility, transparency and clarity causes the evacuation from the discourse of all references to the image as something that happens besides and outside visibility. But, as Adorno points out, the demand for clarity is symptomatic of positivist thinking that is unable to account for change and it therefore politically reactionary:

Clarity can be demanded of all knowledge only when it has been determined that the objects under investigation are free of all dynamic qualities that would cause them to elude the gaze that tries to capture and hold them unambiguously.

(Adorno 1993, p. 98)

Because theory of photography seeks to address its subject as the visible, as that which is brought to the eye, as that which is legible and has a meaning, by dint of the same logic it is also bound to obscure precisely that which is invisible, a-rational, illegible and belonging to sense rather than to logos. In other words, when theory looks at photography it sees only its own reflection because the photograph appears to be doing the same thing that theory does: taking something from outside of itself and presenting it as logically organised information.

Barthes famously rejected the iconicity of photography as its ontological basis by saying that even if the photograph does not resemble the thing it depicts, there is still the certainty that the thing was in front of the camera at some point in the past (Barthes 1981, pp. 4–7). In summarising Barthes' position, Batchen has this to say: 'What makes photographs distinctive is that they depend on this original presence, a referent in the material world that *at some time* really did exist to imprint itself on a sheet of light-sensitive paper' (Batchen 1999, pp. 212–3, my emphasis).

A photograph therefore is not only an image of the referent but also of time as such, as it carries with it the 'original presence' of something that took place in the past. However, by focusing on the referent and on its relationship to the past Batchen overlooks the small matter of the presence of photographs themselves, not so much as physical objects of paper, glass, etc. but the presence of the process that produces the photograph. Unlike most other mass-produced objects, photographs do not conceal the bio-techno-political mode of production that brought them into being, they make this process into an image and hide it in plain view.

According to Karl Marx, in a capitalist system the unrepresentable is defined as the mode of production:

Let us therefore [...] leave this noisy sphere, where everything takes place on the surface and in full view of everyone and follow into the hidden abode of production on whose threshold hangs the notice 'No admittance except on business'. Here we shall see, not only how capital produces, but how capital itself is produced. The secret of profit making must at last be laid bare.

(Marx 1990, pp. 279–80)

The visible aspect of capitalism is the free exchange of commodities and services, this aspect is taking place in the broad light of day and is available for everyone's scrutiny. On the other hand, the sphere of production is inaccessible to the eye, veiled in secrecy, hidden from view. Marx is making the point that the truth about capital cannot be discovered by observation of its surface effects. It is easy to draw a parallel with photography: Capital cannot fail but produce profit and photography cannot fail but produce an image. The production of the profit/image is however hidden from view, yet it is not located elsewhere, but is to be found within the sphere of profit/image by focusing on its invisible aspects.

Ill will as method

Care must be taken not to fall prey to the temptation of stepping out of semiology and structuralism and of seeking the materiality of photography outside of the image. Photographs are images, they cannot be anything else (but these images do not have to be visual). Any attempt to leave the image behind and to focus, for instance, on the materiality of photographs as objects, is bound to invite back the structuralist and the semiologist who will now claim that by trying to escape signification all that was achieved is that a new signifying regime was being set up. The methodology of this book is taking its bearings from Lyotard's insistence that intensities, the libidinal band and productive tension are to be found not outside the sign but within it:

Are we talking about another sort of sign? Not in the slightest, *they are the same* as those with which the semiotician carries out his theory and textual practice. The first thing to avoid, comrades, is to claim that we have taken up a position somewhere else. We're not moving out of anywhere, we're staying right here, we occupy the terrain of signs [...].

(Lyotard 2004, p. 49)

The stubborn refusal to evacuate the domain of the sign is key to the political agency of Lyotard's project as it is the linguistic / semiotic sign which is the site of his argument for non-dialectical materialism. Something of this stubbornness can be discerned in Deleuze's insistence that the representational image of thought can be questioned only by 'an individual full of ill will who does not manage to think either naturally or conceptually' (Deleuze 2004, p. 166). This calls to mind the unnamed narrator of Fyodor Dostoevsky's novel *Notes from the Underground*, who proclaims 'What have the laws of nature and arithmetic to do with me, when for some reason I don't like those laws ...?' (Dostoevsky 2011, p. 37). For Dostoevsky, as for Deleuze getting to the other side of reason and rationality cannot be achieved by rational means. Rationality requires one to surrender to it as the iron law of nature, not permitting the possibility of another reality. To get beyond the brick wall of reason one must equip oneself not with more rationality but with energy of a different kind. Dostoevsky's protagonist says:

I refuse treatment out of spite ... I know better than anybody that I am harming nobody but myself. All the same, if I don't have treatment, it is out of spite. Is my liver out of order – let it get worse!

(Dostoevsky 2011, p. 24)

Ill will is needed to exorcise representation not because ill will is negative but because it is a humour, an affectation. Ill will is not the opposition of representation, it is what happens to representation when it gets in the hands of the alien, the misfit, the nomad. Deleuze emphasizes

ill will rather than non-representational theory because he is concerned not to fall back into representation by way of its negation.

In the context of photography, certain amount of ill will is needed to turn the gaze away from the visible without however negating the image. To think about photographs non-dialectically does not mean to renounce the image in favour of the ‘objecthood’ of photographs (Edwards and Hart 2004), nor does it mean to suggest that the image acquires meaning only within disciplinary or institutional frameworks (Bolton 1992, Tagg 2009). Rather, as this book will go on to suggest, it is important to recognise that both the ‘objecthood’ of photographs and their disciplinary functions are drawn out of a position that privileges the clarity and intelligibility of the image. What theories of photography tend to forget is that visibility and clarity are offshoots of a conceptual framework that is centred on the human subject and is anchored in a subject/object binary. The observation that animates this book is that alongside lucidity and transparency photography is also inarticulate, affective, non-signifying, a-radical and yet, it is precisely these non-hierarchical qualities of the image that give it force, singularity and tension. For this reason, it draws extensively on the work of those philosophers who seek to go beyond signification in their attempt to find the origin of visibility (and of thought) in the non-visible affect-phrase.

As Anne Tomiche saw, in *Discourse, Figure* Lyotard locates a phenomenological link within designation: ‘There is therefore an “eye” within discourse. Discourse is thus both surrounded and undercut by the figural [...] Topographically, the relation of simultaneous exteriority and interiority of the figural to discourse is thus not dialectical’ (Tomiche 2002, p. 9). As Tomiche goes on to point out, Lyotard’s strategy in exposing the phenomenological foundation of language is by way of showing that the distance between sign and referent should not be thought of as negation but as a form of expression. Instead of the dialectical relation between the image and the object, Lyotard proposes radical heterogeneity which he names ‘thickness’.

III. Technology, previously known as life

As a privileged object of critical research, photography is the subject of a number of studies concerned with the ways by which identity, subjectivity, gender, society, art and the real are constructed through a photographic system of representation. This book suggests that such approaches have one thing in common: they consider photography as a rational invention in the service of men, they discuss it from the position of separation between the image and the object, a separation that is bridged by representation and by the representing subject. The result of this anthropocentric position is that they take as a given the observation that photography is a technology that produces an image and that the image is one of resemblance. One of the clearest expressions of this view comes from André Bazin:

Only a photographic lens can give us the kind of image of the object that is capable of satisfying the deep need man has to substitute for it something more than a mere approximation... The photographic image is the object itself, the object freed from the conditions of time and space that govern it.

(Bazin 2004, p. 14)

For Bazin, technology is there to satisfy the ‘deep need’ of men, it is a means to an end: everybody knows how photographs are made, everyone knows what it means to be photographed and how to take a photograph. What everyone knows is known as common sense. To have a relationship with photography that is free and unrestricted by such doxa it is necessary to

depart from the common-sense approach to technology and establish a relationship with it that is extraordinary.

This is the path that Heidegger outlined in the two essays *The Question Concerning Technology* and *The Age of the World Picture*. In these works, Heidegger shows that technology is not an instrument or an object of use, it is not made by humans and for humans, it is the way by which the human subject is constituted through the process of making. The rejection of the instrumental definition of technology allows Heidegger to claim that subjectivity, rather than being a fixed and stable entity, is formed through the process of creation, which for the human being always takes the form of *techne*:

Technology is therefore no mere means. Technology is a way of revealing. If we give heed to this, then another whole realm for the essence of technology will open itself up to us. It is the realm of revealing, i.e., of truth.

(Heidegger 1977a, p. 112)

However, Heidegger adds a caveat to indicate that it is only in the modern age that technology becomes so aligned with representation that it turns the human into a resource, a standing reserve, and a subject. Heidegger argues that the modern age is characterised by the interweaving of two events: the world becomes a picture and the human being becomes a subject (Helfer 1996).

According to Heidegger, the human being acquires a sense subjectivity and identity through the process of acting in the world. The self is formed in and through technology because human acting and doing is the process of *techne*. For Heidegger, a person is *Da-sein* (being-there). A person is not a thing or a substance, human existence comes into being in the performance of intentional acts. To be human therefore is to perform intentional acts, and it is only in the performance of such acts that humanity is actualised (Heidegger 1962, p. 73).

Therefore, Heidegger says that it is wrong to assume that one is using technology to achieve certain goals, rather, one *becomes* through technology, and it is this becoming that constitutes what we latter name 'identity', 'ego', 'subjectivity' or 'sovereignty'.

In *The Question Concerning Technology* Heidegger performs a de-reification of the concept of representation. He proposes a path to the unthought, to that which is yet to be thought: that representation is culturally and historically specific to the Western tradition. He achieves this by connecting representation to the notion of the rational subject. Rationality and representation are thus shown to be drawn out of the same historical trajectory. In this way representation comes to define the way by which the world is given to the rational subject. Technology for Heidegger comes to mean the basic modality according to which the experience of the world is formed. This is because no matter what one does, one is always *already in* technology. There is no opting out. This also means that the familiar notion of technology as means to an end does not hold. But in addition, it means that technology cannot be grasped as an object because technology is the grasping mechanism. What makes technology so elusive is that it is the surface of everything else that is taking place. It is the framework, the diagram, the armature through which experience acquires coherence. Technology does not like to show itself as the grasping mechanism. It stays invisible, working behind the scenes, and we are becoming aware of it only when it stops working. For that reason Heidegger says that the river Rhine still looks like a river and not like the energy resource that is now become (Heidegger 1977a, p. 116). The power-plant on the banks of the river is a monument to technology but it appears to the eye as an isolated object, separate from the landscape. Yet, for Heidegger, the Hydro-electric plant on the bank of the Rhine changes the essence of the river, bringing it over to production, manufacturing, and the storage of energy. Unlike the power-plant in Heidegger's famous example,

photography has the advantage that here the landscape cannot be separated from technology, because in the photograph technology of production is inseparable from the technology of representation. Photography grasps what is ungraspable and produces it in the form of an image.

Two sides of the image

That photographic images are serial, i.e., each ‘individual’ image is part of a series, is hardly an original statement. And yet, it is surprising how little attention is devoted to precisely this aspect of photography. Everywhere we look we see photographs, millions of them, yet ordinarily it is the singular image that appears to us and the fact that this image is part of a series is habitually overlooked. Overlooked is the operative word here, for the seriality of the image is not something that can be visually grasped. Seriality is not visual, it cannot be shown, brought to the eye, figured. It is dynamic, singular, and non-identical. The *technē* of photography is both a *technē* of the exact copy and of seriality and the two cannot be separated or disentangled. And while the former is manifest in the photograph being an image of a thing, and for that reason also static, the latter is manifest in the photograph being a recursive fragment, an instance in a chain of successive executions. As will be discussed later in this book, this doubling up is on the one hand the technological condition that makes the photographic image possible and on the other it opens up a rupture within the photograph. For while it is true that the serial aspect of photography is invisible because it is not part of the image, it is also true that in some way it is inseparable from the image as it speaks to the mode of production of photography.

A brief analogy might help to clarify the last point and to explain why seriality is central to photography. If we take written text as an example, whether it is a parking ticket or a poem there is a clear sense that the text is both content and expression. It speaks to us with an intonation that implies the (deferred) presence of a voice. Even if the text is anonymous, unsigned, manifestly impersonal, exaggeratedly plane, still someone’s voice can be discerned in the choice of phrases. As Derrida has shown, the authorial voice is the voice of authority that we can never fail to hear (Derrida 1988, pp. 1–24). Even if the voice is not of an individual but of an institution as in the case of a tax bill for instance, the text announces not only its meaning but also the correspondents, their epoch, social status, intentions, aptitudes, proclivities (Barthes 1977). It is impossible to subtract or eliminate the voice from the text, for the text is not just words taken from a dictionary, but also the way these words are put together, the way they are arranged in one way and not in another. In reading the text we not only assign meaning to every word but also absorb the choices made by the absent author of the text. These choices, which are manifest at every sentence, give the text its timbre, its colouration for through them we create in our mind the figure of the speaker, their intention, their seriousness or their maliciousness, their explicit and implicit intent. However, it is precisely this presence of the speaker in the text that cannot be extracted from the text because formally it is nowhere. The text is words on paper. Intonation is in the way the words are arranged (like music is arranged) but it is not the words. To demand to see the intonation of the text without the words, is absurd and yet, it is the intonation that gives the words the possibility of meaning (Voloshinov 1983).

In parallel to language there is an aspect of the photographic image that gives it its meaning and yet this aspect cannot be made visible. However, this aspect is not the authorial voice in the sense of the artist or the photographer who ‘made’ the picture, but in the sense of the *technē* that made the image. And *technē* is manifest in photography in the seriality of the image. Each photographic image, even when considered in complete isolation from any other images, still carries within it its seriality. It is imbued with it because it is permeated with the technology of

mechanical reproduction. For instance, Henri Cartier-Bresson's photograph of three women in Alicante (1932) is no doubt saturated with HCB's readily recognizable intonation, with the mannerism evident in his 'hyper-geometric' style and with the precise timing of the exposure. Considered as a representation, this image is a symbol of time and space which confirms to our own experience of time as continuous and linear. Yet at the same time this image is infused with fragmentary repetition that is un-rooted, a-hierarchical, and non-representational. As part of a series, this image is simultaneously co-present in various locations, circulating through data servers, appearing on computer monitors, in catalogues of auction houses, printed books, online shops, mobile devices and slideshows. This ongoing and infinite distribution creates an alternative dimension to the image that speaks not to its ability to stand for reality external to it, but to its ability for autopoietic regeneration. Between the two determinations of the photograph, the representation and the fragment, there is a rift, a fissure that keep both sides incomplete, contingent, mutually unresolved. In the first instance we have an image which fits with our understanding of life as linear and basically unchanging. This understanding is reinforced through linear perspective and monocular point of view. In the second instance, there is a multiplicity of proliferating singularities, multiplicity of perspectives, infinitely bifurcating rhythm, and a conception of life as a differencing flow made out of unconnected fragments. Representation here does not describe a static figure but contours and maps a procedure, or a principle of becoming. Neither system is sufficient without the other for the fragment is embodied in the image and the image is mimetic only thanks to the repetition of the fragment. Photography is the site of conflation between two irreconcilable temporalities: transcendental and immanent. The frame of the photograph with its clear freeze-dry stillness is complicated or even ruptured by the invasion of the fluid space of repetition that disposes with a point of origin, with hierarchical understanding of time and with static, unchanging subjectivity. Deleuze speaks of the two sides of the cinematic image thus: 'The movement-image has two sides, one in relation to objects whose relative position varies, the other in relation to a whole – of which it expresses an absolute change' (Deleuze 1989, p. 34).

From the point of view of representation, the recursive fragment is 'nothing'. As representation is a logic (*logos*) that works through pursuing similarity and assigning identity it sees only identical copies. Because representation works dialectically it assigns identity to everything that it finds similar and non-identity to everything that is dissimilar. The thing that always escapes representation is that which is neither identity nor non-identity (Deleuze 2004, p. 375). What cannot be represented delineates and demarcates the systematic and orderly representational space, however, the demarcation itself cannot be represented, as it is – from the point of view of representation – nothing. From the point of view of the fragment on the other hand, the image is nothing but the potential to differ.

The reproductive process is what makes this image and any other photograph possible. And to the extent that this image announces itself as a photograph, it also announces itself as being a fragment, an object the meaning of which is incomplete because, as part of a series, it belongs to a larger whole and yet it is also a finite entity. Therefore photography is situated between two polarities, two articulations: there is the photographic image, a product of the technology of representation, and there is the photographic series made up of recursive fragments.

Dynamism, difference, chaos

As was suggested in the previous sections, photography transcends representation in favour of difference, fractality and recursive reiteration. However, this fragmentation of the photographic is not an aberration or accident, nor does it render the photographic image meaningless, but it

is an essential quality that defines the structure of the visual field as partaking in a form of logic that is non-linear, a-rational (chaotic), dynamic, sensual and rhizomatic. Photography is taken as a point of entry into the question of the way representation works because in photography representation is immanent to the process of image-making, which sets it apart from other forms of visibility – such as painting – where representation is the product of human agency. What manifests in photography, first of all, is the mechanical operation of reproduction which brings forward the unconscious power of repetition. Even if the photograph is non-legible the eye takes from it the recording of the process of recording itself. The delirium of production is the latent subject of every photograph. For as long as we look at the photograph to see its content, we miss the key message: that the image emerges through self-replication, infinitely repeating its own power to repeat. The original insight offered by photography is that it is a representation in which what is being represented is the *technē* of representation itself.

In other words, photography affords insights into representation precisely because no matter what its subject is, it also automatically produces a reflexive image of representation itself. As a form of imaging in which the problem of representation is welded to the subject of representation, photography is an image for which its own imageness is a problem. By arguing that in photography representation must be understood as double articulation, which is to say as a dynamic system that presupposes both order and chaos, both rational and sensual logics, this book seeks to propose that difference, rather than identity is the immanent condition of visibility. This however implies that photography is not a stable representational system – as the theory of photography would have it – but the very space of the inscription of the philosophical discourse.

To come at the same thing from another angle, the subject of this book is the materiality of photography, understood here not as identity between object and image and not as the material support of photography but as resistance to the transparency, reflexivity and transcendence of representation that manifests itself as sensual and recursive difference. Through exploring the limits of discrete representation this book seeks to find alternatives to semiotic / art-historical analysis through articulating photography as a mode of translation between fragmentary and always incomplete states. This approach is informed by the proliferation over the last twenty years of non-representational theories within the fields on psycho-geography (Thrift 2008), ethnography (Ingold 2011), affect studies (O’Sullivan 2001) and post-structuralist criticality (Olkowski 2007), however, despite considerable amount of research into the application of non-representational theories to architecture, sociology, forensics and anthropology there is currently no single text that maps these concerns onto the landscape of the photographic image.

This book takes as its guiding star the work of those philosophers, writers and artists who refuse to consider representation as frictionless conduit between matter and form or between objects and thoughts. Adorno, Bakhtin, Benjamin, Deleuze, Golding, Kafka, Lyotard, Olkowski and Shestov are among the thinkers for whom representation is both the form that their thought takes and the concern of this thought. It is not an accident that there are no photography theorists in this list. With few notable exceptions (Van Lier 2008, Flusser 2000), photography theory has little to say about representation itself. In this respect photography theory is lagging behind philosophy that aims to expose the ways by which language conditions and confronts thought. Thought that tries to overcome the limits of thought does not find a counterpart in photographic theory mainly because photography appears so straightforwardly visual.

Technology, history, representation

The difficulty with photography is its apparent simplicity and triviality. Histories of photography conveniently start from a fixed moment in time, and the first photographic image is just

as easily identified as the first steam-train or the first gramophone. The notion that photography is simply one of the inventions of the industrial age is further supported by the fact that it was patented by Daguerre in 1836. Since its invention, the photographic process has been continually refined and improved upon which further reinforces the notion that photography is nothing but a technological process. As a product of the industrial revolution photography is just one among an extensive list of devices that were designed to replace human labour and skill with a mechanical contraption. In the same way that the steam-powered loom of Edmund Cartwright made the labour of hand-weavers redundant by replacing them with a machine, and in so doing contributed to the emergence of industrial capitalism, Daguerre's invention was a form of mechanised image-making that revolutionised painting by rapidly making redundant and unnecessary a whole industry of portraiture that flourished in Europe during the early nineteenth century, and in so doing contributed to the emergence of aesthetic modernism (Tagg 1993). However, the linearity of this account is misleading for two reasons. First, the understanding of photography as technology is far from straightforward, for technology is not a simple 'means to an end', but the way by which the modern age is revealing its destiny in the sense of uncovering what 'does not yet lie here before us' (Heidegger 1977a, p. 13). For Heidegger it is precisely modern technology that marks the threshold of modernity as an era in which man is establishing himself as the subject, the driving force and the guarantor of his world. Technology is the way by which man detaches himself from being and constitutes an autonomy that is founded on human finitude. For this reason, technology is the way by which reality is categorised, homogenised, ordered, controlled, and manipulated. It is in this sense that Heidegger can speak about the experience of modernity as technological. Second, the age of technology is at the same time the age of representation because representation relates to that which is outside of man, that which is not immediately present and must be brought in and represented. Technology of representation is therefore essential to the very means by which modernity as autonomy from external forces is being established. For that reason, photography has to be understood as the fulfilment of the liberal-democratic demand for the self-determination of the human subject established through representation.

Framing the eye

Photography is a technology, it cannot be anything else, but technology implies the ability to repeat something, to make something come again. For this reason photographic technology has a dual capacity: it can either be the etalon of stagnation, endlessly bringing to the eye past events, distant sights, remote happenings in a succession of images that hardly even shudder the retina anymore, or the same technology can be perceived as a way of making visible a force for constant renewal, a possibility of different temporality in which things don't have to be the same over and over again. In other words, photography has both the potential for radical territorialization and for radical deterritorialization: it can be both the eternal return of the same and/or the eternal return of the difference. It is precisely because photography is the standard bearer of memory as a succession of frozen moments that it also has the ability to picture time not as a progression of homogenised measured units but as non-chronological, inhuman, singular time, as the expressive potential of difference.

To look at the world photographically means to take the point of view of the camera, of the apparatus, of the process. It means giving up on the eye as the organon of vision, it means the ability to see without eyes. To see like the camera means to forsake human perception of events as given in time, as part of a linear continuous flow. It means to draw on the forces of repetition and to flow with the forces of reproduction that are embedded in the photograph. Vision here is

experienced as pure vision, not the vision of something but visibility itself. It is as if photography absorbed visibility into itself. To argue, as Deleuze had done that the frame is the genetic condition of the photograph means that reproduction and not representation is the gene of photography (Deleuze 1992, p. 85).

The frame is the condition of reproducibility. The anomaly of the photograph is that the frame is visual. An image has a frame. The frame however is not human doing. The edge does not mark the place where the image ends. The edge-frame it is the timestamp that signals the presence of a series. The frame of a photograph is an abnormality: it is a photographic image from which all references to representation were surgically removed. What is left is not a signifier or a reflection, but photography's own means of production made visible. Lyotard says that one has to study the 'work of dreams' to get to the point of hyper-reflection in which the figural shows itself in the discourse (Lyotard 2011, p.71). In the discourse of photography the figural shows itself within the photographic edge that frames the image.

The frame is the disclosure of the rhythm of the photograph. The frame resists the separation between form and content and rejects the image as an idea or a representation. The edge is transgressive because it is sensorial and unrepresentable: not an image but the source of the image as a reflection of reality. The frame is not the limit but the condition of possibility of making visible. In the frame the image comes closer to being what it is not, getting as close as possible to the 'nothing' of the image, but – and this is precisely what makes the photographic limit special – the 'nothing' is visible. The frame of the image frames the rationality of the image, setting a limit to the rationality of the photographic discourse while at the same time suggesting that the image extends and supersedes this discourse.

With everyday objects such as trees it is hard to notice that they are not really there. Heidegger has drawn attention to this: 'What we see and accept is properly not a tree but in reality a void, a thinly sprinkled with electric charges here and there that race hither and yon at enormous speeds' (Heidegger 2004, p. 45). In other words it is not easy to overcome the commonsensical appearance of the tree, the certainty of self-certainty. But, unlike a tree, the photograph has the advantage that its 'void' is written into the photograph itself, it is made evident by the edge, the frame of the image. The frame is a reminder that the image is not a two-dimensional message without a code, that it has depth and thickness that allude to it being subsumed into a representational framework. Between the 'here' and the 'now', between the 'thing' and the 'image' there is a gap, a distance required for the differentiation. The gap is not a concept, it is that what makes the concept possible. The unique position of the photograph is that it is carrying this interval within it, continually reminding us that difference is necessary for the image to be formed. In photography difference is visually figured as the edge of the image, as the unique mark of the technology of repetition.

Politics in the field of vision

As the mainstay of visual culture, photography is often linked to questions of politics and ethics because of its ability to represent identities and illustrate social situations. However, considering photography in representational terms almost always leaves something out that cannot be contained within representation. Paraphrasing Adorno, it is tempting to say that an object does not go into an image without leaving a remainder: there is always something that escapes the image no matter how true to life it is (Adorno 1983). This 'indissoluble something' cannot be captured by those conceptual schemas that are themselves organised around the distinction between matter and form. For that reason, dialectical or metaphysical reasoning is unable to address the 'something' that is left out of representation, for doing so will undermine the representational

foundation of metaphysical thinking itself. This ‘something’ has different names in different philosophical contexts. For Adorno it is the remainder (negative dialectics), for Heidegger it is *aletheia* (truth), for Deleuze it is immanence (difference), for Derrida *différance* (writing), for Lyotard it is the figural (libidinal), for photography it is the latent image. In their separate ways and for radically different political motives Adorno, Heidegger, Deleuze, Derrida and Lyotard are concerned with exposing the fallacy of identity by drawing attention to that which escapes rational, identarian logic. This book aims to show that photography has a unique stake in the challenge to normative logic by exposing the instability of identity in the field of the visual image. The argument elaborated on these pages is that the metaphysics of representation are configured by technology (understood through Heidegger as poetics) and that this particular fusion of *technē* and mimesis allows to define photography as an abyssal logic that can underwrite and reconfigure the understanding of critical thought in general.

For the above thinkers the challenge to identity involves a confrontation with the all-encompassing rational logic that achieved its fullest expression in the philosophy of Hegel. While the discourse of identity proclaims transparency and makes its explicit aim to set up a field of universal communication, in reality this kind of universalism excludes all particularities and empirical realities in favour of abstract ideals. Whoever does not speak the ‘universal language’ or simply does not want (or is unable) to communicate finds themselves beyond the threshold of the ‘ideal city’. As Lingis explains ‘The Socratic effort to communicate with strangers is, in reality, the effort not to rationally certify the existing Athenian republic but to found an ideal republic of universal communication – a city maximally purged of noise’ (Lingis 2000, p.101).

The difficulty faced by anyone who attempts to ‘talk about nothing’ is that in the words of Adorno ‘to think is to identify’ (Adorno 1983, p. 5). Thought – and language as the organon of thought – dispels ‘nothing’ and makes it into something. Because philosophy has no means at its disposal other than language, philosophy of non-identity, of difference and of nothing must devise ways of producing a discourse that circumvents the natural tendency of language to posit identity between subject and predicate. For Heidegger for instance, poetic language escapes and dissolves the positive, naming structures of scientific language. For Adorno, it is art – particularly high modernist art – that escapes reification and identity with the world, and for that reason it is able to ‘constitute its own essence’ (Adorno 1997). For Derrida it is the originary trace that shows that every sign refers to other signs – rather than to a notion of presence – dismantling the central premise of logo-centrism by suggesting that there is no unmediated ‘real’, just an infinite succession of signs reflecting each other in an endless hall of mirrors (Derrida 1998, p. 62). For Deleuze and Guattari it is the passing from one signification to another which creates a kind of rhythmic structure of self-replication which, while lacking any ‘presence’ is still present as the sensation of the rhythm (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, pp. 310–350). This book suggests that for photography, the challenge of non-identity is not in overcoming the limitations of language but in overcoming the limits of vision which in turn establishes a rhythmic surface that allows thought to become more like the photographic image.

1 The shadow of representation

I. Archaeology of representation

Representation: setting the problem

This chapter begins to trace the dual genealogies of representation as a philosophical concept on the one hand and as a technological process of reproduction on the other. In order to delineate what is at stake in the question of representation, it will be necessary to situate photography at the intersection of a number of philosophical arguments that have in common a confrontation with systemic and totalising models of thought that dominated western philosophy at least since the Enlightenment and perhaps since the Greeks.

The representational philosophical model is based on a twofold principle that underwrites most knowledge systems of Western civilization. The first part is drawing a limit, a dividing line between two kinds of entities: theoretical (spiritual) and material (corporeal). This is a fundamental distinction between what something is and how it is described. The word *apple* describes fruit with crisp and sweet flesh (🍏), but the word *apple* cannot be bitten into, even though both *Apple* and 🍏 mean the same thing. Images and objects are forever conceptually separated and belong to different categories: images are clones of objects, never the other way around. There is no grey area, no twilight zone that permits the existence of entities that are part matter and part spirit. Form and content are not only conceptually separated, but they are also defined in opposition to each other, so an image is that which is not an object, and an object is that which is not an image. In the same way that Newtonian (classical) physics considers mass and energy as separate and categorically different entities, representation understands the image as absolutely and ontologically distinct from an object. The second part of the representational paradigm establishes a fixed standard that is shared by all the disciplines and all the faculties of human perception. For while representation admits that change happens, the one thing that never changes is representation itself. For that reason, there is a hierarchy and stability in the representational model that is universal, ahistorical and immune to change.

The representational model functions by relying on a dual principle that underwrites most knowledge systems of Western societies. The first part of the principle is drawing a limit, a dividing line between two kinds of entities. Images and objects are forever conceptually separated and belong to different realms. There is no grey area, no twilight zone that permits the existence of entities that are part matter and part spirit. Form and content are not only conceptually separated, but they are also defined in opposition to each other, so an image is that which is not an object, and an object is that which is not an image. The second part of the principle of representation establishes a fixed standard that is shared by all the disciplines and all the faculties of human perception. For while representation admits that change happens, the one thing that never

changes is representation itself. For that reason, there is a hierarchy and stability in the representational model that is universal, a-historical and eternal. It is not an accident that Immanuel Kant offers representation as the mechanism that will free men from the bondage of the Middle Ages (Kant 2009), for representation holds the keys to knowledge that does not require the authority of god, the priest or the bible. However, representation is capable of this accomplishment because – not unlike religion – it situates an external authority that men must abide by. Because it is invisible, tasteless, odourless, limitless, and universal, representation commands respect as the law of the land; the totality that nothing is exempt from. As the basic premise of classical science, representation implies objectivity and disinterested observation guaranteed on the one hand by a clear-cut separation between the scientist and the object of study, so the scientist's own material conditions do not affect investigation, and on the other, an assumed neutrality that allows the scientist to assert the universality of his findings. It is precisely because photography is both an objectifying process and a material process that it is at the same time the fullest expression of the logic of representation and the very limit beyond which it cannot go. Photography does more than the representation of reality – it changes our conception of the real as solid and intransient into a global network of self-replicating nodal points.

Representation and subjectivity

Representational thinking works by establishing analogies and parallels between particular entities and by situating the human subject as the judge of resemblances. Representational thinking is grounded in the Cartesian plane, which attributes to every person an independent existence as a self-contained subject and an individual ego (Olkowski 2007, p. 40). Representational thinking is hierarchical, as it labels objects according to their adherence to standards and ideals. The most fundamental and thorough criticism of the representational world view has been linked since Heidegger to the observation that the categories themselves are of little help if their own coming into being is not dealt with:

Basically, all ontology, no matter how rich and firmly compacted a system of categories it has at its disposal, remains blind and perverted from its ownmost aim, if it has not first adequately clarified the meaning of Being, and conceived this clarification as its fundamental task.

(Heidegger 1962, p. 31)

In their different ways and for different philosophical motivations a number of thinkers followed in Heidegger's footsteps and continued to 'clarify the meaning of Being' by opposing it to the tradition that imposes the subject-object model upon thought. Following the critique of systemic thought by Foucault, Lyotard, Derrida, Deleuze and other post-structuralist authors this book is critical of anthropological approaches to photography which begin from setting the human subject as an arbiter of likeness and verisimilitude. The pre-discursive will to define thought as rational is endemic to systemic, representational thought and it also persists in theory of photography because of its premise of the pre-discursive subject for whom the world is known as representation. As long as the representational model is allowed to dominate, it will not be possible to consider photography as a being in its own right and not as a replica of an already given and differentiated world. Only by dislodging photography from the discourse of reflection it is possible to consider it not as the truthful (or, which is the same thing, the deceptive) image, but as an event that carries within it certain value that has nothing to do with

the likeness of the image. The task therefore is to inquire not after the visible content of the image but after the particular form of visibility that is being exposed in photography.

In *The Society of Dismembered Body Parts* Alphonso Lingis points to a time when images were not read as signs that refer to concepts. Before signs became subjected to the principle of identity and legitimated by an externally given ground (the logic of the equal sign), there was a possibility of images operating not as symbols to be read but as a force in their own right: 'Savage inscriptions are not signs that refer to concepts; they are diagrams and paths for the hand' (Lingis 1994, p. 296). The eye did not decipher the message according to a pre-given code, it did not read the image as a sign but took in the direct experience. 'The eye does not read the meaning in a sign; it *jumps* from the mark to the pain' (Lingis 1994, p. 296).

Two case studies

As two brief examples, we might think of the photograph in a passport that is used to verify the identity of its owner when the border control (human or facial recognition algorithm) compares the resemblance between the image and the person, and then, in a different (but connected) manner, the video recording made by Diamond Reynolds of the aftermath of her boyfriend, Philando Castile being shot by police officers, which was viewed by millions of people online, and acted as a catalyst to the Black Lives Matter movement. In the first case, the passport photo speaks not only about the similarity between the image and the person, but also about a system of power and control that attributes a legal status to visual resemblance and legitimises the passing of judgement that is based on visual appearance alone. In the second example, the camera-phone recording transcends the logic of recognition, in which we see a black man bleeding out next to his girlfriend after being shot by a white policeman. What is presented to the viewer through the images and the voices that the camera captured, is not only a documentation of an event, but also the perception of a reality that is bigger and more complex than any representation. Rather than being a faithful documentation of something that happened, this footage acquires a certain autonomy from the event it recorded, *releasing* from it a force that is haunting and scarring the viewer. While we can never feel what it was like to be in that car during that shooting, the jittery recording of the car window that frames the policeman on an ubiquitous sidewalk shouting hysterically, combined with the calm, repetitious narration by Diamond Reynolds who is talking both to the officer and to us, simultaneously responding to orders to show her hands and reporting her boyfriend's death and her own arrest, suggest that violence, racism and fear are both everyday occurrences in suburban America and that they have a specific visual form that this video recording managed to capture.

In both cases discussed above the image acts not only as a rational representation of an external reality, and its authority and agency are anchored not only in our naive belief in photography's ability to simply record a world of people, objects, and events just as it is. Rather, what we can glimpse is the autonomy of the photographic image and its ability to expose the power of the image *qua* image to shape and intervene in the world around us. What we are seeing is not a representation of pre-existing reality, but the photograph allows us to intuit that the visual image is endowed with unique power, and that the power of photography lies not in its ability to represent, but in asserting the materiality of visual perception.

The origin of the image

Lingis reminds us that before the eye became trained on decoding ideograms it knew how to understand meaning without reading. In a similar vein to Lingis, but writing about language

rather than images, Foucault argues that there was time when language did not represent but constituted a force in the world: '[language] prophesied the future, not merely announcing what was going to occur, but contributing to its actual event, carrying men along with it and thus weaving itself into the fabric of fate' (Foucault 1986).

Both Lingis and Foucault identify a pre-representational origin of an image that operates not through the paradigms of signification but as a raw force in the world. This allows them to argue that representation is the product of western metaphysics and not the general form by which all knowledge is given. Foucault argues that representation is a specifically modern modality of knowledge (Foucault 1989a). Representation ultimately locates thought within a grounding condition – such as history, structure, culture or the unconscious – and in so doing denies the active event of thought. As Dalia Judovitz (1988b) shows in her analysis of representation in the work of Descartes, representation becomes the central modality by which knowledge is established when knowledge itself becomes equated with mathematical certitude. Prior to Descartes, notions of representation were based on resemblance and mimesis and therefore proceeded by way of establishing similarity on the basis of the Platonic conception of the image as an imitation of the actual thing. Descartes however doubts the accuracy of representation that is based in resemblance and strives to ground it in logical principles that are based on universal mathematics. In so doing Descartes rejects representation as visual resemblance and posits a new modality of representation that schematizes the visible according to logical paradigms (Judovitz 1988b, p. 73). In this way, Descartes grants representation the status of a scientific tool, capable of precise and accurate results, but by the same token, the visual is now placed in an ambiguous relationship to the real: On the one hand, it is criticised as optical trickery and an illusion that does not withstand the test of rational doubt, and on the other hand vision is construed as a logical schema capable of producing axiomatically accurate knowledge (Judovitz 1988a).

What this means for photography is that representation is not a pre-discursive, externally given law of verisimilitude but historically and socially constructed formula that is based on placing the will to schematise according to a logical structure as the dead centre of theory. However, it is not enough to displace representation from the photographic image, it is also essential to attend to the technology of photography in a way that does not take it as a given that technology is the result of human operations.

The meaning of 'technology'

In *The Question Concerning Technology* Heidegger attacks the view that sees technology as 'merely a phenomenon of human civilisation':

For the essence of technology is not anything human. The essence of technology is above all not anything technological. The essence of technology lies in what from the beginning and before all else gives food for thought.

(Heidegger 2004, p. 22)

In saying that technology is not anything human, Heidegger suggests that technology is not a means to an end or a tool, rather, it is the way by which the human comes to pass as an entity and as an autonomous being. For Heidegger there is no being human without technology because it is through actions, travails and labour that the human being discovers his/her destiny, which is to be the guardian of being. In placing technology as the ground of human existence Heidegger is coming close Marx's (1993) central claim that labour – and not ideas – define the ground of history. However, while Heidegger draws on Marx's notion of labour as the foundation

of the human condition, he also distorts it by asserting that labour always already contains within it the beginnings of the poetic and the spiritual. To do so Heidegger introduces the notion of *poiēsis* into the notion of *technē* and claims that labour, praxis and production already contain within them the seeds of the poetic. The connection between technology and *poesis* is one of the fundamental tenets of Heidegger's late work. For instance, in *The Thing* he writes: 'The potter grasps first and constantly what is ungraspable in the empty and produces it as what holds in the form of a vessel' (Heidegger 2012, p. 8).

If Marx seeks to 'correct' Hegel by delineating the opposition between thought and labour and by placing labour (rather than thought) as the foundation of his metaphysics, Heidegger seeks to 'deconstruct' Marx by rejecting the dialectics of thought and labour through establishing a non-dialectical order in which labour and *poiēsis* are conceived not as diametrically opposed entities, but as a mutual gathering under the auspice of technology.

Heidegger's analysis of technology makes an important contribution to the way photography can be understood. The photographic image is not only a product of technological processes, but the process is also inseparable from the image and permeates it at every step. However, it is also the case that technology, whilst being inseparable from photography, is constantly withdrawing from view: what we see in the photograph is the ideogram, the message, the representation of a thing, while the technological essence of the image is turning away from us. According to Heidegger this withdrawing of the essence is key to understanding technology and it is also the most 'thought provoking' aspect of it. As I will show below, this is particularly the case with photography, where the withdrawing of the essence does not cause essence to disappear completely but leaves a mark in the image.

Ontology of reproduction

As was discussed in the previous section, technologies inherent in the production of the photographic image align it with those philosophies that challenge representation in order to establish a relational ontology based not on the separation of items according to a dualist paradigm but on their interconnectedness.

The ability to be re-produced sets photography apart from other forms of visibility and places it within the realm of repetition as the aesthetic form of the recurrence of the fragment. Nietzsche's notion of the eternal return will be fundamental in articulating this form of aesthetics, in which the will to power becomes the will to create a discourse, whereas the eternal return is the process of representation. This understanding of the aesthetics of photography as drawn out of repetition allows to think of the image not through the prism of aesthetics as the study of the visual image, but as a techno-poetic repetition of a fragment. The significance of this theoretical move away from the aesthetics of mimesis and representation also allows to consider critically the notion of photographic time, and to question the centrality of the archive and the document to photography. However, it is the argument of this book that photography as a *technē* of reproduction and of the recurrence of the fragment is essentially pre-visual, because before there can be an image of any kind, there has to be a relationship that precedes the forming of an image.

While the notions of vision and seeing cannot account fully for the way photography operates, and while the archive is not the essence of the photographic, there is still something about seeing a photograph that makes it true. In other words, jettisoning the formal and normative character of representation based on the visual image and the archive, does not automatically mean that photography has no ethical dimension to it, but it does mean that the ethics of photography must be understood not as a form of archiving the past but as a mode of inhabiting the present, that points towards what consciousness cannot formulate and what consciousness must forget in order to constitute itself (Lyotard 1984a).

To say that the theory of photography is characterised by the primacy of representation, is also to imply that this theory is posited on the primacy of the concept. In order to depart from these metaphysical foundations, it will be necessary to demonstrate that the intelligibility of photography is founded not in the domain of conceptual (representational) thought, but in the specific aesthetic of the photographic image that this research locates not in the 'photograph' but in the repetition of the fragment and in the differentials of perception.

In order to begin teasing out the foundations of this move, the following sections will outline the theoretical foundations that allow moving away from representational thinking.

II. Representation and ancient philosophy

Plato: theory of forms

One of the recurrent themes of the Western philosophical tradition is the distinction between sensual perceptions and rational knowledge. Since Plato, the supremacy of rational reason is based on the assertion that it is able to extract true knowledge from experience. As the discussion in the *Republic* helps to explain, perceptions are inherently unreliable and misleading because the senses are prone to errors and illusions. Only the rational discourse has the tools to overcome illusions and to point towards true knowledge. For instance, perception suggests that a figure in the distance is smaller than it really is. Yet, the application of logical reasoning will reveal that the figure only appears small because it conforms the laws of geometrical perspective. Nevertheless, even after the perspectival correction is applied and reason concludes that perception is misleading, the figure still *appears* small, and the truth of the matter is revealed not in the perception of the figure but in its rational representation.

It is precisely because rational representation is the guarantor of truth that it marks both the very possibility of knowledge and the limit beyond which knowledge cannot go. Whatever cannot be rationally represented remains outside of knowledge and immune to it. To know the truth about something means to be able to represent it, and the proclivity for representation is an indication of a sound and rational mind. For this reason, representation carries within it the stamp of self-validating certainty: representation is a rational picture of the world because rationality is the technique of the subject. On the other hand, precisely because the subject has to be validated through representation, whatever belongs to perception remains unknown to the subject (Colebrook 1999). Therefore, representation can be understood as the distillation of rational knowledge from experience.

Structure of representation in Plato

The structure of representation is derived from the correspondence between a model (thing) and a copy (image), but this identity is grounded in the Platonic definition of Reason as the ability to distinguish between the true and the false. In Platonism, the sensible world is produced as a copy of the world of ideas, and it is the task of reason to overcome the errors of the copy in order to arrive at the truth. The greatest contrast is between εἰκών (*eikon*) and εἶδος (*eidos*), as the image (*eikon*) by necessity presupposes the notion of the other, of that which is different from the reality of the thing (*eidos*): 'We say that a maker of an image knows nothing about that which is but only about its appearance' (Plato 1997a, 601b–c) thus the basic distinction is between the real (ideas) and images (copies). The division drawn in classical Greek philosophy between the model and the copy establishes a hierarchy of truthfulness: the model will always be more true and authentic than the copy, because the world of ideas is more real than the sensible

world. Images can have objective value and be universally meaningful because they presuppose a subject for whom something in the world can be construed as an 'image'. Consider for instance the way we attribute specific time and place co-ordinates to photographs. When I say while looking at a picture: 'this was taken on a holiday in Crete', I interpret the picture as relating to a temporal and spatial reality of my own subjectivity. My experience of time as chronological and space as three-dimensional, is constitutive of the data that is being available in the photograph. The subject is not external to the image but integral to the construction of the image as a copy of subjects' own reality.

Aristotle: establishing representation as the basis of rationality

Aristotle's *Metaphysics* is significant to the understanding of representation because of two specific conceptual moves he initiates in order to contest Plato's theory of forms and undermine the notion of univocity of being. As will be discussed in some detail below, Aristotle's aim is to replace these notions with the concepts of individual identity and the principle of telos. As these Aristotelian concepts constitute the foundation of much of the later representational and scientific thought it is important to show how they get set up and what is being lost or compromised along the way. The first of these is aimed at correcting what Aristotle perceived as a logical flaw in Plato's theory of forms. Aristotle argued that forms are unable to account for the diversity of entities that forms purported to define (Aristotle 1984). Forms cannot capture diversity because they are universals which are common to all the members of a class. For instance, the universal 'whiteness' is the predicate, which is common to all the white objects, however, 'white' does not exist outside of the objects whose colour is white. Similarly, gold is yellow, but yellow does not exist outside of gold. The second conceptual move is derived from the first and is directed against Plato's conception of the univocity of being. Aristotle already established that forms do not exist as separate entities but are predicates of objects and matter. Matter is therefore a bundle of predicates such as quantity, quality, time, position and relation which is another way of saying that matter too does not exist in isolation (Widder 2002). If we strip away all the predicates of gold there will be nothing left, for without its predicates gold does not exist.

Aristotle's universal principles

The separation between objects and predicates distinguishes Aristotelian philosophy from the earlier Eleatic. For the Eleatics Being is one and there is no gap between a concrete entity and predicates. For instance, Parmenides says 'Thinking and Being are the same thing' (Gallop 1991). Heidegger comments on this fragment:

Man's distinctive feature lies in this, that he, as the being who thinks, is open to Being, face to face with Being; thus man remains referred to Being and so answers to it. Man *is* essentially this relationship of responding to Being, and he is only this.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 27)

In Heidegger's characterisation, the thought of Parmenides asserts thought itself as a productive and creative force that maintains direct relationship with things in a way that thinking of being is at the same time the production of being. This is precisely the kind of reasoning that Aristotle finds unacceptable, and he seeks to excrete any such tendencies towards univocity and establish knowledge on universal principles.

However, to argue as Aristotle did that knowledge is universal is not enough in order to establish representation as the basis of knowledge. It was further essential to demonstrate that conceptual reasoning and orderly classification are also the basis for a political practice that ensures stability and continuity. As will be shown below, Aristotle's philosophy of finitude is being established and grounded in representation as the organic form of knowledge in which the possibility of change is both enshrined and restricted. As any concrete thing is a collection of predicates which can change over time, a thing can have some predicates one moment and some other predicates the next. However, while the predicates of the thing can change, the fundamental nature of the thing remains the same. In this way Aristotle is able to allow change to take place while maintaining unchanging identity at the core of the subject. It is worth noting the extent to which contemporary normative understanding of identity is still deeply Aristotelian (Irwin 1990),

Moreover, Aristotle reasoned that separation between subject and predicate creates plurality. When saying 'X is white' there remains a conceptual distinction between the subject in which the whiteness is seated, and the qualification of 'being white' (Aristotle 1984, p. 141). Splitting of the proposition into subject and predicate ensures on the one hand the stability of the subject and on the other accounts for the difference among predicates only *in relation* to the stable subject. In this way identity is being established as the guiding principle of conceptual thinking as difference is only allowed to exist between predicates and between subjects but not as an autonomous force. This is how stability is maintained and a static centre is established within each proposition:

Those things are said to be other in kind whose ultimate substratum is different, and which are not analysed the one into the other nor both into the same thing (e.g. form and matter are different in kind); and things which belong to different categories of being; for some of the things that are said to be signify essence, others a quality, others the other categories we have before distinguished; these also are not analysed either into one another or into some one thing.

(Aristotle 1984, p. 82)

This logic denies the possibility of considering qualities (predicates) as powers in their own right through which being itself is produced, and it allows Aristotle to claim that different categories do not share a single origin and that being exists only as a predicate in a proposition. This split of the proposition into subject and predicates not only eliminates the need for a univocal being, but it also establishes an opposition between being and thinking, experience and thought, one and the many, aesthetic and intellectual perception.

Problems with Aristotelian logic

However, as will be shown below, while the Aristotelian logic provides coherence through hierarchy of identical generic concepts, it reduces difference to the status of a predicate and in so doing it runs into internal contradictions (Olkowski 1999, p. 19). Problems with this logic appear when a statement that is logically or syntactically correct is experientially wrong. The most basic form of this reasoning can be expressed in the judgement all M are P, all S are M, therefore all S are P.

All humans are mortal. Socrates is human. Socrates is mortal.

On the face of it this statement seems unproblematic, yet internal contradictions and logical inconsistencies arise when the analytical content of this statement is contrasted with the experiential or existential content. For instance, the minor premise of the above syllogism (Socrates is human) leads to a false identity as it suggests an equivalence between the terms 'Socrates' and 'human'. The identity, expressed by the conjuncture 'is', proves problematic because it establishes a relation of equivalence between the two parts of the statement, however, the two parts do not appear to be identical. 'Human' is one of the predicates of 'Socrates' but not the only or the necessary one. We could just as well say that Socrates is Greek, or man etc. which are predicates that are independent of 'Human'. There seems to be a break or a chasm between the essence of human and the singular instance of 'Socrates' (Bryant 2008, p. 7).

The contradiction lies in the relationship between the essence and the particular (or subject and predicate) and can be conceived as arising from the assumption that the relationship between predicates and concrete entities is posited on logical reason. Socrates is real and concrete entity whose existence is independent for the predicate 'human'. Being human is only one of the predicates that define Socrates. When not attached to any concrete reality, the predicate 'human' has no existence of its own, it is just an abstraction. However, a concrete entity such as Socrates is a bundle of such abstractions (predicates). Predicates are said to be the source of all concrete things and logically prior to them.

W.T. Stace is clear on this point:

The world-purpose is immanent in the world itself. It is not a psychic event which happens in a mind. *It is a logical reason.* What happens happens for a reason. This reason is the purpose of what happens. The events are the consequents of the reason, of the purpose. The purpose or end, then, is prior to the world, not as its cause in time, but as its reason. The principle of form, the universal, is the reason, and the world is the consequent. The universal is therefore logically prior to things, not prior to them in time.

(Stace 1955, p. 21, my emphasis)

As Stace explains, Aristotle places logical reason that unfolds towards its purpose as the basis of his metaphysical system. The separation between concrete entities and predicates does not occur in practice, but it is taking place in thought. Predicates are factually inseparable from objects but logically they are independent and can be considered separately in the mind.

Reason is inaugurated to account for the relation between the sensible intuition of concrete entities and the intellectual comprehension of abstract predicates. Because both the particular and the abstract cannot be known 'in themselves' as their knowledge presupposes that something is already 'at hand' Aristotle has to introduce reason as the *de facto* ground of all knowledge. Heidegger clarifies this point:

We can say negatively: finite knowledge is noncreative intuition. What has to be presented immediately in its particularity must already have been 'at hand' in advance. Finite intuition sees that it is dependent upon the intuitable as a being which exists in its own right... Finite intuition of the being cannot give the object from out of itself.

(Heidegger 1997, p. 18, quoted in Bryant 2008, p. 7)

Representation enters metaphysics

Regarding concrete things Aristotle (1984, p. 101) says that they cannot be defined but they are known by the aid of thought or perception, this is because matter is unknowable in itself. This is

therefore the way by which representation enters Western metaphysics. Its function is to address the ostensible impossibility of knowing a concrete, individual entity. Aristotle inaugurated the notion of individual entity in order to deny the existence of the Platonic forms, but by refusing the independent existence of ideas he was forced to conclude that objects cannot be known in themselves, but only through their predicates. Representation is therefore linked to the will to mastery over all things, but it is bought at the price of the loss of immediate knowledge or things in themselves. This is how representation shows itself as way of thinking that posits the world as objective reality that can be comprehended through rational deduction and logical reasoning. The desire to categorise, identify and classify is expressed through the impetus to give names to entities and in that way to achieve a measure of control over the world. The concrete is designated through its predicates which allows the grouping of the concrete under categories. But predicates are disconnected from the concrete entity, they can only represent it as an image, and for that reason unmediated access to the material, the non-conceptual or the factual is not possible under this system. The power of Aristotle's model cannot be denied. By means of the distinction between subjects and predicates he gave the human mind mastery over the forces of nature, providing it with the tools to systematically classify and methodically order the world. But in so doing Aristotle established another force: the force of the system which is just as powerful, if not more so, then the forces of nature it commands (Weil 1988, pp. 19–20).

As Olkowski (1999, p. 15) indicates, Deleuze locates the origins of representation in the parameters of the hierarchical Aristotelian framework of genera and species. For Aristotle a concept is categorised according to the way it is divided by specific differences. For instance, the predicate 'rational' divides the genus 'animal' into 'human' and 'non-human' species (McMahon 2005, p. 43).

Difference in Aristotle

There are two ways in which Aristotle understands difference. The first is difference in kind and the second difference in degree. Difference in kind refers to irreconcilable difference between genus, for instance the difference between animate and inanimate being. The other kind of difference is difference between two things that have something in common. For instance, human being and a cow have in common that both are animals. In both cases difference is understood through identity. On that point, Deleuze suggests that Aristotle's metaphysics has no room for another kind of difference: difference that is not managed by identity, i.e. difference in itself (Deleuze 1990, p. 403). For Aristotle difference is subordinate to identity because he does not recognise the autonomy of difference.

The instrumentalization of difference and its subordination to identity allows for an all-encompassing system of knowledge governed by one form of logic that unites all parts of the physical, ethical and sensual world (Widder 2002, p. 60). However, the consequences of privileging identity over difference go beyond issues of nomenclature and have direct influence on the way being is conceived. This is because at the limit of the hierarchical system, at the top level of classification, there is difference between the genera but these genera themselves are not subsumed under a meta-genus or a higher-level concept. What all the genera have in common is their difference from each other but Aristotle refuses to recognise difference as the meta-genus common to all the genera (Aristotle 1984, p. III, 3). The plurality of being is that which is making change possible and allows a thing to have certain qualities at one time and other qualities another time while remaining fundamentally the same (Widder 2002, p. 62).

Subordination of difference to identity ensures the plurality of the Aristotelian system, but this plurality is fundamentally teleological, founded on differences and divisions between species

and precluding the production of meaning that is not based on the concept of identity. As Deleuze points out, Aristotelian conception of difference is entirely relativist which precludes it from becoming a universal concept (*eidos*).

Here we find a confusion disastrous for the entire philosophy of difference: assigning a distinctive concept of difference is confused with the inscription of difference within concepts in general – the determination of the concept of difference is confused with the inscription of difference in the identity of an undetermined concept.

(Deleuze 1990, p. 40)

III. Enlightenment and representation

Vision and representation in Descartes

Metaphors of vision and reflection are prevalent concern within a both post-structuralist and structuralist traditions. For instance, Rodolphe Gasché (1986) places reflection at the centre of metaphysics, emphasising the optical connotations of the action of mirroring and throwing back light as the guiding metaphor for the mode of operation by which the mind has knowledge of itself and its operations. On the other hand, Richard Rorty sees great danger in philosophy's reliance on vision arguing that traditional philosophy is held captive by the image of the mind as a great mirror containing various representations. (Rorty 2009, p. 12). In *Downcast Eyes* Martin Jay (2004) maps out the centrality of vision to critical thought since Descartes to explain why post-modern philosophies begin their critical projects with the eye. According to Jay, contemporary continental philosophy's central project is the critique of the tendency to favour ocularcentric theories of knowledge. Jay enlists Bruno Latour's concept of 'hybridity' to suggest that the figural cannot be reduced entirely to the discursive. His criticism is aimed specifically at Lyotard to whom he assigns a 'discursive' approach to the visual.

Historically vision has played central role in the construction of philosophical concepts: From Plato's allegory of the cave to Brunelleschi's studies of perspective, to Descartes' (2001, pp. 99–127) optical experiments, sight was the privileged sense of identity and rationality for Enlightenment thinking. For that reason, the positive connection between vision and rationality is one of the foundational principles of philosophy. For Descartes vision is directly related to *logos* because it is an extension of the mathematical principles that govern the behaviour of light. However, there is a problem: despite being rational, vision produces likenesses which are spontaneous and subjective and so they pose a treat for logical reasoning. Descartes returns to this point several times in *Dioptrics*:

We must not think that it is by means of this resemblance that the picture makes us aware of the objects – as though we had another pair of eyes to see it, inside our brain [...] rather, we must hold that the movements by which the image is formed act directly on our soul *qua* united to the body, and are ordained by nature to give us such sensations.

(Descartes 1970, p. 246)

Duality of vision in Descartes

It is due to this paradoxical duality of vision that Descartes strives to separate likeness from representation. What becomes clear through Descartes' discussion of painting in *Optics* is that there is a contradiction between likeness (which Descartes calls *resemblance*) and representation that for Descartes is an extension of vision which in itself a masked form of mathematical thought (Judovitz 1988a).

In Descartes' theory of 'lumen naturale', natural light has its source in God and possesses a perfect symmetry with the mind: 'For I have certainly no cause to complain that God has not given me an intelligence which is more powerful, or a natural light which is stronger than that which I have received from Him' (Descartes 1993, p. 89). With the notion of 'lumen naturale' Descartes hopes to bypass the vagaries of the senses. His study of dioptrics is based on the claim that a lux of non-sensory divine origin is the cause of movements of the lumen, or the light of the mind. (Vasseleu 1998, p. 4)

Vision is therefore a site of tension between the eye as an exact and rational instrument on the one hand and of the eye as one of the five senses which can be easily deceived by *trompe l'oeil*, hallucination, likenesses and appearances, on the other. The paradox of vision is that it can claim privilege as being uniquely rational and yet, it cannot detach itself from the perpetuation of illusion that is common to all senses (Vasseleu 1998). As will be discussed below, this tension is an on-going concern for metaphysical thought that comes to a head with the invention of photographic technology in the nineteenth century. The invention of photography is a pivotal moment of merging between aesthetic and rational principles and the overcoming of the traditional divisions between science and art and between philosophy and technology. Photography is a technology that confirms the rationality of vision and it ties together both aesthetic mimesis and mathematical representation under the auspice of *ratio* manifest in the scientifically validated image making process. It is possible to argue, as Vilém Flusser has done, that it is because Western epistemology is based on the Cartesian premise that to think means to follow the written line, that it does not recognise photography as the harbinger of a new philosophy that operates with images rather than with words (Flusser 2002, p. 26).

Dialectics and photography

After several decades of critical effort, it might seem that every aspect of the relationship of photography to the world was already explored and all that is left to examine are ideological differences arising from conflicting and incompatible world views and the application of these word views to new technical developments. Art historical studies advance the notion of the photographic image as an aesthetic by applying to it concepts developed for the appreciation of fine art (Fried 2008), while sociologists insist on the fundamental ideological underpinnings of photography as means of constructing a total view of reality (Berger 2013). The analytical view attributes essential qualities to photography (Costello and Iversen 2010), while phenomenologists emphasize the embodied experience of viewing a photograph (Barthes 1981, Batchen 1999). Structuralists read photography through linguistic and semiotic codes (Burgin 1987) and post-structuralism denies that it possesses a singular essence (Tagg 1993). Presumably, the available range of approaches is also broad enough should one wish to address the development of new photographic practices, cultures and techniques brought about by the hyper-growth in various forms of digital imagery for screens.

And yet, despite the ostensible diversity of interpretative methodologies, all these approaches share the same empirical certainties about the essential nature of the 'man' as the one for whom the photograph is an image, and as the one who upholds the difference between the image and 'the real'. The implicit assumption is that photography is a discourse on and about man, and that the photograph carries a resemblance to a prior state of affairs. The common ground of anthropological approaches is that photographs are images that relate to pre-existing being, and this relation is constituted in the mind of a subject for whom the photograph is an image. Subjectivity and representation are the unshakable underpinning beliefs that belong to the same, more general opinion according to which there is a world out there that can be taken up to be

inscribed in an image. But it is precisely the notion that there is some ‘real’ that exists independently of inscription and representation, that constitutes the ideological premise that considers a photograph as *an image of something* (Cohen *et al.* 2016, p. 12). To say the same thing slightly differently, the technological process that automates memory and inscription and links-up information, communication and labour into one unconscious stream of image data tends to conceal from view the paradox that the world we inhabit does not at all resemble its photographic representation.

When a photograph is defined in terms of the visual content inscribed within it, this focus on the intelligible already determines in advance a relationship that is symbolic, linguistic and dialectical. The often-quoted statement from *Camera Lucida* sums up the prevailing assumption that a photograph is at the same time an index of presence and a mark of absence:

It is thus at the level of the denotated message or message without code that one can plainly understand the *real unreality* of the photograph.

(Barthes 1977, p. 44)

The dialectic of the photograph is the intrinsic contradiction of the *real* and *unreal*, X and not-X, which have to be taken together to form the picture. The copy and the model, the image and the world, the concept and the object are held together as diametrical opposites mediated by the long shadow of the Hegelian dialectic. Barthes’ neat formula seems to be all encompassing in its unification of opposites, but in presenting photography as the visual embodiment of a dialectical contradiction it smuggles into the discourse of photography the notion of the critical subject for whom the world appears photographically as the unified and homogenous field of representation.

The advantage of this mode of analysis is that it enables to make objective and universal truth claims that still make room for the contradictions, movement and subjective human activities that are required in order to introduce change into the system. On the other hand, the problem with dialectical thinking is that this ‘system’ is based on a logic that operates with binary oppositions in which the ‘model’ is related to and opposed to the ‘copy’, the ‘image’ is opposed to the ‘thing’, the ‘subject’ is opposed to the ‘object’, ‘negative’ to ‘positive’, ‘form’ to ‘content’, etc. and the whole of reality appears to be contained within the parameters of binary logic.

Philosophy of reflection

Considered through a representational paradigm, photography can be seen as the culmination of the philosophy of reflection as it is developed from Plato to Hegel. As a philosophical model, reflection requires three moments: the object is reflected by a polished surface, the polished surface that is reflecting its own reflection, and the subject who discovers themselves in the process of self-mirroring. The speculative goes beyond simple rationality, for it sublates the opposition between rationality and reflection. Not only subjectivity and objectivity, but all other oppositions are sublated (preserved and destroyed) in the movement of speculative thought. Gasché had remarked that ‘the paradigm of reflection requires a third element, which triggers the unifying dialectic between the mirror and its object, as well as between the mirror and itself’ (Gasché 1986, p. 31).

Hegelian dialectics and representation

Dialectics, particularly in its Hegelian form, is the triumph of rational representation over conventional pictorial resemblance. For Hegel, the dialectical move starts from a sensorial input: a

human subject encounters an object, this encounter is sensual and immediate, it is taking place in the *now*. The *now* is a moment of totality. It is, 'the most abstract and purest truth' (Hegel 1998a, pp. 58–9). And yet, this moment does not last, and it is at once exposed as false because pure being appears to co-exist with pure not-being. As Hegel explains:

The Now is pointed to, *this* Now. 'Now'; it has already ceased to be in the act of pointing to it. The Now that *is*, is another Now than the one pointed to, and we see that the Now is just this: to be no more just when it is. The Now, as it is pointed out to us, is Now that *has been*, and this is its truth; it has not the truth of *being*.

(Hegel 1998a, p. 63)

The 'now' is always already 'not know', because the moment to grasp it already passed, and therefore the present is imbued with its own passing. It can be said that the whole trajectory of the Hegelian dialectical move is drawn out of the addition of non-being to being. In Johnny Golding's analysis:

At the very moment one might point or attempt to grasp (both intellectually and practically) the present-tense Real in all its glorious manifestations – this 'Now' will always-already disappear into a Before or an After or a Somewhere Else. This is because the present – as present, i.e. as a 'not-mediated' entity, can never itself become embodied or 'fully realised', precisely because *ipso facto* it is 'im-mediate'.

(Golding 2010a)

The non-being, or the negation of being, is not a conceptual abstraction but the concrete knowledge of death as death. As Taylor explains 'Our starting point is finite existence which is first in the order of discovery' (Taylor 1979, p. 37). Pure being and pure not-being are co-present at the founding moment of sense-certainty in which sense is the knowledge of being and certainty is sureness of death. Hegel expresses this with exceptional clarity:

Pure being and *pure nothing* are, therefore, the same. What is the truth is neither being nor nothing, but that being – does not pass over but has passed over – into nothing, and nothing into being. But it is equally true that they are not undistinguished from each other, that on the contrary, they are not the same, that they are absolutely distinct, and yet that they are unseparated and inseparable and that each immediately *vanishes in its opposite*. The truth is therefore, this movement of immediate vanishing of the one in the other.

(Hegel 1998b, p. 188)

The inability of the mind to reconcile the two, to hold them together as one creates dynamic oscillation in which being *necessarily* becomes non-being and non-being *necessarily* becomes being. This movement extracts being and non-being from their own stasis and merges them into a dynamic new entity which is the sublation of being and not-being: Becoming. Jean-Luc Nancy identifies becoming (dynamism) as the fundamental characteristic of Hegel's thought:

The world is therefore not a simple result, nor does it have a result. It is the world that itself results *in* its own movement, and the thought of this its own truth is itself, in turn, a movement and a restlessness – the very same, in fact, to the extent that it is restlessness of self, for itself, and uneasy about itself; and because it reveals itself as other, infinitely in the other.

(Nancy 2002, p. 6)

Becoming then forms the ground and the foundational principle that gives new meaning to being and not-being as parts of a dynamic whole. This is the basis of the entirety of the Hegelian dialectical move. The process repeats itself through progressive sublation of opposites which leads the spirit through a sequence of repetitions that ultimately results in freedom that is obtained via self-knowledge. This sublation of subject and object is for Hegel the goal of human history and the final truth. By way of repeated dialectical negation, the spirit moves towards the goal of Absolute Knowing. Hegel's optimistic progression towards unification between the self and the world is both reaffirmed and parodied by Nietzsche, for whom the sequence of repetitions required by the Hegelian move is not a promise of freedom but of eternal damnation. 'The eternal hourglass of existence is turned over again and again, and you with it, speck of dust' (Nietzsche 2001, p. 194).

According to Hegel, being is the domain of the senses, while non-being is supersensory, 'there now opens up above the *sensuous* world, which is the world of *appearance*, a *supersensible* world which henceforth is the *true* world, above the vanishing *present* world there opens up a permanent *beyond*' (Hegel 1998a, p. 87).

The sublation of being and non-being produces the totality/unity that equals truth. Dialectics is drawn out of the certainty of death, of non-being.

Death, if that is what we want to call this non-actuality, is of all things the most dreadful, and to hold fast what is dead requires the greatest strength. [...] But the life of Spirit is not the life that shrinks for death and keeps itself untouched by devastation, but rather the life that endures it and maintains itself in it. It wins the truth only when, in utter dismemberment, it finds itself.

(Hegel 1998a, p. 19)

At first, being and non-being are seen as completely separate, self-contained, homogenous and absolute. Understanding attempts to hold onto being as a totality by excluding non-being. Yet, this proves to be impossible for being is meaning-less without non-being: one is implicated in the other's actuality. The understanding attempts to separate being from non-being but paradoxically produces a kind of osmosis by introducing a time element that destabilises the structure. For Hegel then, the ultimate goal of the dialectic is the discovery of identity of subject and object – their oneness is revealed through a process of continuous negation. In the preface to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* Hegel explains:

The truth is the whole, but the whole is nothing other than the essence consummating itself through its development. Of the Absolute it must be said that it is essentially a *result*, that only in the *end* is it what it truly is; and that precisely in this consists its nature, viz. to be actual, subject, the spontaneous becoming of itself.

(Hegel 1998a, p. 11)

For Hegel, identity is located in the relation to other, already and always mediated through the sublation of opposites. 'The truth' or absolute knowledge is the identity of identity and non-identity. In this way reflection and representation are exposed as one and the same. Truth is not in the one or the other but in their passing over – have already passed over – into each other. The move of the Hegelian dialectic echoes the fusion of the *icon* (*imitation*) and *logos* (*understanding*) in the photo-mechanical image. Hegel contends that light is not only a form of energy and a physical substance but also a major philosophical concept that produces subjectivity in its wake.

But light as such exists only as *one* side of what is implicit in the principle of subjectivity, i.e., as this more ideal [self-]identity. In this respect light only manifests, in the sense that it proves in nature to be simply what makes things *in general* visible; but the *particular* character of what it reveals remains outside it as an object which is not light but the opposite of light and so is dark.

(Hegel 1975, pp. 808–9)

The knowledge or knowing cannot be anything other than immediate knowledge itself, it must be knowledge of the immediate, of what simply *is*. Or, as Hegel (1998a, p. 61) says, “‘Now’ is day because I see it; ‘Here’ is a tree for the same reason’. Our approach to the object must also be *immediate* or *receptive*; we must alter nothing in the object as it presents itself. In *apprehending* it, we must refrain from trying to *comprehend* it.

For Hegel, truth is not in the immediacy of knowledge but in the mediation of substance by subject. The way things appear to the senses does not lead to truth and concepts created by the mind are equally unreliable. Any attempt to hold perception and cognition as separate will fail in getting to the true. For this reason, according to Hegel (1998a, p. 4), both Descartes and Spinoza fail short of reaching the truth. Both perception and cognition lack an awareness of themselves, a self-consciousness that must be preserved in the apprehension of the subject. Only in this way will the subject appear as pure negativity.

Implications of dialectics

In coming to discuss the implications of the Hegelian dialectical negation to the understanding of photography as the merging of the visible and the logical it is significant to underline Hegel’s critique of Plato’s theory of forms: ‘Only this *self-restoring* sameness, or this reflection in otherness within itself – not an *original* or *immediate* unity as such – is the True’ (Hegel 1998a, p. 10). Here it can be seen that Hegel’s response to Platonism which places the knowledge of the essence above the form (eidos) is that this is not serious, for all it can grasp is the abstract universality of the subject. Taken in this way, as separate from the form, the essence is dead. On the other hand, it will be equally a mistake to subsume form in the substance by saying that they are one. In order to achieve its full potential form has to be assimilated in substance in such a way that preserves it as form, and substance has to be reflected in the form and find its self-consciousness within it. This conception of truth as a process of mutual reflection between substance and form or between cognition and reflection sees the separation of *logos* and *icon* as misleading and artificial. The visual and the logical are only fully formed once they are fused with each other in a way that keeps them fully separate and fully co-dependent at the same time. A recurring theme throughout Hegel’s writing is the sublation of nature and spirit and the error of conceiving either one without the other:

The distinction between nature and spirit has been interpreted quite correctly as meaning that we must trace nature back to ‘reality’ as its basic determination, and spirit to ‘ideality’. But nature is not just something fixed and complete on its own account, which could therefore subsist even without spirit; rather, it is only in spirit that nature attains to its goal and its truth. Similarly, spirit, for its part, is not just an abstract word beyond nature; on the contrary, it only genuinely is, and proves to be spirit, insofar as it contains nature sublated within itself.

(Hegel 1991, p. 153)

Sublation

The double meaning of the German word '*aufheben*' (sublation) captures perfectly the relationship of this dialectic to photography (Cassar 2010). On the one hand, we understand it to mean 'clear away' or 'cancel', as in the expression that a law or regulation is cancelled (*aufgehoben*). But the word also means 'to preserve', in the sense that something is well taken care of (*wohl aufgehoben*) (Inwood 1999, p. 284). This ambiguity in linguistic usage through which the same word has both a negative and a positive meaning is put to a great use by Hegel as an illustration of the way sublation itself operates: the two meanings of the word 'sublation' are themselves sublated to create the restless, never-to-be-pinned-down concept of sublation. The movement of the Hegelian *Aufhebung* finds its counterpart in the gesture of photography in which reflection is sublated with understanding, resulting in a truly speculative form of truth that simultaneously preserves and alters while inscribing the object in the space of its own negation (Cassar 2010).

Sublation has a long history in photography, for instance Sekula (in: Burgin 1987) regards the photograph as mobile, contingent, and inherently social entity caught as it were between the double ideological demands of aestheticism (or subjectivism) and scientism (or objectivism). The reason why a number of theories of photography approach it from a dialectical standpoint of the sublation of light or alternatively as an archive which simultaneously preserves and destroys the archived object, could be traced to a problem with the dialectical negation itself. As Nathan Widder demonstrates, Hegel fails to show the Notion's actualization in history:

The only way to redeem the historical dialectic is to excuse it from having to provide a causal chain wherein the Notion becomes actual in human history by demonstrating this realization to be an already established fact. In other words, history must already have terminated, so that the historical dialectic simply recounts its fulfillment, bypassing the need to explain it.

(Widder 2002, p. 32)

It is worth noting that the reason Hegelian ontology runs into internal difficulties is precisely because, being a unified system, it requires solid foundations. On the other hand, a realist ontology such as that of Deleuze does not require a foundation but only demands a minimal amount of knowledge to begin a fermentation or to reproduce as a rhizome. As Manuel DeLanda clarifies (2004, p. 55)

[A] realist ontology may be lifted by its own bootstraps by assuming a minimum of objective knowledge to get the process going and then accounting for the rest. The minimum of presupposed knowledge need not constitute a foundation at all. Whether the choice of minimum to start with is correct or not can be checked by the overall coherence of the resulting ontology and by verifying that it does indeed avoid the postulation of general entities (ideal types, eternal laws).

The problem is one of bootstrapping, as DeLanda (2004, p. 55) explains

'bootstrapping' is a computer science term the refers to the difficulty of starting up a computer: When a computer is turned on (or 'booted up'), the software must be loaded into the hardware, but 'loading' is a software function. This circularity is broken by hardwiring a little bit of software (a hardware mini-loader) which loads the software.

Hegelian logic of negation only makes sense if looked at from its end point that comes back and provides the ground for the whole of the dialectical movement. Photography might be able to provide the starting point for the process at it establishes experientially the assimilation of nature by logic as it anchors the *logos* in the physical substance of light. In this context photography can be seen as the experiment that proves the truth of the dialectic by demonstrating that the Notion, (i.e. image) is produced through the process of sublation and negation.

We saw that the conditions of a system based on dialectical negation are such that Hegel cannot accept the idea of a God that created the world from outside of the system (theism) because the world then is an unessential addendum for the existence of God. Similarly, Hegel cannot accept the existence of a rational consciousness that just accidentally appeared in the world (naturalism). Photography, as the process by which nature records itself, confirms to Hegel's idea of God who eternally makes the conditions of its own existence.

Hegel: thinking without images

As the examination of the Hegelian dialectic in the previous section showed, by dint of being a totalising system it requires a foundation which is external to it. This point was neatly summarised by George Eliot's quip (2000, p. 1) 'Men can do nothing without the make-believe of a beginning.' In the Hegelian ontology it can be said that the beginning begets representational thinking precisely because it posits negation as the driving force of the whole system without being able to account for the becoming of negation, or to explain why negation is necessary and not contingent. As Widder (2002, p. 31) explains, 'the dialectic fails to account for the motor force it demands, so that mediation remains incomplete insofar as the Notion does not account for its own becoming'.

Hegel established negation as the force that makes it possible to distinguish something from nothing through the continuous movement of becoming. In so doing Hegel was hoping to overcome the qualitative distinction inherited from Kant between the transcendental subject and the empirical manifold or multiplicity. In the *Critique of Pure Reason* Kant proposes to overcome metaphysical thinking through installing reason – rather than an externally given force – as the foundation of knowledge. He is able to do so by proposing a number of *a-priori* categories for all possible experiences. A category is *a-priori* (literally 'from the beginning') when it is independent from experience and its justification derived purely from thinking logically about the proposition itself. *A-priori* knowledge is self-contained, derived from logic without having to gather any evidence. For instance, the statement 'a triangle has three corners' is an *a-priori* statement, because it is validated from within the statement itself. In this way, Kant thought to finally solve the controversy between rationalism and empiricism. Rationalism, or idealism maintains that space and time are not real entities but merely ideas we hold in our minds. On the other hand, empiricism maintains that space and time are absolute and have an independent existence. Due to *a-priori* statements Kant is able to argue that space and time are both absolute and that they derive from our minds. Thanks to *a-priori* statements, the transcendental subject is in possession of a logic that allows him to synthesize external reality. However, there is a price to pay for this form of logic, for while *a-priori* statements are absolutely certain and experience independent, by the same token they do not permit any knowledge of reality that is external of us, but only of our experience of it. Going back to the example of the triangle, we can be certain *a-priori* that a triangle has three corners, but all that means is that this is what a triangle is *for us*, we still don't have any knowledge of the triangle in the real world. In other words, the logic of *a-priori* can only account for possible experiences, not for the real or actual ones. As Somers-Hall (2012, p. 25) explains 'Kant's main preoccupation is [...] with the validity

of propositions given in advance of our enquiry, rather than with a genuine description of subjective life.’ For Hegel, this was all much to abstract and stifled. Hegel’s aim was to create a total and all-encompassing system which never-the-less was capable of dynamism, creativity and change. To achieve this aim Hegel seeks to avoid presuppositions that would ground the system in an externally given law, and for that reason he does not start from the concept of man (therefore he rejects the Cartesian *Cogito*) or from *a-priori* categories (Kant) which are prior to the world. However, start somewhere he must in order to arrive at the ultimate realisation of spirit as universal consciousness. Hegel pirouettes out of this tight spot by taking as a foundation something that is necessarily real, yet it does not depend on being externally given – this is Absolute Spirit, or logic. Stace gives particularly lucid explanation of this move

in a general way we have already seen that the system of categories constitutes reason, and that reason is its own reason, is self-explained and self-determined. And this means that it is dependent only upon itself. And this in turn means that it is real.

(Stace 1955, p. 66)

In other words, for Hegel, there is no question of what we can or cannot think, but only of what objectively is. Stace then goes on to insist that ‘It must be admitted, however that the inability to think purely, to think without an accompaniment of pictorial images, is grave impediment to the understanding of philosophy, especially the philosophy of Hegel’ (Stace 1955, p. 69).

As will be shown below, Hegel’s attempt to ‘think without images’ relies on having a subjective image of what it means to think. It is significant that for Hegel, images in general (both in the lay sense and as aesthetic creations or works of art) are one of the stages in the development of the Spirit which must be overcome on the way to the Absolute. ‘Art is, and remains for us, on the side of its highest destiny, a thing of the past’ he says (Hegel 1993, p. 13). According to Deleuze, the problem with any attempt to start a philosophy without any presuppositions is that presuppositions are of two kinds: objective and subjective, and while it seems possible to evacuate philosophy of objective presuppositions, the subjective ones prove to be much harder to get rid of: ‘While Hegel criticized Descartes for this, he does not seem, for his part, to proceed otherwise: pure being, in turn, is a being only by virtue of referring all its presuppositions back to sensible, concrete, empirical being’ (Deleuze 2004, p. 164).

Image of thought in Hegel

The problem therefore is that it is precisely ‘pure non-sensuous thought’ that begins from an *image* of what it means to think. Therefore, while Hegel successfully located a starting point that does not depend on any objective presupposition, he did not succeed in avoiding a pre-philosophical presupposition of the empirical being of thought. As Widder (2002, p. 34) explains:

Hegel draws the necessity of negation from the inability of being as a simple positivity to distinguish itself from nothingness. This creates a movement purporting to be autonomous. Given Hegel’s inability to show the Notion’s actualization in history, however, it becomes clear that the dialectic itself rests on a final cause that remains external to it.

This implies that a critique of representation proceeds by way of showing how exactly was representation smuggled into a philosophical discourse that purports to rid itself of all representations. Deleuze (2004, p. 164) outlines this process with exemplary clarity:

[The philosopher] can assume that the universality of his premises – namely, what it means to be and to think... – will be implicitly understood, and that no one can deny that to doubt is to think, and to think is to be... When philosophy rests its beginning upon such implicit or subjective presuppositions, it can claim innocence, since it has kept nothing back – except, of course, the essential – namely, the form of this discourse.

In this way, systemic philosophy is exposed as founded on the presupposition of the natural capacity for thought. However, this capacity is never acknowledged as such because it is nothing more than the common sense of what does it mean to think. This failure of systemic thought to account for the subjective origins of its own system can be taken as a starting point for an a-systemic philosophy, one that will necessarily embrace paradox, difference and dissemination.

It will be shown later that there is a significant parallel between systemic philosophy and photography because here too the basis is the presupposition that everyone knows what it means to look. However, the claim of this book goes further than to say that photography is a special case of systemic thought, rather, the suggestion here is that thought that wishes to be non-systemic and to avoid the trap of subjective presupposition must start from photography.

IV. Representation and post-Enlightenment

Identity

So far, we have seen that the notion of representation is deeply intertwined with the deepest concerns of Western metaphysics. As a metaphysical construct, representation is both the guarantor of rational knowledge and the limit beyond which this knowledge cannot go (Colebrook 1999, p. 1). Fundamentally, re-presentation is happening when something already known and familiar is being re-affirmed. Representation therefore is a matter of reaffirming previously held beliefs, it is a question of discovering correspondence and identity with past experiences. For that reason, representation is the triumph of identity over difference.

In its simplest form, the problem of identity can be expressed in a formula $A = A$, where A can be anything you like, a table, a Stradivarius violin, a molecule of hydrogen, the universe or you. To say that the A is equal to A means that it is not, and can never be anything other than A. For that reason, $A = A$ means that $A \neq B$. The power of identity lies in its ability to divide the world into autonomous, separate and clearly defined entities: a table is a piece of furniture with a flat top and one or more legs for eating, writing or working, a violin is a stringed musical instrument played with a horsehair bow (Webster 2018). So far so clear cut, yet a problem immediately arises when we imagine a table with strings stretched over its surface, and a bow moved across them: while it is not a Stradivarius, can we be certain that the table is not at the same time a little bit of a violin? And what becomes of a violin when I place it on a leg and eat my dinner from it? If a table and a violin present such unsolvable epistemological problems, how much more complex the situation becomes when the A is not a piece of furniture but a person who is not-quite-white, not-quite-straight, not-quite-black and not-quite-fe/male. It is an irony of the identity argument, that one of the most sophisticated lines of reasoning against identity comes from Heidegger: who certainly was no stranger to indulging in a bit of racial purity himself.

Everywhere, wherever and however we are related to beings of every kind, we find identity making its claim on us. If this claim were not made ... there would then also not be any

science. For if science could not be sure in advance of the identity of its object in each case, it could not be what it is ... Thus, what is successful and fruitful about scientific knowledge is everywhere based on something useless.

(Heidegger 2002, pp. 26–27)

As Heidegger tersely explains, identity is simultaneously science's greatest achievement and the very limit beyond which it cannot go. Without identity there can be no science, as behind every definition lies the assumption that $A = A$. Equipped with this formula science can go about its business: water = H_2O , zebra = an African wild horse with black-and-white stripes and an erect mane, $E = MC^2$. Yet, the universal reach of the identity principle is also its fundamental weakness, for, while there is nothing that cannot be expressed as $A = A$, this all-powerful mechanism relies on the notion that the '=' (equals sign) represents an objectively given reality. For were it not the case, no scientific argument could make a claim for universal validity. Yet, what is the '=' if not a mental construct, something we can think of, but find it impossible to pinpoint its whereabouts. And if the '=' is something that exists only in our minds (and does it really mean the same thing for each and every one of us?), can we really trust it to base the whole edifice of science and culture on it? Could there be a chance that our mental image of '=' is simply wrong?

Belonging together

As was discussed in previous sections of this chapter, as a figure of metaphysical thinking identity always requires representation as its ground. In *Identity and Difference* Heidegger states that there cannot be a ground that is not externally given. His way of getting out of the requirement for a ground is to replace the logical marker of identity, the rational 'is' or the '=' (equals sign) with the notion of *belonging together*. (Heidegger 2002) In the two lectures *The Principle of Identity* and *The Onto-Theo-Logical constitution of Metaphysics* Heidegger proposes a way of thinking that attempts to overcome the limitations of Aristotelian, and subsequent Western metaphysics by questioning the principle of identity. Heidegger opposes a logic of relation *as* relation of man and being to the logic of identity. This sets him apart from the tradition of metaphysical thinking that considers thought and being as prior to identity. Heidegger takes as his point of departure a fragment from Parmenides: 'for the same perceiving (thinking) as well as being' (2002, p. 27). For Heidegger, Parmenides does not divide the what-is into the realm of the illusory and the realm of what truly is.

Even more suggestively, by shifting the problem from the question of identity to the question of belonging Heidegger signals the possibility of a clean break with metaphysical reasoning. Aristotelian metaphysics of identity put forward a philosophy of finitude. Heidegger breaks away from this form of thought by thinking of the encounter between thought and being as taking place in space, not in time.

Heidegger's lectures are important to the examination of photography undertaken here, because they allow a way out of the vocabulary that dominates writing on photography with such analytic concepts as the index (Krauss 1994), sign (Krauss 1985), ideology (Burgin 1987), lack (Burgin 1996), and identity (Tagg 1993). What these diverse concepts have in common is that they belong to systems of thought premised on rational logic, representation, semiology and anthropology which all founded on the philosophy of identity. By focusing only on what can be re-presented and communicated through photography, photography criticism operates as a closed system premised on the visibility of photographic representation. These systems are unable to account for that which is non-identical, singular, obscure, hidden, latent, non-

communicative and timeless. Heidegger's criticism of metaphysical thinking is a particularly apt starting point for a discussion of photography precisely because, as we have seen, photography is generally understood as the visual embodiment of the basic concepts of metaphysical thinking: representation, identity, negation (lack) and subjectivity.

Heidegger's critique of the Principle of Identity

In his critique of metaphysics, Heidegger's starting point is Aristotle's principle of identity also known as the principle of non-contradiction that states $A=A$. Aristotle says:

But still, it is possible to demonstrate by refutation even that the denial of the principle of non-contradiction is impossible, if only the disputant speaks of something. If he speaks of nothing, it is ridiculous to look for a rational discourse (*logos*) with someone who has rational discourse about nothing, in so far as he does not have it; for in so far as he lacks rational discourse, such a person makes himself like a vegetable.

(Irwin 1990, p. 182)

An important aspect of this principle is that it prefigures a notion of linear and chronological time: two different objects cannot be the same object because two objects cannot inhabit the same space at the same time. Aristotelian logic is situated within and based upon the physical world. However, once the laws of the physical world are challenged (through art, technology or science) this logic falters and the law of non-contradiction does not seem to apply. Non-representational art, Einstein's theory of relativity and the internet all offer well known scenarios that contradict the principle of identity. This book submits that photography is another one of the scenarios where the law of non-contradiction does not apply because it suggests a form of logic based on repetition and self-replication.

Identity is such a basic assumption of rational thinking that it forms part of most theories of photography. It seems the most natural thing in the world to suggest that an image is in some way identical to a reality that is external to it. Heidegger says of the principle of identity that it is considered 'the highest principle of thought' (Heidegger 2002, p. 23), by which he means metaphysical thought that takes *logos* as its ground. The original formula $A=A$ is an expression of the grounding of being in logic, it is the mediation of existence with the tools of thought that internalised the language of scientific reasoning. Heidegger's way of stepping out of metaphysics is by substituting the '=' with the belonging together of A and A in which he stresses the *together* over the belonging:

'Principle of identity' means now: a spring demanded by the essence of identity because it needs that spring if the *belonging* together of man and Being is to attain the essential light of the appropriation.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 39)

In the introduction to the text Joan Stambaugh comments on Heidegger's move to emphasise its strategy to move beyond dialectics through the shift from *together* to *belonging*:

If the element of *together* in belonging-together is emphasized, we have the metaphysical concept of identity which orders the manifold into a unity mediated by synthesis. This unity forms a synthetic totality of the world with God or Being as the ground, as the first cause and as the highest being. But if the element of *belonging* in belonging together is

emphasized, we have, thinking and Being held apart and at the same time held together (not fitted together) in the Same. To come to an understanding of the *belonging* together of man and Being, we must leave metaphysical thinking which thinks Being exclusively as the cause of beings and thinks beings primarily as what is caused. We must simply leap out of it. Thus the principle of (Satz) of identity becomes a leap (Satz) out of metaphysics.

(Heidegger 2002, pp. 12–13)

By emphasising *together* over *belonging* Heidegger escapes the grounding of his system in identity (belonging is still too close to rational, dialectical thought of Aristotelian metaphysics). ‘A’ *together with* ‘A’ opens up a groundless surface unframed by logical reasoning. In belonging *together*, the emphasis is on a relationship between things rather than on the dividing line between them. The binary logic of yes–no or true–false is replaced with a fuzzy logic concerned with degrees of belonging. The evacuation of equivalence does not bring chaos and anarchy but puts forward a different form of logic that does not reject identity but situates it as singularity within the realm of disjuncture and difference.

By positing ‘belonging *together*’ as the primordial relation, Heidegger shifts the focus of identity from ‘I’ to ‘we’ in which identity is understood as a movement of difference oscillating between the two, not belonging to the one. In this way Heidegger breaks away from dialectical thinking that aims for the unification of opposites through negation. In ‘Difference and Repetition’ Deleuze illustrates the forming of an identity through belonging:

Lightning, for example, distinguishes itself from the black sky but must also trail it behind, as though it were distinguishing itself from that which does not distinguish itself from it. It is as if the ground rose to the surface without ceasing to be ground.

(Deleuze 2004, p. 36)

The ‘identity’ of the lightning is not found in its separation from the sky but in its belonging to that from which it is separate, ‘the distinguished opposes something which cannot distinguish itself from it but continues to espouse that which divorces it’ (Deleuze 2004, p. 36). The relation of belonging takes precedence over that which is related: ‘no longer representing belonging in terms of the unity of the together, but rather of experiencing this together in terms of belonging’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 29). Heidegger’s shift from rational identity to ‘belonging’ as an expression of the human condition is a move away from truth as representation to a form of truth that is discovered in the original oneness in which thinking and being are not opposed to each other but form a unity.

The origin of truth

The emphasis on the *together* in ‘belonging together’ shifts the focus from individual entities and fixed identities towards impersonal and pre-individual relation of belonging. This move allows Heidegger to leap away from Kant’s transcendental idealism and Hegel’s speculative logic by destroying the subject–object dualism and deriving knowledge and experience not from the external difference between subject and object but from the internal difference of the subject from itself (Bryant 2008, p. 35). Central to this manoeuvre is the understanding of truth not as a logical certainty but as unconcealment. The Greek word for unconcealment is ἀλήθεια (*alethia*). Heidegger explains the etymology as the ‘un-covering’ (of truth): ‘*un*-concealedness indicates that truth is wrenched from concealment and is in conflict with it. The primordial

essence of truth is conflictual' (Heidegger 1998, p. 26). Heidegger is concerned here to signal that *aletheia* is not the truth of a logical argument nor can it be translated as the Latin *veritas*:

For the main feature of the essence of truth in the modern metaphysics of Schelling and Hegel is never *αλήθεια* in the sense of unconcealedness but is certainty in the sense of *certitudo*, which, since Descartes, stamps the essence of *veritas*.

(Heidegger 1998, p. 26)

The understanding of *αλήθεια* for Heidegger is connected with *tēchnē* and *poesis* as the processes of differentiation through which the truth of belonging of beings and being is being uncovered. In *Being and Time* Heidegger elaborates:

To translate this word as 'truth' and, above all, to define the expression conceptually in theoretical ways, is to cover up the meaning of what the Greeks made 'self-evidently' basic for the terminological use of *αλήθεια* as a pre-philosophical way of understanding it.

(Heidegger 1962, p. 262)

As several commentators observed, Heidegger's understanding of *αλήθεια* depends on unusual translation. Etymologically *αλήθεια* is the not-hidden, the uncovered. Truth for Heidegger means the uncovering of Being (Okrent 2005, p. 470).

The *technē* of unconcealment is in the belonging together of human being and Being as a process of making, constructing and building. However, this togetherness should not be understood as a consistency, resemblance, or similarity for all three require a prior condition or arbitration, and in any case judgements of resemblance can only be conducted in the light of day, under the auspice of a logical procedure. Togetherness in Heidegger's sense is pre-individual, necessarily phenomenological relation that makes the realisation of being possible through providing a space for action. Therefore, Heidegger insists that being must be found in togetherness:

We stand outside of science. Instead, we stand before a tree in bloom, for example – and the tree stands before us. The tree faces us. The tree and we meet one another, as the tree stands there and we stand face to face with it. As we are in this relation of one to the other and before the other the three and we *are*. This face-to-face meeting is not, then, one of these 'ideas' buzzing about in our heads.

(Heidegger 2004, p. 41)

The double movement folded in unconcealment creates a feedback loop that alternates hiding and uncovering in an infinite motion that defies the finitude and certainty of truth. This self-referential circuitry of unconcealment allows Heidegger to question the presuppositions of value-driven reasoning and the validity of teleological unfolding of knowledge. The fundamental questions unconcealment aims to collapse while simultaneously drawing them into focus are concerned with the ontological distinctions between space and body, the ability of language to represent and the nature of the world as a knowable substance (Dreyfus and Wrathall 2005, p. 10). Shestov seems to be in agreement with Heidegger that truth is impoverished by being reduced to knowledge, when he says:

Everyone has been convinced that man needs knowledge more than anything else in the world, that knowledge is the only source of truth, and especially – I emphasise this

particularly and insist upon it – that knowledge furnishes us with universal and necessary truths which embrace all being, truths from which man cannot escape and from which there is consequently no need to escape.

(Shestov 1968, p. 7)

Flash of logos

The reframing of truth in a way that brings knowledge and representation into question allows to liberate photography from the framework of representation and to consider it not as a rational representation and signification but as a modality of truth that is being unconcealed through the rhythmic recurrence of intensities and the difference between fragments. Read in this way, photography's claim to truth is not to be found in the identity between an object and an image but in something that prefigures this correspondence by creating the conditions that make representation possible. According to this interpretation the being of photography is not in the exposure to light, but in the concealment that contains a relation. No doubt, light has a complex role to play in photography as it relates all images back to the notions of trace, imprint and representation. Clarifying Heidegger's relevance to photography, François Laruelle's makes the point of distinguishing between light as 'flash of logos' and light of 'Heideggerian arrival':

The flash of Logos, of the event or axiomatic decision is the Greek model of thought, its circularity, merely differed, effectively its two strips crossed in the interior form of a figure eight and even if the topology arrives in order to form the whole of the subject of the circle of philosophy [...] A deconstruction of the philosophical flash is necessary as well as the deconstruction of the absolute fact of reason of the factum, because the flash of logos and the rational factum are the same structure. Yet these doublets are at worst, these 'arrivals' (Heidegger) at best, are philosophically considered as completed and closed by Being or 'metaphysics, they are negatively and not positively thought as effects of onto-vectorial insurrection.'

(Laruelle 2015, pp. 37–8)

However, what gets lost in the privileging of light as the expression of rational mediation is the ontological difference as the essence of photography. For Heidegger truth, understood as unconcealment, *aletheia*, is the first casualty of metaphysics. Truth cannot be discovered by scientific methods and logical reasoning because the law of identity is being taken as the ground of inquiry. Truth cannot be discovered because it withdraws into darkness, difference, nothingness. Deleuze helps to clarify this point: 'Difference is not diversity. Diversity is given, but difference is that by which the given is given, that by which the given is given as diverse' (Deleuze 2004, p. 280). Diversity is that which appears in the photograph, it is the pluralism of the Aristotelian categories, the variations in quantities, qualities, position, genus, species. Difference is that which makes all this diversity manifest itself. In a photographic schema diversity is equal to content, but difference could be thought of as the repetition of the mechanical procedure that produces copy, after copy, after copy. For Heidegger, as for Deleuze the deconstruction of representation is necessary because it allows to get beyond identity and equivalence. Deleuze says 'we are faced with the alternative between undifferentiated groundlessness and imprisoned singularities' (Deleuze 2004, p. 122). Heidegger argues that before an image of a thing can be made, before identity can be established there has to be an enframing that makes it possible to make a statement that coincides with reality. In *The Question Concerning Technology* *Ge-stell* is translated as 'enframing' – the overwhelming arrival of technology of the

modern age. 'But where have we strayed to? We are questioning concerning technology, and we have arrived now at *Aletheia*, at revealing. What has the essence of technology to do with revealing? The answer: everything' (Heidegger 1977a, p. 182). In photography, this 'enframing' is the mode of production that creates self-replicating repetitions.

This imperative for veridical statements is for Heidegger the essential task of thinking (Heidegger 2004). Logical reason as manifested in modern technology is the ground from which thought must leap backwards to the original relation of beings and being. Heidegger believes that in our age, this primordial truth is simultaneously revealed and concealed by modern technology. The ambivalent status of truth is mirrored in the ambiguity of technology itself: on the one hand technology continuously produces new tools that order and dominate nature, endangering the truth of the essential belonging of humans to their world. But at the same time technology, understood as the poetics of making, is a creative force that can reveal the true essence of the age (Heidegger 1977a, pp. 13, 32–33).

This recursive ambiguity that causes technology to oscillate between the greatest danger and the saving grace is drawn out of the changeability of being itself through history. Early Greek thought experienced being as unconcealment which is not only a statement about the world but also about *technē*; a method for knowing things. *Technē* is different from the know-how and the craftsmanship of material production, it embodies the poetics of uncovering:

What is decisive in *technē* does not lie at all in making and manipulating nor in the using of means, but rather in the aforementioned revealing. It is as revealing, and not as manufacturing, that *technē* is bringing-forth.

(Heidegger 1977a, p. 13)

This complex understanding of technology as combining skill (*techne*) and art (*poiēsis*) bears on the rethinking of photography not as an image but as an event of coming together of self-replication and expression which accomplishes the step out of metaphysics within the realm of the visual.

Perdurance: Heidegger's move beyond dialectic

Liberating photography from representation means not simply generating new thoughts about light, framing, digitalisation, etc. but also proposing a modality of practice that is not tethered to oppositional, dialectical thinking. At least since Plato's claim that light is the foundation of true knowledge, the Western philosophical canon has identified it as the source of universal wisdom. It is this implied dialectical connection between physical light and rationality that assigns to photography the role of a truthful and reliable witness.

This section will lay down the foundations for a non-dialectical understanding of the photographic by first exploring the philosophical underpinnings of the role of representation and its relationship with the 'is'. This will be accomplished through Heidegger's concept of difference as 'the differentiation of overwhelming and arrival ..., the perdurance (Austag) of the two in *unconcealing keeping in concealment*' (Heidegger 2002, p. 65). Contrary to Hegel, who sets up a dialectical relation of sublation between being and nothing, Heidegger defines the 'is' as the simultaneous holding together and the keeping apart of Being and beings. Perdurance for Heidegger is the event of exposure in which beings are distinguished from Being while at the same time espoused by it. It is an event of separateness and togetherness that defies logical expression as it sustains both identity ($A=A$) and difference ($A\neq A$). In this way Heidegger overcomes the

dialectical imperative of sublating the one in the other. However, it will be inaccurate to understand perdurance as the co-existence of opposites, as opposition itself is a formal category that is dissolved by difference. Heidegger's challenge is to step back out of thought that operates through categories in order to get closer to 'thinking' where all categories are dissolved:

In our attempt to think of the difference as such, we do not make it disappear; rather, we follow it to its essential origin. On our way there we think of the perdurance of overwhelming and arrival. This is the matter of thinking, thought closer to rigorous thinking – closer by the distance of one step back: Being thought in terms of the difference.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 65)

Fractals and other monsters

One of the difficulties in comprehending Heidegger's notion of difference is in the way Heidegger disposes of the static conception of logic and substitutes it with something altogether more fuzzy and yet not less productive, as this step out of rationality allows for movement, noise, irregularity and chaos to enter the 'picture'. In this context, Heidegger's 'step out' of thinking can be usefully compared to Benoit Mandelbrot taking a 'step out' of Euclidian geometry in order to get away from the perfection of ideal geometric shapes and closer to those forms that classical geometry leaves aside as formless:

I claim that many patterns of Nature are so irregular and fragmented, that, compared to *Euclid*... Nature exhibits not simply a higher degree but an altogether different level of complexity... The existence of these patterns challenges us to study those forms that Euclid leaves aside as being 'formless,'... Mathematicians have disdained this challenge, however, and have increasingly chosen to flee from nature by devising theories unrelated to anything we can see or feel.

(Mandelbrot 1982, p. 1)

According to Mandelbrot, the aim of geometry should not be the pursuit of pure and abstract truth (identity between shapes), but the mapping of the irregular topographies and fragmented patterns that make the actual shapes of trees, clouds, mountains and coastlines. Mandelbrot's geometry is not a refinement of the standard Euclidian geometry but a radical departure from rational logic in order to make room for infinite or undefinable values and for 'statistical self-similarity':

Geographical curves are so involved in their detail that their lengths are often infinite or more accurately, undefinable. [...] Seacoast shapes are examples of highly involved curves with the property that – in a statistical sense – each portion can be considered a reduced-scale image of the whole.

(Mandelbrot 1967, p. 636)

An image based on the principles of classical geometry is orderly and hierarchical, representing idealised objects in a state of perfect symmetry and harmony. Fractal geometry on the other hand uses chance and statistical distribution, and disregards entirely the laws of perspectival representation, proportion and regularity. It is the destruction of form, symmetry and hierarchical order that brought these new structures into the sphere of 'pathology' and 'monstrosity'. As Mandelbrot explains,

classical mathematics had its roots in the regular geometric structures of Euclid and the continuously evolving dynamics of Newton. Modern mathematics began with Cantor's set theory and Peano's space-filling curve. Historically, the revolution was forced by the discovery of mathematical structures that did not fit the patterns of Euclid and Newton. These new structures were regarded as 'pathological,' ... as a 'gallery of monsters,' kin to the cubist painting and atonal music that were upsetting established standards of taste in the arts about the same time.

(Mandelbrot 1982, p. 3)

For Deleuze too, difference is always monstrous precisely because it destroys forms, relations and hierarchies:

It is as if ground rose to the surface, without ceasing to be ground. There is cruelty, even monstrosity, on both sides of this struggle against an elusive adversary, in which the distinguished opposes something which cannot distinguish itself from it but continues to espouse that which divorces it.

(Deleuze 2004, p. 36)

Difference is produced in the rising of the ground to the surface without losing the ground, it is the same gesture that Heidegger describes simply as 'Being thought in terms of the difference' (Heidegger 2002, p. 65). On the face of it a paradoxical thought, for Being is the 'is' and not difference, but for Heidegger the 'is' is a construct of the mathematically oriented scientific consciousness that represents Being as the 'is' and in so doing seeing nothing but its own rules of representation. Like Euclidian geometry, the 'is' operates with rules that represent reality as an idealised, symmetrical and hierarchical form. Getting to Being in Heidegger's sense requires stepping out of the 'is' into the unfamiliar territory of presence and belonging together. However, the destruction of the 'is' does not imply that irrationality and chaos writ large, rather, it means that Being unfolds as an event that grounds itself in appropriation:

Being transits [that], comes unconcealingly over [that] which arrives as something of itself unconcealed only by that coming-over. Arrival means: to keep concealed in unconcealedness – to abide present in this keeping – to be a being.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 64)

Heidegger suggests that the way out of the 'is' passes through the event of appropriation which lies not only outside of representation but also outside of normative, scientific certainty. Language is the mode of appropriation that pushes beyond knowledge, through which being (Dasein) can overcome representation and discover its active being in the voice of being that speaks through language: 'The event of appropriation is that realm, vibrating within itself, through which man and Being reach each other in their nature, achieve their active nature by losing those qualities with which metaphysics has endowed them' (Heidegger 2002, p. 37). However, it is not easy to hear the self-vibrating voice of Being that speaks in language. As Heidegger explains it requires going beyond the 'is' into the domain of the poetic:

Neither the 'is' nor the word attain to thinghood, to Being, nor does the relation between 'is' and the word, the word whose task it is to give an 'is' in each given instance.

(Heidegger 1982, p. 87)

Therefore:

What the poetic experience with language says of the world implies the relation between the 'is' which itself is not, and the world which is in the same case of not being and being.

(Heidegger 1982, p. 87)

Heidegger proposes a reversal of the normative relation between 'man' as the speaking subject and speech as the spoken object. In this reversal, language ceases to be a technology in the hands of man and its poetic essence as 'the house of being' is coming to the fore. As Oberst explains,

As language itself bears the secret of its beginning and continued development, it is language that has to be questioned about the force of its evolution. For Heidegger this force, source and origin is being itself.

(Oberst 2009, p. 4)

Reversal of indexicality

A similar reversal in relation to photography will require the re-evaluation of photographic indexicality, as the equivalence between the image and the referent. Following Heidegger's methodology, it will require suggesting that the fatefulness and the similitude of the photographic image conceal an 'event of appropriation' in which the photographic is released from its everydayness, and difference – rather than identity – is able to rise to the surface. Instead of thinking of the photographic image as something 'given' to perception, a 'step out' of the 'is' of representation betokens that there is an 'unseen' image that suggests that an image is not solely the subject of 'viewing', that the image reveals the essential origin of difference as the ground of representation. It also suggests that the *poiēsis* of photography is directly linked to exposure as the repeatable and unrepresentable action in which image and being belong together. In the context of photography, the 'unseen image' can be specifically and concretely located in the notion of the latent image. As will be discussed below, the latent image is the invisible image left on the light-sensitive surface by exposure:

No impression can be seen, not even the slightest beginning of the picture, and yet the picture already exists there in all its perfection, but in a perfectly invisible state...

(Frizot 1998, p. 61)

The invisible (latent) state of the photographic image is generally overlooked in photographic theory, it is literary its blind spot, however for this book it is an indication that exposure pushes material perception beyond itself, into its origin as difference, as the unconcealment kept in concealment. By using the photographic process against itself, the latent image allows to leap out of the 'is' of representation towards an event of appropriation. The latent image permits to rethink photography as a step-back out of the visual image into the event of difference that underwrites representation. However, this leap into the 'hidden' or latent event that precedes representation is not enough to establish photography as fractal and mimetic surface, as the latent image is still the transcendent reversal of the visible.

If the latent image is considered as the *is* of photography, it suggests that there are two temporal registers involved in the production of the image: the first is the chronological time

in which the image is marked by its connection to past events or situations. It is the biological time of decaying bodies in which the image carries a timestamp of the past that marks its place along the infinite straight line that stretches between the past and the future; and second, it is the time of the latent image. Time of the event, the 'now' which is outside of subjectivity, (the event that must be bracketed out by subjectivity in order to constitute itself). It is the present which is constantly divided into past and future and is outside linear time, immeasurable and inhuman. In *Logic of Sense* Deleuze defines two temporal series: Chronos and Aion:

Inside Chronos, the present is in some manner corporeal. [...] The present measures out the action of bodies and causes among themselves. [...] [Aion is] [t]he pure and measureless becoming of qualities threatens the order of qualified bodies from within. Bodies have lost their measure and are now but simulacra. The past and the future, as unleashed forces, take their revenge, in one and the same abyss which threatens the present and everything that exists.

(Deleuze 1990, pp. 186–7)

These two regimes of temporality appear first in Nietzsche's *Thus spoke Zarathustra* where the time of Aion is linked to the eternal return:

'See this moment!' I continued. 'From this gateway Moment a long eternal lane stretches *backward*: behind us lies an eternity. Must not whatever *can* already have passed this way before? Must not whatever *can* happen, already have happened, been done, passed by before?' [...] And this slow spider that creeps in the moonlight, and this moonlight itself, and I and you in the gateway whispering together, whispering of eternal things – must not all of us have been here before?

(Nietzsche 2006, p. 126)

Two regimes of the image therefore: the visible image of which Nancy says, 'The image is what takes the thing out of its simple presence and brings it to pres-ence, to *praes-entia*, to being-out-in-front-of-itself, turned toward the outside [...] Thus the image is, essentially, "monstrative" or "monstrant"' (Nancy 2005, p. 21). And the invisible, latent image which is motionless, where nothing ever happens, time of stasis and of surfaces without depth. The latent image is pre-individual because it is located in the temporal space of the event, before the emergence of subjectivity and the concomitant distinction between subject and object (Lecerle 2002).

For Heidegger the event of arrival is grounded in language as the mode of appropriation through which the nature of life itself is organised as *poiēsis* and *aletheia*. However, there is an argument to be made that in the age of technology and instantaneity the 'is' finds its political and ethical articulation not only in language but crucially in the technical image, and particularly in the image of the mobile multimedia. As Olkowski says:

The question of the order of the image is also and more importantly a question about the nature of life itself as politics and perception come, to a greater and greater degree, to be organized by technicity, an organization which functions so as to eliminate pleasure and pain by abandoning affective, temporal life.

(Olkowski 2003, p. 36)

Latent image as the event of photography

Exposure of many minutes in the camera produced no visible image, but Daguerre discovered that a 'latent' image formed in the silver iodide layer by the action of light could be revealed by treating the plate with the fumes of heated mercury.

(Coe 1976, p. 16)

When photography is thought of in the context of 'visual culture' it is unavoidably considered either as a figure of critique, as content or as an image of something, as a mimesis, which is one of the oldest definitions of the image in the Western tradition. In each case it is the visual that is the focus of theory and the invisible, the latent is summarily absent. As will be discussed in one of the following chapters, the latent image is the invisible image of photography which, by evading visibility and representation allows access to that which lies beneath the 'contents' of the image. The technical description of the latent image as an invisible image produced by the exposure of the film to light suggests that it is an image that cannot be understood in representational terms as verisimilitude. While the question of the latent image will be taken up and developed in a later chapter of this book, here the concern is with an image that has no appearance, that is, strictly speaking, nothing. It is indeed regarded as 'nothing' by photography theory inasmuch as it has nothing to say about it. While this 'nothing' also functions as a kind of erasure of the border between presence and absence, between the image and the thing it should not be understood as the transcendental condition of all art. It is interesting to quote Wall on this point,

To us, art remains 'constantly invisible', hidden, *en deçà*, and *autre nuit*. But we are drawn to it, nonetheless. When the object is doubled and neutralized in the image, when the image withdraws the object from the world, and when the object disappears into its own imagen – then it exercises its fascination, its 'powerless power'.

(Wall 1999, p. 112)

Rather, the latent image has to be understood as the site where the transition between the thing and the image is taking place. The latent image is therefore not the object nor is it the image but the 'third space' where the encounter between the thing and the image is taking place. The necessity of the latent image for the production of the photograph indicates that the kinship between the thing and the image must pass through radical difference.

Imaging and translation

As the latent image is distinctly under-theorised in photographic literature it is important to listen to those authors who seek to challenge and explicate the common understanding of mimesis. This is because the latent image is the middle point between thing and image and its subtraction from the discourse of photography not only makes it doubly hidden by also reinforces the belief in identity, a belief which this book seeks to challenge by contrasting it with the event of difference.

Walter Benjamin considers this difference between the original and the image as the materiality of translation:

To grasp the genuine relationship between an original and a translation requires an investigation analogous to the argumentation by which a critique of cognition would have to prove the impossibility of an image theory. There is a matter of showing that in cognition

there could be no objectivity, not even a claim for it, if it dealt with images of reality; here it can be demonstrated that no translation would be possible if in its ultimate essence it strove for likeness to the original.

(Benjamin 1999, p. 73)

Benjamin complicates the notion of translation by showing that translation as such has no objectivity as translation itself cannot be revealed. There is no language in which translation can speak, it has no properties of its own, for that reason it is numb. While languages are imbued with the ability to represent things, ideas and concepts, translation itself must remain invisible and selfless. However, this is not to say that it is immaterial. Translation is not an object but communication in its 'embryonic or intensive form'.

Following Benjamin's explication, the latent image is neither a visual image, nor is it an object. It is the manifestation of kinship between the object and the image in its intensive form. However, this kinship (Benjamin) or belonging *together* (Heidegger) is hidden, so the only thing that is shown in the latent image is what is concealed. The latent image reveals only its own latency, but this latency is the possibility and the condition of communication.

Following Benjamin's thought on translation it is possible to suggest that the encounter between the object and the image in the liminal space of the latent image points toward a vastly different type of mimesis to the one associated with imitation and copy. In the latent image the subject (the thing) is present only as a withdrawal, it is lost to vision and unavailable to the eye as even the shortest exposure to light destroys it. However, the thing is not absent from the latent image, it is present as the delay or the interval. In other words, the latent image is the kind of immanent present from which both past and present emanate yet it remains singular and undivided. It is non-identical in relation to the object and to the thing, and yet it maintains some kind of cohesion in the form of an encounter that is taking place within the invisible space of the latent image. This encounter as Benjamin says is 'intensive', it is an interplay between two languages: the language of things and the language of images. The latent image is the dynamic interrelation between objects and images manifest as absence or 'nonrelation'. As Massumi explains:

If meaning is a process of translation from one substance to another of a different order and back again, what it moves across is an unbridgeable abyss of fracturing. If meaning is the in-between of content and expression, it is nothing more (nor less) than the being of their 'nonrelation'.

(Massumi 1992, p. 16)

The problem of linking a thing with an image is not limited to photography. Lyotard teaches that: 'thought, cognition, ethics, politics, history or being, depending on the case, are in play when one phrase is linked onto another' (Lyotard 1988, pp. xii–xiii). What Lyotard has in his sights are the doctrines of Western metaphysics that privilege linear, stable and fixed relationship between concepts and forms of expression. These philosophies tend to be hierarchical and to posit a clear relationship between meaning and truth by taking representation as the ontological basis of thought: Lyotard exemplifies these by Leibniz's 'Characteristica Universalis' on the one hand and by Russell's logic on the other. Both these systems are unable to account for situations in which two entities are linked not through identity but through irresolvable difference. Contra these metaphysical models Lyotard enlists two alternatives which he considers to be 'epilogues to modernity and prologues to an honourable postmodernity' (Lyotard 1984b), these are the upshots of the unrepresentable that resist the foreclosure of difference by

technologies of information and commodification. The first is the Kantian 'sublime' as developed in the 'Critique of Judgment', the second is Wittgenstein's 'Philosophical Investigations' and the posthumous writings. It is significant that both Kant and Wittgenstein are proponents of representational thinking in their earlier texts: Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* is a work of logical positivism that continues with the tradition of Russell's logic, and Kant's 'Critique of Pure Reason' institutes representation as the intermediary between sensation and reason.

2 Time

I. Photographic sublime

Fractal self-replication

The shift from an image to an event is a strategy employed by this book to avoid the circular reasoning that takes representation as the ground of the image, because in this kind of reasoning representation is already written into the discourse, taken as given, and manifested in the formula $A=A$ (the principle of identity, see Chapter 2). To avoid falling into the trap of representation, this book suggests that the primary feature of photography is not the content of the image, but its fractal self-replication. In the previous chapter it was suggested that the representation of reality is secondary to the fractured and fractal a-radicality that gives photography its non-linear and non-hierarchical structure. The photograph, understood as a slice, as a repeatable and replicable fractal, allows to move beyond the binaries of subject and object, reality and image, form and content, because it provides a way to achieve a double feat: to get out of representation as the totalising picture of reality on the one hand while on the other not to lose the ability to talk about the peculiar truth of the photograph. 'Truth' here means not a faithful reproduction of something that is pre-given, but the movement of self-replication, which is manifest in every photograph. A photograph is not only a picture of something, but also a fragment in a potentially infinite chain of replicas. This duality of the photograph as both an image of something and a copy of itself suggests that the photographic image participates in two kinds of veridical statements. One that is based on correspondence between an image and a thing, and a second that is based on the eternal recurrence of the copy. This second form of truth allows one to encounter photography not as a representation but as an experience of repetition. For Foucault the breaking away from transcendental teleology of representation is necessary for the constitution of an ethical self:

It deprives us of our continuities; it dissipates that temporal identity in which to exorcise the discontinuities of history; it breaks the thread of transcendental teleologies; and where anthropological thought once questioned man's being or subjectivity, it now bursts open the other, and the outside. In this sense, the diagnosis does not establish the fact of our identity by the play of distinctions. It establishes that we are difference, that our reason is the difference of discourses, our history the difference of times, our selves the difference of masks. That difference, far from being the forgotten and recovered origin, is this dispersion that we are and make.

(Foucault 1989b, p. 131)

In other words, understood as fragment or fractal, photography is a site of expressive, dynamic, singular, and non-individual events which do not require falling back on the totalising diagram of representation and metaphysics. Golding describes the move out of representational philosophy as a gathering of a number of philosophical trajectories. These influences include Spinoza, Hume, Nietzsche, Leibniz, Heidegger, the Stoics, Carroll, Bacon and Foucault.

What they had in common was an analytic accounting for cultural reinvention beyond the usual binaries of good and evil... a way to account for the truth of culture as that which must emerge from ungrounded 'difference', a 'difference' that was something to be grasped, invented – that is to say, *inhabited* – in all its inglorious manifestations, productions, changes without recourse to a totalising picture of reality.

(Golding 2009, p. 141)

To the extent that photography is a discourse of truth, it is not to be found in the visual resemblance and not in what Foucault names 'old categories of the Negative (law, limit, castration, lack, lacuna)' (in: Deleuze and Guattari 1996, p. viii), but in the way the photographic image operates as a fragment. This understanding of the fragment as a plurality of a-radical events is different from the way fragment is understood in normative, rational logic where the identity of the fragment is determined by its self-reflexive relation to the whole.

The understanding of photography as self-replicating fragment allows to revisit the question of photographic time. In this chapter it will be suggested that event-image is not an archive of time, but it *is* time. This is the understanding of time not as linear chronology but as the event that Lyotard develops by highlighting the difference between the post-modern sublime and Kantian sublime. This book seeks to engage Lyotard's understanding of the event with the aid of the *sublime* of photography and explore how the photographic image allows for a conception of a time that is not archival and historical but on that embraces indeterminacy and fractality.

Modern and postmodern sublime

There are three ways by which the sublime is defined as an ethical experience. First, Edmund Burke conceived of the sublime as a bodily and spiritual experience of horror that is being mitigated by the sense of one's safety. The sublime is what happens when the drive for self-preservation clashes with fear that results from encountering something mighty, confusing, and threatening and is mitigated through the feeling of physical security.

Second, Immanuel Kant, in *Critique of Judgment* revisits the question of representation (*Vorstellung*), that was central to the *Critique of Pure Reason* as activity of the mind, but he approaches it in terms of aesthetic judgement. The experience of the sublime reaffirms human nature as rational through its ability to conceive of immeasurable formlessness (Kant 2007a, pp. 75–96). The subject determines him/herself by clamming superiority over nature. In this way Kant attempts to bridge the gap between theoretical and practical reason by placing the aesthetic experience of the sublime as a mediating mechanism between the sensible and the analytical. Kant distinguishes between mathematically sublime and dynamically sublime but asserts that in both cases it is the power of reason as the supersensible force that triumphs over nature (Kant 2007a, p. 145).

Third, in *The Post-Modern Condition: A report on Knowledge*, Jean-Francois Lyotard identifies a shift between the modern, i.e. Kantian, and the postmodern sublime: in modernist

aesthetics the sublime is explored at the level of content leaving the form of the artwork intact; while the content can be transgressive, the form is reassuringly traditional. In postmodernism however, the denial of solace is precisely the political point of the sublime, as it is the identity – manifest through representation – that is being shattered through the operation of the post-modern image, putting forward ‘the unrepresentable in presentation itself’ (Lyotard 1984b, p. 81).

Lyotard’s view of postmodernity highlights the fractal nature of the unrepresentable experience that refuses to become part of a totalising system or be subjected to the operations of rational logic that establishes some kind of reciprocity between reason and experience. Lyotard seems to imagine a work of art that is constantly striving to expose the diagram of its own foundation and push through its limits by perpetually using the work against itself and by undermining its own mode of production. While the Kantian sublime still holds on to the certainty and clarity of form, it is this very clarity that is not self-evident and problematised in the postmodern discourse.

Lyotard draws further distinction between the Kantian sublime and the postmodern sublime, whereby in Kant the sublime exposes the failure of representation to reach out to ideas that cannot be represented, such as ‘the idea of the world’ and ‘the idea of a simple (that which cannot be broken-down and decomposed)’ (Lyotard 1984b, 78). This encounter with the immeasurable and the irrational is sublime not because of the magnitude of the experience but because it causes subjectivity to realise the error of subject/object relations. In the sublime, subjectivity is dissolved. Neither language nor visual representation can encompass these moments of total dissolution of identity, which for Lyotard makes the sublime into a political problem, for it raises the question of accounting for the non-identical, minoritarian, culturally or politically unrepresented.

For Lyotard, the ‘postmodern sublime’ is symptomatic to the sense of crisis that envelops both the contents and the structures of knowledge, i.e. an epistemological crisis caused by breakdown and loss of trust in the foundations of rational knowledge. In the sublime, reason is reaching its limit and entering a domain of the incomprehensible, the monstrous and colossal. In our own time, the crisis of knowledge in all its forms is manifest in the current dismantling of the institutions of liberal democracy, against the background of climate emergency:

The postmodern [sublime] would be that which, in the modern, puts forward the unrepresentable in presentation itself; that which denies itself the solace of good forms, the consensus of a taste which would make it possible to share collectively the nostalgia for the unattainable; that which searches for new presentations, not in order to enjoy them but in order to impart a stronger sense of the unrepresentable. A postmodern artist or writer is in the position of a philosopher: the text he writes, the work he produces are not in principle governed by preestablished rules, and they cannot be judged according to a determining judgment, by applying familiar categories to the text or to the work.

(Lyotard 1984b, p. 81)

Photographic sublime

The idea of the sublime as the manifestation of the unrepresentable appears in Kant’s ‘Critique of Judgment’ where he says:

One can describe the sublime thus: it is an object (of nature) the representation of which determines the mind to think of the unattainability of nature as a presentation of ideas.

(Kant 2007a, p. 151)

Lyotard explains that the sublime dismantles individual experience, for it is antinomy to consciousness: ‘it is what consciousness cannot formulate, and even what consciousness forgets in order to compose itself’ (Lyotard 1984b, p. 197).

For Lyotard the sublime is:

what dismantles consciousness, what deposes consciousness, it is what consciousness cannot formulate, and even what consciousness forgets in order to constitute itself. What we do not manage to formulate is that something happens, *dass etwas geschieht*. Or rather, and more simply, that it happens ... *dass es geschieht*. Not a major event in the media sense, not even a small event. Just an occurrence.

(Lyotard 1984a, p. 197)

The sublime therefore dismantles the causal chain of representational thought by introducing the notion of an event that stands in opposition to representation, accountability and countable [compatible] use of time (Lyotard 1988, p. xvi).

For Lyotard, the postmodern sublime is symptomatic to the sense of crisis that engulfs both the contents and the structures of knowledge, i.e. an epistemological crisis that prises apart the foundations of rational knowledge models. For this reason, the postmodern sublime must be understood as an event that transcends the dualism and subjectivity of Cartesian thought. Theories of photography that emerge out of cultural studies and that confine their attentions to the visual fail to address the question of representation as it is being exposed by photography. As Heidegger shown in *The Age of the World Picture* the history of Western metaphysics is a history of the rise and the triumph of the subject that achieves its full expression with Descartes who broke with the tradition of representation as mimesis and resemblance and instituted instead a model of representation based on formal logical principles (Heidegger 1977a, p. 127). As Judowitz explains, the same principles are at the basis of Descartes’ notion of the subject which by implication means that philosophical thought as a whole is founded on representational principles.

For Lyotard, the ‘is’ is not a description or an event but the event-ness of the event: ‘Before asking questions about what it is and about its significance, before the *quid*, it must “first” so to speak “happen”, *quod*. That it happens “precedes”, so to speak, the question pertaining to what happens’ (Lyotard 1984a). In the context of the photographic image-event, putting the *quod* before the *quid* means deferring the content of the image and instead getting to grips with the event of the image happening. Conceived as an event, photography is both *quid* and *quod* as it is both the ‘what is happening’ (representation) and the ‘it is happening’ (exposure, the *now*). Furthermore, the *what* and the *is* are not co-present but suspended in a state of undecidability that is incompatible with permanence, fixity and stable identity.

Not by human hand

Photography has a long history of being linked with clarity and transparency and simplicity that are usually associated with machinic processes, which distinguish it from other modes of image production that depend on the talent, aptitude, and skill of an individual artist. As early 1844 Henry Fox Talbot pointed to the ability of photography to produce images without human intervention. The evacuation of human agent from the image undermined the role of the author or creator and pointed to the possibility of images produced solely by means of technology (Talbot 1969). However, Talbot’s position regarding the question of transparency of the photographic image is a complex one. For instance, Vered Maimon suggests that Talbot’s text

neither supports the view of photography as a mechanised copy nor as 'authentic' index but has to be understood as part of the discursive framework of the romantic historical tradition which recognises that any claims for truth are undermined by the constant change and the inevitable passage of time (Maimon 2008, pp. 314–325). Azoulay draws attention to the title of Talbot's book *Pencil of Nature* as an indicator of his desire to free photography from the burden of authorship by 'elimination of the human agent and presentation of photography as a medium for the production of images without human intervention' (Azoulay 2010).

II. A hole in time

The concept of linear time in Kant

As Lyotard's notion of the event is developed in direct reference to the notion of the sublime in Kant, it will be helpful to begin by briefly outlining Kant's epistemology. The Kantian Copernican turn at its most simple means that source of the laws of nature is in human understanding:

However exaggerated and absurd it may sound to say that the understanding is itself the source of the laws of nature, and hence of its formal unity, such an assertion is nevertheless correct and in accordance with the object, namely, experience. ... all empirical laws are only particular determinations of the pure laws of the understanding...

(Kant 2007b, p. 167)

According to Kant, objective reality is not pre-given, it is constructed by consciousness by setting up causal relations between events. At the same time, the inner life of consciousness itself is not subject to the same laws of causality and therefore distinguishable from objective reality. As Kant explains:

We have representations within us, and can become conscious of them; but however far that consciousness may extend, and however accurate and exact it may be, yet the representations are always only representations, that is inner determinations of our mind in this or that relation to time.

(Kant 2007b, p. 218)

In essence, Kant draws a sharp distinction between mental events and empirically real events by maintaining that the later are organised according to strict causal relations while the former are not:

[T]he order and regularity in the appearances which we call **nature** are carried into them by ourselves; indeed, we could never find them in nature, if we ourselves, or the nature of our mind, had not originally placed them there.

(Kant 2007b, p. 164)

Kant's assertion is that the distinction between imagination and memory is not to be found in the content of consciousness, as the content can be identical whether the event is true or imagined, but in the structure of judgements about the content of consciousness. The difference between real and imaginary experiences cannot be determined on the basis of the content of consciousness alone because imagined events and real events can appear identical to consciousness (Wolff 1990). The criterion for differentiating between them is that real events are part of a necessary causal chain that unfolds in time in a particular way, while imaginary events do not have this quality:

[I]f ... I perceive the freezing of water, I apprehend two states (that of fluidity and that of solidity), and these as standing to each other in a relation of time. But in time, which I use as the foundation of the appearance as inner **intuition**, I necessarily represent to myself synthetic **unity** of the manifold, without which that relation of time could not be given **determinately** in an intuition (with respect to the succession of time).

(Kant 2007b, pp. 162–3)

The experience of the freezing of water is not in the events of fluidity and solidity but in the necessary causal connection between them (fluid first, then solid) which is determined by the structure of judgements. According to Kant's approach, to determine the reality and the truth value of something that happened is to stand in a necessary temporal relation to sequence of events. As Kant asserts in the above example, the hallmark of reality is not the events that take place, but the linear succession of the events as they follow each other in time.

Heidegger: non-linear time; the event

Kant's understanding of time as universal and isotropic (measurement independent) is challenged by Heidegger's assertion that human time is perspectival and non-linear:

In resoluteness, the Present is not only brought back from distraction with the objects of one's closest concern, but it gets held in the future and in having been. That *Present* which is held in authentic temporality and which thus is *authentic* itself, we call the '*moment of vision*'. This term must be understood in the active sense as an ecstasis. It means the resolute rapture with which Dasein is carried away to whatever possibilities and circumstances are encountered in the Situation as possible object of concern, but a rapture which is *held* in resoluteness. The moment of vision is a phenomenon which *in principle* can *not* be clarified in terms of the 'now'. The 'now' is a temporal phenomenon which belongs to time as within-time-ness: the 'now' 'in which' something arises, passes away, or is present-at-hand. 'In the moment of vision' nothing can occur; but as an authentic Present or waiting-towards, the moment of vision permits us *to encounter for the first time* what can be 'in a time' as ready-to-hand or present-at-hand.

(Heidegger 1962, pp. 387–8)

For Kant, understanding and time are inseparably linked as the cognitive ability to exercise judgement is premised on time being one of the categories of consciousness. Time is an *a priori* form of judgement which shapes and enables the comprehension of objects qua objects (Kant 2007b, pp. 68–71). For Kant, the objectivity of time, understood as its unified and idealised flow, is connected with the rationality of human reason and in this way warrants human autonomy from heteronomous forces such as the will of god, eternity and the absolute. When photography is considered as superimposed on the flow of absolute time, with each image carrying a timestamp that assigns to it a moment in the past, it too becomes part of the claim for autonomy, objectivity, and rationality. However, as will be suggested later in this section the time of the photographic image is different from the time of the photographic event.

The 'now' – in the blink of an eye

In *Kant and the Problem of Metaphysics* Heidegger critiques Kant's conception of time as for him it is not a linear progression from one moment to the next (Heidegger 1997, pp. 37–44). Heidegger rejects the idea that time is uniform 'measure of motion' (Aristotle); undeviating

movement comprised of past moments which are no longer now, future moments which are not yet here and the present moment which is the in between point between the past and the present. Instead of the Aristotelian 'now' as the linking of past with the present, Heidegger positions the 'now' as a radically different form of temporality that he names 'the moment of vision' (*Augenblick*), literally 'blink of an eye'. As several commentators observed *Augenblick* is a term with both theological and philosophical heritage, 'in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed' (Corinthians 15:52). Dreyfus points to the difficulty of translating *Augenblick* as 'moment' because this can imply something like a blip on an otherwise unperturbed continuum, while for both Kierkegaard and Heidegger it is a momentous event of a total switch from one state to another. In *Fear and Trembling* the knight of faith makes an unconditional commitment that redefines his whole life and Dasein changes from inauthentic being to authentic (Dreyfus 1990, p. 321). However, what is important is not so much the implicit reference to the New Testament and the explicit reference to Kierkegaard but that Heidegger here splits time into two series. In effect, Heidegger rejects both Aristotelian time as 'measure of movement' and Kierkegaard's eternity and creates a time of revelation in which god is replaced with death. This moment of revelation is the conversion of Dasein to authenticity. The 'now' as a temporal phenomenon is chronological and sequential, it is quantitative and belongs to time as within-time-ness. On the other hand, *Augenblick* is a dual movement of oscillation towards the future (death) and a recoil from it. For Heidegger the 'moment of vision' is the temporality of Dasein in which it finds authenticity, as the paradoxical essence of being futural.

Technology and the moment of vision

While Heidegger does not discuss *Augenblick* (moment of vision) in relation to the key concept of his later philosophy: technology, it is nevertheless implicitly present in sections 338–9 of *Being and Time*. After establishing that 'moment of vision' is in principle different from 'now', because it does not belong to the flow of time and because in the 'moment of vision' nothing can occur besides an encounter with time, Heidegger goes on to say that what makes the 'moment of vision' authentic is not its singularity, but on the contrary its ability to be repeated:

In anticipating, Dasein *brings itself again forth* into its ownmost potentiality-for-being. If *Being-as-having-been* is authentic, we call it '*repetition*'.

The inauthentic present, the 'now' corresponds to that which happened in the past in the mode of 'having been', this is the mode of representation which claims originality. As Heidegger says, originality can never be authentic because it is posited on the premise of forgetting of the belonging together of Dasein and being. In this moment of forgetting, which Heidegger calls 'falling' the thing loses its thingness, the image loses its imageness and becomes 'means to an end'. When Allan Sekula says 'Nothing could be more natural than a newspaper photo, or a man pulling a snapshot from his wallet and saying, "This is my dog"' (Burgin 1987, p. 86) he is describing the state of falling in which the image manifests to an ecstatic unity of 'having been' by making the dog present through representation that was itself forgotten. Sekula adds: 'But this particularly obstinate bit of bourgeois folklore – the claim for the intrinsic significance of the photograph – lies at the centre of the established myth of photographic truth'. It is interesting to note that as he is claiming that the truth of the photograph is a myth, Sekula immediately sets up another myth: that photography must be understood as signification. He goes on to say: 'The problem at hand is one of *sign emergence*; only by developing a historical

understanding of the emergence of photographic sign systems can we apprehend truly *conventional* nature of photographic communication' (Burgin 1987, pp. 86–7).

Signification is inauthentic mode of being

For Heidegger signification is an inauthentic mode of being because it accepts the totalising effect of representation in order to present coherent and sensible picture of being. Signification seeks stability and reassurance in the temporal continuity of biological time and in the mathematical and technological certainty of measured, pragmatic time of day-after-day.

In contradiction to the inauthentic and singular 'now', *Augenblick* is fragmentary, equivalent only to itself, a time of its own. When Dasein stops hiding behind the security of representation it stops falling, awaiting, and forgetting and changes to repetition and forerunning. Living authentically Dasein is repeating the *Augenblick* in which its essence is revealed. In this way Dasein embraces the 'hardest to bear' doctrine of eternal return:

that eternity *is* in the Moment, that the Moment is not the fleeting 'now', not an instant of time whizzing by a spectator, but the collision of future and past. Here the moment comes to itself. It determines how everything recurs.

(Heidegger 1991, p. 57)

The way *technē* reveals itself is through re-production (*Wiederholen*). As the English translators of Being and Time indicate, it is inadequate to translate *Wiederholen* as 'repeat' because the English word does not capture the kinetics (authenticity) of active re-making, as in 'to fetch, to collect, to bring back again'. While 'repeat' in English connotes redundancy and tiredness of the copy, *Wiederholen* means that Dasein repeats itself authentically through a complex move of throwing itself into the future by a critical relation to the past (Heidegger 1962, p. 437).

This ability to reveal its authentic essence as repetition is for Heidegger the *technē* of the 'moment of vision':

The word *technē* denotes rather a mode of knowing. To know means to have seen, in the widest sense of seeing, which means to apprehend what is present, as such. For Greek thought the essence of knowing consists in *alētheia*, that is, in the revealing of beings.

(Heidegger 1978, p. 184)

There are therefore two distinct temporal modalities or series at work: there is the series of chronological time that runs along a straight and narrow line stretched between the past and the future, and there is a series comprised of the repeated 'moments of vision' that create a field of intensity, rather than a liner progression from one moment to the next.

Both the metaphysical-ontological temporality and the recursive-fractal intensively are at work in the photographic image-event: on the one hand the photographic image is the manifestation of the analytical methodology that over the course of Western history perfected the ability to produce accurate, reliable representations that benefit a broad range of discourses and disciplines. However, no matter how accurate, evocative, abject, uncanny or scientific these representations are, they necessarily fail to picture the present moment because the present is occupied by representation itself and as Kant insisted, representation itself cannot be represented: 'Now it is very evident that I cannot know as an object that which I must presuppose in order to know any object' (quoted in Holquist 2010, p. 23).

On the other hand, the self-replicating image, the fractal, can create an authentic presence by way of a self-replicating feedback loop. Is it possible that instead of using representation as a model, one would say that there is a code that is translatable, and therefore in that sense recognisable. and the fact that it is recognizable does not invoke externally given and pre-supposed logic because its recognition is figured by the repetition of fragments.

III. The leap out of metaphysics

Ontological difference

This section is taking as its point of departure the observation made by Heidegger in the closing paragraphs of *Identity and Difference* that despite the efforts made by philosophy to discuss ‘representation’ and ‘subjectivity’, there is an inherent difficulty in trying to do so from within metaphysical thought:

It must remain an open question whether the nature of Western languages is in itself marked with the exclusive brand of metaphysics, and thus marked permanently by onto-theo-logic, or whether these languages offer other possibilities of utterance – and that means at the same time of telling silence.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 73)

The suggestion advanced below is that photography, understood as technology that makes legible images, is a privileged point of entry into the problem of ontological difference because it does not rely on the language of metaphysics and for this reason it does not get entangled in the tendency of language to operate through the implicit acceptance of the norms of representation. There are two main ways by which photography allows to challenge the hegemony of representational paradigms. First, because in photography, unlike in language, representation is not implied, but it is the very surface of the image. In other words, while in language representation is concealed behind forms of expression such as logic, rhetoric, metaphor, and poetics in photography representation is explicit, empirically present, verifiable by observation and unavoidably demonstrable. Second, in language representation is concealed behind the speaking subject, the intonation, and the voice of the discourse. Words are always spoken by someone, which means that subjectivity and representation are inseparable from an utterance. In photography however the image is the outcome of a technological process, not of the agency of a subject, which means that representation does not have to be attributed to a subjectivity.

As Heidegger pointed out, key metaphysical concepts such as ‘subjectivity’, ‘identity’ and ‘representation’ are also the key onto-theo-logical principles by which language operates, which means that at the precise moment when philosophy attempts to perform an autopsy on one of these concepts, by the very fact of doing so it is forced into a representational mode that becomes the basis of the examination. In other words, Heidegger is pointing out that while there is a fundamental divergence within thought that allows it to study itself, this divergence also ensures the impossibility of any thorough self-perception and radical self-examination, as any explicit attempt to examine representation or subjectivity is coming against the implicit reliance of language on representation as its *modus operandi*. Heidegger further complicates the situation by suggesting that this inability of language to represent representation to itself is also connected with the forming of subjectivity, which means that as soon as one posits oneself against representation to examine it, one is already taken over by representation to an extent that no radical examination is possible. The subject, the ‘I’ that attempts to catch representation

is itself formed by the process of representation. Therefore, it seems that representation and subjectivity are destined to remain the black hole of Western philosophy because, as Judovitz says: ‘we must rely on the language of metaphysics, on its form, logic and implicit postulations, precisely at the moment when we seek to contest them’ (Judovitz 1988a, p. 3). Heidegger’s ultimate failure to ‘get out of metaphysics’ is discussed by Golding:

Heidegger’s analysis still required a kind of ground (ontic) to knowledge; that is, a kind of ‘groundless ground’, he was still brought face-to-face with the (quasi-) mystical onto-theologic Godhead haze itself. Toward the last of his days, a very disgruntled Heidegger claimed it was impossible, all things considered (and he had considered all things) to jump from the proverbial metaphysical ship.

(Golding 2010a)

The cause of causes

However, despite the entrapment of the subject in representation, Heidegger tentatively suggests that the possibility of questioning metaphysics ‘must remain an open question’. The roadmap for this questioning is spelled out thus: ‘The ground itself needs to be properly accounted for by that for which it accounts, that is, by the causation through the supremely original matter – and that is the cause as *causa sui*’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 72). The challenge therefore is to think the cause of philosophy, its non-philosophical begging and origin that Heidegger ironically names ‘the god of philosophy’: ‘Man can neither pray no sacrifice to this god. Before *causa sui*, man can neither fall to his knees in awe nor can he play music and dance before this god’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 72). Getting out of metaphysics requires no less than abandoning the self-referential, self-causing way of thinking that is taking for granted what it is trying to prove. Accomplishing this task necessitates a ‘step back... out of metaphysics’. The crossing of the metaphysical threshold and the clearing of an alternative path for thought is however fraught with difficulties, for as Heidegger says, metaphysics are ingrained in modern technology which permeates all aspects of life and thought (Heidegger 2002, p. 72). But even if this difficulty is somehow overcome, there remains the additional problem that ‘Western languages are languages of metaphysical thinking’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 73). Stepping out of metaphysics therefore requires an altogether different way of doing philosophy, one that will not be bound to subjectivity and representation to the same extent as Western languages.

Photographic exposure

What is required by Heidegger is a total recall of a pre-metaphysical past, yet this past is not chronologically prior, but logically preceding representation:

we attain to the nearness of the historic only in that sudden moment of a recall in thinking. ... [this] holds true above all also for our attempt in the step back out of the oblivion of the difference as such, to think this difference as the perdurance of unconcealing overcoming and of self-keeping arrival.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 67)

Heidegger’s diagnosis of the metaphysical malaise is the ‘oblivion of the difference as such’: in metaphysical thought difference is subsumed under the copula ‘is’ (as in ‘A is A’) and the remedy is to think this forgotten difference not as an opposition to identity (for an opposition is still part of the same logic of representation) but as the arrival of presence that

‘assigns the difference of Being and beings to perdurance as the approach to their essence’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 67). The relation of Being and beings must not be understood as identity but as movement of ‘perdurance’. As Gillian Rose explains: “perdurance”... captures the idea of perfect duration, is a felicitous but strange translation of *austag* which means “arrangement” or “settlement” in the litigious sense of settling something in court’ (Rose 1984, p. 78). The requirement therefore is to think the relation of Being and beings outside the linearity of chronological time as a kind of perfect duration that is not a strictly temporal relation but a spatial-temporal event that holds Being and beings apart as well as bringing them together. This highly complex notion of time can be perhaps understood as the ‘now’ – not in the sense of the present instant, or the orgiastic immediacy of religious ecstasy that attempts to stretch to infinity the moment between past and present, but as the ‘now’ that marks the occurrence of an event, of something that happens. As Lyotard explains: ‘An event, and occurrence – what Martin Heidegger called *ein Ereignis* – is infinitely simple, but this simplicity can only be approached through a state of privation’ (Lyotard 1984a, p. 197). The event of perdurance dismantles thought because in it the subject and the object are held simultaneously together and apart. Deleuze explains it thus:

Lightening, for example, distinguishes itself from the black sky but must also trail it behind, as through it were distinguishing itself from that which does not distinguish itself from it. It is as if the ground rose to the surface without ceasing to be ground.

(Deleuze 2004, p. 36)

It seems that Deleuze found a way of grasping the ‘perdurance of unconcealing overcoming and of self-keeping arrival’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 67) as the moment of exposure that creates an event through a flash of lightning. It is possible that unknown to himself Heidegger opened a way for philosophy to move into a sphere where meaning is established purely through perdurance understood as exposure.

Heidegger suggests that the step out of metaphysics necessitates an event of presence and owning (*Ereignis*) that knows no chronological time because it is an instance of perfect duration: a direct, unmediated relation of Being and beings. With what is perhaps one of the greatest ironic statements of modern philosophy, Gillian Rose drily comments:

It seems that unknown to himself, Heidegger has brought us into the orbit of Biblical Hebrew; a language which has imperfect and perfect tenses but no past, present and future tenses, and which has no possessive verb ‘to have’; a language of the kind into which Heidegger attempts to transcribe German.

(Rose 1984, p.78)

To elaborate on Rose’s argument, Hebrew language is different from Indo-European languages because the verb ‘to be’ is not needed in the construction of sentences. For instance, a sentence such as ‘the jug *is* on the table’ will become in Hebrew ‘the jug on the table’ (הכד על השלחן). The omission of the verb ‘to be’ is precisely what allows Rose to claim that Heidegger seeks to transcribe German into a non-metaphysical language such as Hebrew.

Graven images and representation

Rose points out the similarities between perdurance as ‘the highest most significant event of all / a giving of presence that prevails in the present, in the past and in the future...’ (Rose 1984,

pp. 78–9) and *Yahweh* (the god of Israel in the Hebrew Bible): ‘In the Hebrew *Yahweh* speaks in the imperfect tense which announces His Perdurance: His presence in the future and past as well as present’ (Rose 1984, p. 80).

Rose further clarifies what exactly Heidegger is taking from the Jewish religion: ‘Heidegger seems to give us *Yahweh* without *Torah*: the event seems to include advent and redemption, presence and owning...’ (Rose 1984, p. 80). However, Rose leaves out what is perhaps the most significant attribute of *Yahweh* for the understanding of perdurance: the ban on depicting the god of Israel in an image.

Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. Thou shalt not bow down thyself to them, nor serve them: for I the LORD thy God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation of them that hate me.

(Quoted in Halbertal *et al.* 1992, p. 37)

It is significant that in these verses the ban on representing god follows immediately after the ban on having other gods and must be understood as a separate prohibition: It is forbidden to worship other gods and it is forbidden to make images of god. As Halbertal and Margalit indicate, the claim that god has no image is one of the foundations of the neo-Aristotelian teaching of Maimonides, however there are other traditions within Judaism, particularly the rabbinic tradition and the cabala that contain literary descriptions of god. In any case, even those strands of Judaism that maintain that god is or can be seen never venture into visual depiction. Significantly, the ban on representation is not limited to visual or pictorial representation of God, for it is also forbidden to write the name of God.

Perdurance

The two main justifications for the Hebraic ban on representation help to clarify the relevance of representation to the question of perdurance. The first is concerned with the use of predicates to describe God. Statements such as ‘god exists’ or ‘god is one’ create an impression of an object to which different predicates can apply which contradicts the idea of god’s unity (Halbertal *et al.* 1992, p. 58). Similarly, for Heidegger, the true nature of Being understood as perdurance cannot be represented through predication:

Someone wants to buy fruit in a store. He asks for fruit. He is offered apples and pears, he is offered peaches, cherries, grapes. But he rejects all that is offered. He absolutely wants to have fruit. What was offered to him in every instance *is* fruit and yet, it turns out, fruit cannot be bought. It is still infinitely more impossible to represent ‘Being’ as the general characteristic of beings.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 66)

The second aspect of the ban on representation concerns the relationship of perdurance to time. According to Maimonides, who uses the Aristotelian definition of time as dependent on motion, the concept of time does not apply to God:

It is quite clear that there is no relation between God and time or space. For time is an accident connected with motion, in so far as the latter includes the relation of anteriority

and posteriority ... and since motion is one of the conditions to which only material bodies are subject, and God is immaterial, there can be no relation between him and time.

(Maimonides n.d., p. I,LII see also Halbertal *et al.* 1992, p. 58)

The ban on representation is therefore not only the assertion of the invisibility of god, but it is meant to determine the absolute otherness of god and the essential categorical difference between god and all other forms of being (Halbertal *et al.* 1992, p. 59).

The ban on graven images is precisely due to the perfect and transitive presence that is outside of time and constitutes the event of all events. Perdurance is therefore directly related to the ban on representation and the general iconoclasm of the Judaic tradition. It follows that Perdurance is a leap out of visual representation into the essence of visual representation: 'The step out of metaphysics is the step out of technology and technological description ... into the *essence* of modern technology...' (Heidegger 2002, p. 52). While Gillian Rose asserts that the step out of metaphysics takes Heidegger into Biblical Hebrew, it is the assertion of this book that this leap does not go far enough, as all languages – not only German – are misleading and limited in the description of perdurance because they necessarily evoke the speaking subject. In any case, there are two reasons for the unsuitability of language for the description of perdurance. First the syntactic structure of language creates a duality between a subject and predicate which makes it unsuitable to talk about oneness. As Wittgenstein says

It is impossible to represent in language anything that 'contradicts logic' as it is in geometry to represent by its co-ordinates a figure that contradicts the laws of space, or to give the co-ordinates of a point that does not exist.

(Wittgenstein 2001, p. 13)

The second is that language that is used for the description of familiar reality is unsuitable for the description of the absolute other. The familiar linguistic categories of predication and existence do not apply to perdurance. 'The difference of Being and beings, as the differentiation of overwhelming and arrival, is the perdurance (Austrag) of the two in *unconcealing keeping in concealment*' (Heidegger 2002, p. 65). For that reason, the leap advocated on these pages is from the orbit of language into the orbit of photography. However, photography must be understood not as a homogenous entity but as a constellation of recursive and self-replicating exposures.

Getting out of metaphysics by way of photography

Heidegger's leap out of German language takes him out of language entirely, into the orbit of technology as the environment of perdurance/exposure. As Johnny Golding observes,

Heidegger's failure to get out of metaphysical thinking is due to the fact that Heidegger based his analysis on the requirement for knowledge to have some kind of ontological ground. In other words, for Heidegger, philosophy and language are inextricably bound together, and as Western languages are founded on the verb 'to be' no radical questioning of being is possible from within those languages.

(Golding 2010b)

This orbit is taken by this book as photography. Rose suggestion to understand perdurance as *Yahweh* (the god of Israel) finds support in Lyotard's understanding of *ein Ereignis* as:

Makom or the *Hamakom* of Hebraic tradition – the *there*, the site, the place, which is one of the names given by the Torah to the Lord, the Unnamable.

(Lyotard 1984a, pp. 196–7)

Both Rose and Lyotard leave out the question of technology and forgo its centrality to the understanding of perdurance as the notion of difference produced by the technological age. For Heidegger however, technology is the fundamental quality of the modern era:

Technology is therefore no mere means. Technology is a way of revealing. If we give heed to this, then another whole realm for the essence of technology will open itself up to us. It is the realm of revealing, i.e. of truth.

(Heidegger 1977a, p. 112)

Perdurance (exposure), difference and technology have this in common: in all three Being manifests itself in the immediacy of that which arrives. Joan Stambaugh explains perdurance as the difference between ‘Overwhelming and Arrival’:

The difference grants a ‘Between’ in which the Overwhelming of Being and the arrival in beings are held toward each other and yet held apart. This between is perdurance. It is the most fundamental presupposition for anything to be or to happen at all.

(Heidegger 2002, p. 17)

Technology, Heidegger explains, is not purely technological nor is it purely human. In modern technology Being appears even though ‘We fail to hear the claim of Being which speaks in the essence of technology’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 35). In ‘Art Beyond Representation’ Barbara Bolt points to the continuity between two works by Heidegger: ‘In *The Age of the Word Picture*, we are brought to an apprehension of Being as presencing. In “The Question Concerning Technology”, Heidegger develops the idea of *technē* as *poiēsis*’ (Bolt 2011, p. 59). Technology therefore is not only the obstacle to the overcoming of metaphysics, but also the way by which this overcoming can be actualised.

3 The event

I. Critiques of ocularcentrism

The non-completeness of the image

This Chapter takes as its point of departure the observation that the ability of photography to picture something is usually connected with representational schemas and ocular regimes of visibility on the one hand and with stillness and linearity in relation to time on the other. Corollary to this is the insistence on the subject as the ground of the photogenic operation. Because this is the case, very few veer from talking about photography outside of the framework of subjectivity. The writings of photography by Roland Barthes are a case in point. In his early texts Barthes looked at photography through a semiological schema famously saying that photography is ‘message without a code’ This structuralist reading was later taken up and developed by Victor Burgin in ‘Thinking Photography’ (1987). However, at a later stage Barthes was speaking of awakening from ‘the dream of scientificity’ (Macey 2001, p. 309), and in *Camera Lucida* (his last work) he turns his back on structuralism and develops a phenomenological approach to photography: ‘So I make myself the measure of photographic “knowledge”. What does my body know of Photography?’ (Barthes 1981, p. 9). In *Camera Lucida* Barthes offers the *Punctum* as a phenomenological substitution to the earlier notions of denotation and connotation which belong to a semiological – and therefore scientific – methodology. The *Punctum* describes the subjective experience of being touched, or wounded by a detail in a photograph (Barthes 1981, p. 53). The punctum is a detail that appears in the image not through the intention of the photographer but due to the indiscriminate recording of the apparatus. While this aspect is not developed in *Camera Lucida* it is possible to consider the punctum as a mark of the technology which undermines the centrality of the photographer to the photographic process. Ariella Azoulay explains:

Barthes sought to use the notion of the punctum to undermine the centrality of the singular photographer, the uncontested ruler of what Barthes terms the ‘studium’ of the photograph, where the punctum figures as a kind of residue neglected by the photographer. But even Barthes’ ‘punctum’ didn’t undermine the centrality of the photographer as the one who stages the studium and creates the conditions for the emergence of the punctum.

(Azoulay 2010)

Postulates of linguistics

Against this background, this chapter proposes to rethink photography not as a visual image but as a visible event by exploring how assumptions about representation, visibility, and

subjectivity are challenged in the work of several theorists in relation to language. This is not to suggest that photography has to return to semiology but precisely the opposite: to argue that in becoming aligned with semiotics in the first place, photography theory took the wrong linguistic turn and ended up in a place that makes it very difficult to think about photography as a plurality and multiplicity of meanings. With different emphasis and for varied reasons Foucault, Lyotard and Lacoue-Labarthe argue for the plurality of language by suggesting alternatives to the rigid semiotic schemas of Ferdinand de Saussure and C.S. Peirce and it is the suggestion raised on these pages that photography can learn from this effort. One of the most sustained and influential alternatives to Saussure's conception of language, and one that influenced generations of French theorists, is found in the writings of the 'Bakhtin Circle' that was active in Russia in the 1920s–1930s. For instance, Voloshinov writes 'Discourse ... arises for the non-verbal real-life situation and maintains a very intimate connection with it. Moreover, discourse is directly filled with that life and may not be detached from it without losing its sense' (Voloshinov 1983, p. 10). The texts of the *Bakhtin school* form the basis of many contemporary critiques that argue that denotation and signification are not the be all and end all of linguistics. For instance, when Deleuze proposes that language is an event before it is a signifying practice as in this passage: 'Denotation and manifestation do not found language, they are only made possible with it. They presuppose the expression. The expression is founded on the event, as an entity of the expressible or the expressed' (2004, p. 208).

As Deleuze argues, the plurality of language has something to do with producing sense as well as producing meaning and it is only because language is capable of sense that it is also capable of philosophy. This position is expressed most clearly in Deleuze's review of Jean Hyppolite's *Logique et Existence*. Deleuze states:

Philosophy must be ontology, it cannot be anything else; but there is no ontology of essence, there is only ontology of sense.

(Deleuze 1997, p. 191)

The problem with semiotic and structuralist approaches to language is their assumed essentialism that takes the form of a clear separation between the speaking subject and the object that is being spoken of. According to Derrida the immunity to self-awareness stems from the need to have a centre, a fulcrum or an Archimedean point that is both within and outside the discourse:

It has always been thought that the center, which is by definition unique, constituted that very thing within a structure which while governing the structure, escapes structurality. This is why classical thought concerning structure could say that the center is, paradoxically, *within* the structure and *outside* it.

(Derrida 2001, p. 352)

This opposition between subject and object is the ground zero of all anthropocentric thought and it is not difficult to see that theories that understand photography as a process of mediation between objective reality and reflective or mimetic images, (i.e. they place the image on one side and the object on the other) belong to the same discursive model. When language is understood from this essentialist, anthropocentric perspective what is being taken for granted is not only the separation between subject and object but also the affinity between thought and truth. This affinity becomes the static kernel of thought and of language. Indeed, Deleuze states: 'It is presumed that everyone knows, independently of concepts, what it meant by self, thinking, and being' (Deleuze 2004, p. 164). Inside this kernel no movement is possible and while the system

can procure new forms of knowledge through dialectical unfolding, and in this way to account for movement, this movement is bound to be external to the subject at the centre of the system. Deleuze formalises this point as follows: 'Knowledge understood in this way is a movement which is not a movement of the thing. It remains outside the object' (Deleuze 1997, p. 192). This is also the case with the theories that see the essence of photography in the image: photography is understood as the making of images from objects by means of representation. Representation is therefore considered as a fact, and photography as the science of this fact (Deleuze 1997, p. 192).

In Foucault's shadow

Overcoming the certainty of representation and subjectivity in the context of photography requires looking beyond the image into the photographic event. It is for this reason that the work of Foucault on the archive is key for this discussion, as Foucault untangles the archive from the metaphysical certainty of mimesis and representation and repurposes it as a constellation of discursive fragments that defines the conditions for the inauguration of subjectivity and representation (Foucault 1989b). However, there is also additional reason for paying close attention to Foucault in the context of photography, as Foucault has been a point of reference for a number of photography studies, most well-known of which is perhaps *The Burden of Representation* by John Tagg (1993). Tagg's text is symptomatic of the way by which photography theory is making use of Foucault to establish conceptual consistency of photography as a meaning producing apparatus while oblivious to the emphasis Foucault places on dismantling precisely such essentialist understandings. In his later work 'The Disciplinary Frame' Tagg reflects on his earlier work by saying:

In the *Burden of Representation*, I examined the conditions under which the dangerously prolific field of photographic meanings came, in the course of the nineteenth century, to be marked out and segmented, so that a plurality of locally specified, adjacent, but contradictory *photographies* could be institutionalized – each claiming to ground its status on the fundamental character of the medium. It was, however, precisely the term, 'the medium' that came under pressure. ... 'The medium' of photography was not given and unified. It was always a local outcome, and effect of a particular closure of the discursive field, a function of a specific *apparatus* or *machine*, in the sense in which Foucault used these terms. The 'medium' had to be constituted and it was multiply defined.

(Tagg 2009)

Here it is clear to what extent Tagg is prepared to follow Foucault and at what point he turns back towards essentialism. Namely: for Tagg, Foucault is useful inasmuch as he explains the production of multiplicity of meanings within a fixed hierarchical structure, but he does not take seriously Foucault's challenge to taking as a given the 'prolific field of photographic meanings'.

As will be shown below, Foucault – like Deleuze – rejects the ontology of essence that places the subject at the centre of the archival structure (either in the role of the archivist or as the docile, surveyed body). Instead, Foucault maintains that the archive archives the difference of discourses, and that subjectivity and reason are produced through this difference (Foucault 1989b, pp. 126–131). By evacuating essentialism from the (photographic) archive and restoring to it a play of distinctions – as Foucault intended – it becomes possible to rethink photography away from the abstraction of representation. It is at this point that the work of Lyotard

becomes complimentary to this effort as the event that Foucault considers in terms of discursive practices becomes in the hands of Lyotard a way of rethinking time away from its linear and chronological unfolding. By turning finally to Lacoue-Labarthe it will be suggested that the paradoxical structure of a-logical, a-radical surface establishes the conditions for non-dialectical, hyperbolic photography that engages not with the representation of objects but with the materiality of time.

Exhaustion of the transcendental

Photography's realism is often attributed to the technical ability of the photographic apparatus to capture not only an image of the thing but something of the thing itself. A classic example of this approach is found in the often-quoted text 'The Ontology of the Photographic Image' by André Bazin:

No matter how fuzzy, distorted, or discolored, no matter how lacking in documentary value the image may be, it shares, by virtue of the very process of its becoming, the being of the model of which it is the reproduction; it *is* the model.

(Bazin 2004, p. 14, emphasis in the original)

Similarly in Peter Wollen we find:

Photographs... are very instructive, because ... they are exactly like the objects they represent. But this resemblance is due to the photographs having been produced under such circumstances that they were physically forced to correspond point by point to nature.

(Quoted in Mulvey 2009, p. 55)

The reason photography can be seen as sharing the existence of the object it represents is because the photographic exposure inscribes not only the physical presence of the object but also a moment in time. This, again, is clear in Bazin: 'photography does not create eternity as art does, it embalms time, rescuing it simply from its own proper corruption' (Bazin 2004, p. 14). The notions of photography as a placeholder of memories, memento-mori and an archive of time are derived from this connection between the indexicality of the photograph and its ability to 'embalm' time.

However, this way of thinking about the photographic is deeply ocularcentric and metaphysical because it is based on assumptions about human agency as reduced to the perception of logic-driven, chronological continuity. When photography is considered as rational and (implicitly) linked to the rational psychology of the human subject it is difficult to rid it of the dualisms of presence-absence, matter-form and a subject-object. The overarching presumption is that of a human being whose psychological continuity is sustained over time, which allows for photographs to act as windows onto chronologically prior events. It is this separation between the subject, considered as a constant entity, and the object, considered as inert matter, which allows photography to make a claim for objective knowledge. In other words, if photography is defined by the identity it institutes between the image and the subject, there are always implicit assumptions about what does it mean to be (or not to be) an image, and these assumptions are concerned with such essences as lack, absence and negation because an image is that which is not an object and vice versa. This understanding of photography foregrounds a process of archiving by which the object is sublated with the agency of light to produce an image. The resulting photo-graph is the outcome of a dialectical negation by which the object is both

removed and preserved. As Dag Petersson observes, this kind of idealistic understanding of photography ‘as a process whereby a purely informal idea (the world as it is) mediates itself through light and shapes the unstable matter of the chemical emulsion into an analogical imprint’ (Petersson 2005, p. 67) leads itself all too naturally to identifying parallels with other disciplines. The example he quotes is taken from Benjamin’s *The Arcades Project*:

The past has left images of itself in literary texts, images comparable to those which are imprinted by light on a photosensitive plate. The future alone possesses developers active enough to scan such surfaces perfectly. Many pages in Marivaux or Rousseau contain a mysterious meaning which the first readers of these texts could not fully have deciphered.

(André Monglond in Petersson 2005, pp. 49 & 72ff)

As this quotation demonstrates, viewed through an idealist lens, photography can appear as an eternal and unchanging model of teleological unfolding of truth by means of uncovering or developing. In other words, to pose the discourse of photography as the *a priori* condition of textuality (as Monglond suggests) is to take for granted that there is essential truth to be found both in statements and in images. For Foucault, this kind of totalising logic is deeply problematic as it proposes metaphysical continuity and identity between regimes and disciplines in place of attention to the ‘rules that characterize a discursive practice’ (Foucault 1989b, p. 127). In other words, the challenge for the discourse of photography is to identify its pre-rational singularity, or those qualities that differentiate it from the totalising logic of representation without ever completely detaching it from this logic.

The edge of the image

One possibility of getting out of the totalising logic of representation is sketched by Heidegger in *Bremen and Marburg Lectures* (2012). In the essay *The Thing* Heidegger uses the example of a jug to say that an object cannot be understood scientifically through the analysis of its chemical composition or its physical properties. Rather, an object must be understood within the manifold of human practices, rituals and behaviours that crystallise in the object’s essence. In Heidegger’s example of the jug its essence is holding and outpouring. It is significant that the essence of the jug does not depend on whether it is empty or full because essence is not determined by the content, rather it is established through the notion of nearness:

When we think the thing as thing, then we protect the essence of the thing in the region from where it essences. Thinging is the essence of the thing in the region from where it essences. Thinging is the nearing of the world. Nearing is the essence of nearness. Insofar as we protect the thing as thing, we dwell in nearness. The nearing of nearness is the authentic and sole dimension of the mirror-play of the world.

(Heidegger 2012, p. 19)

Only by going beyond representation it is possible to approach the essence of the thing. This teleological suspension of representation is absolutely necessary for the mirror play of the world to uncover itself in the thing. By applying the same approach to photography, a path opens that leads beyond the content of the image into that which constitutes its nearness. It is only in this nearness and not in the content that world is reflected. The nearness of photography, as that which holds and pours might be found in the verge, or the edge of the image. This understanding is supported by Derrida, for instance: ‘This requirement [to distinguish between the

content and the essence of an object] presupposes a discourse on the limit between the inside and the outside of the art object, here a *discourse on the frame*' (Derrida 1987, p. 45). However, the frame should not be understood as the key-line, or the edge of an image, rather it is the visible mark of the fractality of the image which marks the movement of repetition and self-replication as the essence of photography in which, as Heidegger says, can be glimpsed 'the mirror play of the world'.

However, just as the essence of the jug has nothing to do with the substance it holds, so the essence of photography has nothing to do with light. As Barbara Bolt comments 'Light is the source of universal knowledge, which serves as an objective to be universally achieved. Here light provides the metaphor for rational intelligibility that underpins western understandings of human subjectivity' (Bolt 2004, p. 128). Due to the perceived rationality of light, photography provides extremely convincing and convenient site for the grounding of 'truth' as transcendental value, as it seems to be opposed to any kind of arbitrariness; it is taking something (object, event) that was part of the flow of time and making it visual and static by means of light. This is a gesture that presupposes a universal singular unity revealed through the process of reflection and sublation. Situated within the paradigms of bringing to light and revealing the truth photography appears as the paragon of the way representation operates and as such it is also always linked to the question of ethics and liberal democracy. Both contemporary identity politics and liberalism regard individual self-identity as fully formed only through representation (Colebrook 1999, p. 11).

II. The archive and its discontents

The non-representational archive

Because of the importance of representation to the politics of identity, the investment in the truth-value of photography is not only aesthetic but also political. The notion of photography as the archive of time, the index of truth and guarantor of memory is pervasive and omnipresent. But to consider photography solely as an image and a representation is to suggest that it can be exhaustively described as an archive which, as Foucault warns, is not possible:

[I]t is not possible for us to describe our own archive, since it is from within these rules that we speak, since it is that which gives to what we can say – and to itself, the object of our discourse – its modes of appearance, its forms of existence and coexistence, its system of accumulation, historicity, and disappearance.

(Foucault 1989b, p. 130)

This is to say that the identity of the archive cannot be apprehended by a method that is based on representation because representation as a concept and an idea is premised on the notions of totality and finitude. As Colebrook shows, the essential quality of representation is that it marks a limit to knowledge:

Modern philosophy situates itself within the representational limits of the subject. Representation is a condition of finitude. Because knowledge is received from without it must be taken up and re-presented. What can be known is therefore determined and delimited by the representational powers of the subject... Representation marks a limit, a point beyond which knowledge cannot go: a recognition of the point of view of knowledge.

(Colebrook 1999, pp. 1–2)

The notion of a society formed by or through representation implies transcendent and universal law on the one hand and individual and autonomous subjects capable of rational representation on the other.

However, this is not an indication that the archive is unknown in the Kantian sense of the *noumena*, or the thing-itself, but rather, that representation cannot account for or grasp a system that is not a static totality. Only common denominators, identities and transcendental statements can be captured by representation, while events and singularities escape it. Representation cannot deal with the 'now' understood as the intuited, authentic present because the gesture of representation, of archiving and of sublation creates regularity, distance, and preservation in which the subject is suspended, delayed, and mothballed. If the image is understood as only able to deal with situations that happened in the past, then it does not capture the present. If on the other hand the image is grasped not as a representation of the past but as an event that is taking place in the present, then it is not the content of the image that is of interest, but its occurrence. Not what the image is of, but the fact that it is happening.

Difference

Considered as an event, the photographic archive is never closed, never completed, never achieving the totalising and universal state of 'truth', and yet it is productive of a form of existence that recovers authenticity from representation, a surface out of depth and singularity out of homogeneity. One of the most useful ways of understanding the archive in terms of difference is found in the work of Foucault:

[I]t dissipates that temporal identity in which we are pleased to look at ourselves when we wish to exorcise the discontinuities of history: it breaks the thread of transcendental teleologies; and where anthropological thought once questioned man's being or subjectivity, it now bursts open the other, and the outside. In this sense, the diagnosis does not establish the fact of our identity by the play of distinctions. It establishes that we are difference, that our reason is the difference of discourses, our history the difference of times, our selves the difference of masks. That difference, far from being the forgotten and recovered origin, is this dispersion that we are and make.

(Foucault 1989b, p. 131)

The photographic archive is not exhausted by the visible, indeed, as Foucault explains in the above quotation, the archive cannot be confined to the transcendental teleology (representation being prime example). The archive must remain singular and open, neither to be subsumed under the cloak of metaphysics nor to become an accident and dissipate into the void. Only by being singular and non-individualistic can the archive overcome the entrapments of lack, negation and categorisation which in every case maintain rational cohesiveness by being anchored in pre-discursive notions of time, space and movement. The existence of logic, structure, chronology and subjectivity cannot be simply presupposed because presupposing them begs the question of the origin of this logic, of that chronology. The non-archival archive Foucault demands in the above quotation is the answer to the question of origins, as it is the medium through which difference takes place.

Subjectivity

Foucault's strategy in overcoming the representational force of the archive is by considering the archive not as a container of some pre-archival knowledge, but as a force which is inseparable

from any knowledge, utterance or statement. By detaching the archive from its foundations in metaphysics Foucault can make the claim that it is not the subject who produces the archive, but it is the archive that produces the subject. Giorgio Agamben points out that at the time of writing *The Archaeology of Knowledge*, Foucault did not yet use the term ‘apparatus’, using the term ‘positivity’ instead. By tracing the genealogy of positivity through Hyppolite’s writings on Hegel, Agamben establishes that ‘positivity’ is the historical element by which Foucault overcomes Hegelian universals such as ‘State, Sovereignty, Law and Power ... an apparatus is “the network” [*le réseau*] that can be established between these elements’ (Agamben 2009, p. 7). Agamben concludes that ‘apparatuses must always imply a process of subjectification, that is to say, they must produce their subject’ (2009, p. 11). This genealogy allows to establish a correspondence between two key moments of Foucauldian terminology: the apparatus and the archive. In *The Archaeology of Knowledge*, the chapter on the archive titled: ‘The Historical *a priori* and the Archive’ opens with the following sentence: ‘The positivity of a discourse – like that of Natural History, political economy or clinical medicine – characterizes its unity throughout time, and well beyond individual *œuvres*, books, and texts.’ It goes on to situate the archive not as a discourse, but as that by which the discursivity comes into being: the event that escapes totality and which is ‘at once close to us and different from our present existence, it is the border of time that surrounds our presence, which overhangs it, and which indicates it in its otherness...’ (Foucault 1989b, p. 131).

For photography it means that neither indexicality nor representation nor mummification of time succeed in exhaustively describing photography because in each case the question of the genesis of these operations remains unresolved. The positivity of the photographic discourse, its conceptual consistency as *apparatus* is expressed through the plurality of fragments that forms the *a priori* difference of the image. Difference is the condition that allows the creation of the photographic fragment as surface without depth but with the ability to self-replicate as copy-of-copy-of-copy. This is not a question of discovering what the image is of, but of allowing the image to have certain expressivity (that does not express a *something*), certain eventness, a way of inhabiting a ‘now’ which is non-visual, non-identical, non-discursive but dynamic and a-temporal.

The photographic archive

By re-configuring the archive as apparatus Foucault is concerned to point out that the purpose of the archive is not to be a placeholder of memories, a copy or a replica. At the same time Foucault does not seek to destroy the mimetic quality of the archive, rather his aim is to propose an archival model that does not rely on the original-copy paradigm in which the archive is the imperfect copy of an original:

The archive is not that which, despite its immediate escape, safeguards the event of the statement ...[n]or is the archive that which collects the dust of statements that have become inert once more, and which may make possible the miracle of their resurrection; it is that which defines the mode of occurrence of the statement-thing; it is the system of its functioning.

(Foucault 1989b, p. 129)

There is an underlying structure to the archive that does not speak to the relationship of the archive to the world but to the self-identical relationship of the archive to itself. Rather than a form of mummified time or a memory prosthetic that warrants identity and continuity by

demarcating and ordering time, the archive is a multiplicity of self-identical fragments that preserves the possibility of diversity, multiplicity and difference:

Far from being that which unifies everything that has been said in the great confused murmur of a discourse, far from being only that which ensures that we exist in the midst of preserved discourse, it is that which differentiates discourses in their multiple existence and specifies them in their own duration.

(Foucault 1989b, p. 129)

The photographic archive (if we can still use this term) is not an archive of images, of past moments, events, and situations, rather it is the archive of a form of duration that is specific to photography and related to its *technē* of fragment and copy. The photographic archive does not archive images but the specific duration that preserves the fractal, fragmented time of the photographic exposure.

Following Foucault and Heidegger it becomes possible to argue that photography is not a form of representational knowledge, it cannot be grounded in light, logic or vision as these are pre-determined through specific historical narratives. Rather, photography has its own plurality, its own 'other' which is disclosed in the way photography makes itself present or manifests itself in the world through reproduction. This manifestation is contained within its mode of production and reproduction which suggests a form of non-chronological temporality that can accommodate fractal and fragmented surface events.

III. The fractal image

Fractality and immanence

If photography is not only a representational mechanism, then what is it? One answer to this question is that photography can be conceptualised as fractal multiplicity, because it is possible to consider it not as a device that is pointing to an external and chronologically removed situation outside of it, but as an event in its own right that is produced through mechanical reproduction. Overcoming representation cannot be achieved by replacing it with another kind of essence. As Foucault says in his review of Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* and *Logic of Sense*:

Overturn Platonism: What philosophy has not tried? [...] Plato is said to have opposed essence to appearance, a higher world to this world below, the sun of truth to the shadows of the cave [...]. But Deleuze locates Plato's singularity in the delicate sorting, in the fine operation that precedes the discovery precisely because it calls upon it and tries to separate malign simulacra from the masses [*people*] of appearance. Thus it is useless to attempt the reversal of Platonism by reinstating the rights of appearances, ascribing to them solidity and meaning.

(Foucault 2000, pp. 343–345)

What is required is a theory that can liberate photography from the representational paradigm without however installing another externally given rule. By considering photography not as an image but as an event of fractal distribution it becomes possible to initiate another understanding which does not collude in representation, rather it is a way by which representation itself can be disseminated. The event of photography is not related to the content of the image,

it is not describable in pictorial terms, and it cannot be aligned with events that are external to it. Photography as event is derived entirely from the power to reproduce which generates self-replicating copies. However, this power to replicate should not be understood as photocopy, but as the production of difference. Difference here is not the difference between representations, but difference in its pure form: an autonomous difference which emerges alongside representation. The ability of photography to be re-produced through self-replication suggests the presence of a force that has no signifying power, yet it is the site of the creation of sense. The question of content, of the subject, and the way the world is represented is superseded in favour of an incorporeal sense that allows to move beyond ontology.

It will be remembered that Heidegger posited a pre-ontic being as the event of ontological difference which precedes representation. However, this move was severely criticised by Adorno who claims:

The term ‘ontological difference’ permits his [Heidegger’s – DR] philosophy to lay hands even on the insoluble moment of entity. What we are to understand by such a ‘being’ alleged to be quite independent of the ontical sphere – this, of course, has to remain unsettled. Definition would involve it in the dialectics of subject and object, in the very thing from which it is to be exempt. [...] Talk of the ‘ontological difference’ comes down to the tautology that Being is not entity because it is Being.

(Adorno 1983, pp. 115–6)

Heidegger is here accused of tautology because he posits something as the basis of the discourse which cannot be the subject of the discourse, in this way – according to Adorno – subjectivity is brought back as contraband. However, it is still possible that that which cannot be discoursed can be pointed at in silence. The event of photography presents just such a possibility because here difference is produced not discursively but by means of mechanical reproduction and self-replication. Drawing upon Heidegger’s definition of technology as pre-subjective it is possible to claim that photography establishes the event of ontological difference without lapsing into subjectivity.

The time of the photographic event is opposed to the linear chronological time of the photographic image which presupposes cohesiveness and uninterrupted continuity. The instantaneity of the photographic exposure is not a blip on the linear continuum but a point set outside of it which however allows to take account of the fact that the linear continuum is itself a historical construction. In other words, the expressivity of the photographic event which expresses nothing but its own expressivity and constitutes its own essence is at the same time inseparable from the visible image and is in direct opposition to its representational and communicative codes.

Cruelty of the event

While the photographic image always assumes the discourse of representation as its ground and mimesis as its ontological foundation, the photographic event has a different dynamic that institutes multiversal and fractal ontology that sets up its own form of logic that is non-representational, a-individual, non-identical and a-rational. According to Lyotard, this form of logic is associated with anxiety and privation (1984a, pp. 197–8), and Foucault likewise stressed the ‘cruelty’ of this logic.

Physics concerns causes, but events, which arise as its effects, no longer belong to it. Let us imagine a stitched causality: as bodies collide, mingle and suffer they create events on their

surfaces, events that are without thickness mixture, or passion; for this reason they can no longer be causes.

(Foucault 2000, pp. 172–3)

While for Lacoue-Labarthe this logic of the event is product of the irresolvable internal paradox of representation by which representation always strives to make the subject present yet only has artificial substitutes at its disposal (words and pictures). This rupture at the heart of representation splits and disintegrates subjectivity and identity and in so doing establishes a sensual logic that Lacoue-Labarthe names ‘mimetology’ (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998).

Sublime and photography

Foucault, Lyotard and Lacoue-Labarthe institute something they name respectively *archive*, *sublime*, and *mimetology* in order to make it possible to discard or supersede rational logic not because this logic does not work but because it works all too well by describing states of affairs, events and situations. However, like Euclidian geometry this logic only captures idealised forms and perfect, static shapes and has nothing to say about movement and change. For Foucault, the political problem of the archive, which is to say the problem of its power, is not to explain the hierarchical structure of knowledge and the sovereignty of the archivist, but to account for ‘points of contact, places of insertion, irruption, or emergence, domains or occasions of operation’ (Foucault 1989b, p. 128) – not to expose the operation or representation in the hospital or in the prison but to explore the conditions of mutation, the mechanisms of re-shaping and the levers of amendment that both produce and delimit notions of self and subjectivity. For Lyotard, the sublime is the ‘now’ that allows one to ask ‘is it happening’ and in this way to witness the inexpressible, that which ‘cannot be presented and which remains to be presented’ and in this way to undo the presumption of static, linear and chronological time. The way the undecidable operates was developed by Jacques Derrida in *Limited Inc.*: ‘Undecidability is always a *determinate* oscillation between possibilities (for example, of meaning, but also of acts). These possibilities are themselves highly *determined* in a strictly *defined* situations... they are *pragmatically* determined’ (Derrida 1988b, p. 148). When Derrida describes the political significance of undecidability, he is concerned to emphasize that it is not a question of total indeterminacy or some kind, or an abrogation of responsibility. To the contrary, the object of undecidability is to assert the radical freedom and struggle involved in making a decision. Without an element of undecidability, the main precondition for an ethical decision is not being met. What Derrida helps to delineate is the way by which an image maintains within itself a heterogeneity that does not reach a limit or an end, preventing it from becoming pre-determined, or conditioned on some kind of moral imperative, logical necessity or instrumental indexicality. For Lacoue-Labarthe, the internal paradox of the logic of representation is symptomatic to the subjectal loss (*desistance*) which suggests the possibility of an ‘abyssal’ logic and a return to a more paradoxical, undecidable subject that manifests his/herself by self-absence (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, Martis 2005, pp. 48–52). Foucault, Lyotard and Lacoue-Labarthe propose in different ways that a system does not need to be homogenous, unified and unmoving in order to work. In each case rational, representational, totalising logic is rejected in favour of system that is a-logical, fragmented, non-linear, paradoxical and yet effective in explaining how change operates and in getting to grips with some kind of incorporeal materiality that escapes all forms of dialectical thought.

All three approaches converge on the subject of photography as taken up by this book and allow to conceive of it not as a form of identity but as a form of irreducible difference. Traditional approaches that allow representation to take over, do not consider photography as something to do with change as it is generally seen as a way of freezing, mummifying or fixing.

Both in its theoretical and in its lay sense photography is seen as a communication of a past moment at all points in time. The photograph once taken is available anywhere, anytime; it is always producing the past by re-establishing it somewhere else. In this way photography is always seen as insisting on linear, chronological time. But, as the work of Foucault, Lyotard, Deleuze and Lacoue-Labarthe demonstrates, this linearity is at best misleading, at worst politically dangerous and in any case, it does not help to understand how sense is being established in the case of the visual image. Incorporeal materiality can be understood as a kind of environment around which the visual gets mapped without imposing representation, and that can only be thought through fully with the notion of the archive, the sublime, the event and the abyssal/mimetic logic that deals with questions of time as the 'now' rather than with the notions of linearity which depend on the chronological conception of time.

Image and event

In the previous section a move was initiated to separate photography from the idea of the image (with all its metaphysical/semiological/representational baggage) and to suggest that as long as photography is considered in visual terms something remains unaccountable. The evocations of Foucault's understanding of the archive, Lyotard's treatment of the sublime and Lacoue-Labarthe's reworking of mimesis we designed to delineate the kind of operation required to produce a form of logic that can account for change and movement. As Foucault explains in his discussion of the archive, it is not representation that accounts for the way power operates but movement and change. For that reason, logic that has no way of addressing change has no political radicalism of its own. As was pointed out earlier, it is exactly because language is capable of both change and stasis that it is tantamount to philosophy. Language already implies plurality. As Deleuze discusses in *Difference and repetition*, the plurality of language is due to it containing both meaning (which can be true or false) and sense (which can be thought of as intonation, timbre or style):

Two dimensions may be distinguished in a proposition: *expression*, in which a proposition says or expresses some idea; and *designation*, in which it indicates or designates the objects to which what is said or expressed applies. One of these would then be a dimension of sense, the other the dimension of truth and falsity.

(Deleuze 2004, p. 191)

On the other hand, photography traditionally implies exactly the opposite: a static, fossilised moment in time, frozen and immobile. Numerous accounts, whether concerned with the history, the meaning or the culture of photography consider its essence as the ability to fix an image that is in some ways identical to the thing, as in Barthes' statement 'photography repeats to infinity that which can never be existentially repeated' (Barthes 1981, p. 6). In all these (representational) accounts of photography, the visible is taking precedence over the invisible. This is not only because photography is considered as the discourse of the visible, but also because these theories are themselves representational in the sense that they privilege to identity and verisimilitude over diversity and difference.

Ontology of the image

As was discussed in earlier section, considered as the paragon of identity photography remains immune to movement, change and difference. This section will move the argument forward by suggesting that to fully account for both the visual image and a visible and expressive dynamic that lies outside of identity, photography has to be considered as an ontology. For Bergson in

Matter and Memory the image is an ontology as it mediates between consciousness and matter. Here Bergson uses photography metaphorically, yet he insists on the ontological primacy of the image. Bergson rejects representation by insisting that the image is not the given but that by which the given is given, i.e. sense and not essence:

The whole difficulty of the problem that occupies us comes from the fact that we imagine perception to be a kind of photographic view of things... – a photograph which would then be developed in the brain-matter by some unknown chemical and psychical process of elaboration. But is it not obvious that the photograph, if photograph there be, is already taken, already developed in the very heart of things and at all the points of space? No metaphysics, no physics even, can escape this conclusion.

(Bergson 2005, p. 38)

This is not to strip photography of its representational and aesthetic functions but to suggest that the *technē* of representation and the image produced with this *technē* already involve the concept of difference. Heidegger in *The Age of the World Picture* uses the notion of picturing something specifically as the essential quality of modernity:

Where the world becomes picture, what is, in its entirety, is juxtaposed as that for which man is prepared and which correspondingly, he therefore intends to bring before himself and have before himself, and consequently intends in a decisive sense to set in place before himself. Hence world picture, when understood essentially, does not mean a picture of the world but the world conceived and grasped as picture.

(Heidegger 1977a, p. 182)

As Heidegger expands in *The Question Concerning Technology*, technology is the discourse of the impersonal and pre-subjectival:

Technology is therefore no mere means. Technology is a way of revealing. If we give heed to this, then another whole realm for the essence of technology will open itself up to us. It is the realm of revealing, i.e. of truth.

(Heidegger 1977a, p. 113)

In the introduction to the English translation, Lovitt explains the nuanced meaning of the word ‘truth’ (*Wahrheit*) in this context; it points not only to the usual for Heidegger notion of ‘unconcealment’ but also ‘to keep safe, to preserve’ by making manifest. Uncovering (*αλήθεια*) is for Heidegger a personal and pre-individual notion of truth that cannot be captured metaphysically, yet it is being translated in the technology of the age. The notion of truth as the uncovering positions it before chronological / calculable time as the time of eternity. The truth of technology therefore is unconcealment and safekeeping by way of making manifest. This connection between technology and truth allows to conceive of photography as the technological safekeeping of non-chronological time understood as perdurance or exposure (Heidegger 1977a, p. 12).

Ontology and technology

For Heidegger, technology is not (only) means to an end, it is also an ontology because truth reveals itself in the technology of the age. This however requires careful unpacking, as it will be a mistake to think of truth here in the sense of essence or as something that can be represented. Truth for

Heidegger is always out of reach, it makes thought possible by being the un-thought. Being on the outside of thought, truth cannot be represented for it is the continuous process of revealing and concealing understood not dialectically as opposites that cancel each other out and merge into each other but as a univocity in which the belonging together of revealing and concealing is required to form the event, the now, the exposure of perdurance. In *Parmenides* Heidegger explains:

The α in $\alpha\text{-}\lambda\eta\theta\epsilon\iota\alpha$ in no way means simply an undetermined universal ‘un-’ and ‘not.’ Rather, the saving and conserving of the un-concealed is necessary in relation to concealment, understood as the withdrawal of what appears in its appearing. The conserving is grounded in a perpetual saving and preserving.

(Heidegger 1998, p. 124)

According to this non-dialectical understanding of truth, the visible photographic image is not opposed to, or separate from that which is invisible and absent, rather, the visible and the invisible are co-present in the realm of the technological unfolding in which what is coming to presence is the event of non-chronological, immeasurable time. It is precisely because photography is considered as the technology that archives (chronological) time that it has a privileged relationship with the ‘event of appropriation’ (*Ereignis*) in which the ontological, non-chronological time is revealing itself as independent from past, present, and future. The difference between the image of photography and the event of photography is therefore connected with a conception of time: The photographic image, by force of its technology presupposes the existence of reality outside itself and of a past of which it is an image. The photographic event, on the other hand, is the reality of technology itself as the revealing and concealing the way by which the actual reveals itself as the force of reproduction.

The event

The notion of the photographic event is in close proximity to the notion of the event as developed by Lyotard across a number of texts, particularly *The Sublime and the Avant-Garde* and *Lessons on the analytic of the Sublime*. Lyotard’s notion of the event is drawn out of Heidegger’s ‘event of appropriation’ inasmuch as it points towards the present-unrepresentable, (naming the unnameable) ‘now’. But Lyotard is also using Heidegger against Heidegger to complicate the event as the unnameable of Heidegger’s own thought.

Following Lyotard’s notion of the event it becomes possible to suggest that there is more to photography than an image-based approach would suggest. Lyotard is using Kant’s distinction between the beautiful and the sublime to propose that there is an additional dimension to the correspondence between images and things that evades any form of representation (Kant 2007a, pp. 75–77). Furthermore, this dimension cannot be comprehended by consciousness and it dismantles subjectivity as the immobile and totalising centre of the essentialist worldview. However, this inscrutable and largely unknowable dimension grounds the notion of the ‘event’ as placed outside of chronological time, being essentially timeless as well as accounting for the reversal by which the invisible and the unknown becomes the basis for the possibility of the visible. For Lyotard the event goes to the heart of that which cannot be spoken of:

What we do not manage to formulate is that something happens, *dass etwas geschieht*. Or rather, and more simply, that it happens ... *dass es geschieht*. Not a major event in the media sense, not even a small event. Just an occurrence.

(Lyotard 1984a, p. 197)

The event is a reminder that there is something that is not yet absorbed, assimilated or processed by consciousness, and that this something is the moment of consciousness's own disappearance. This stuttering of consciousness, the failure to grasp and to account for the now-event is the moment of the sublime. In this moment of malfunctioning consciousness becomes exposed to a different temporal order, in which the causal link between cause and effect is broken and the chronological sequence becoming damaged. Lyotard here draws on a line of argumentation put forward by Adorno: In the section of *Negative Dialectics* titled 'The Crisis of Causality' Adorno speculatively suggests that: 'Even Kant would have to admit that an awareness of all the causal sequences that intersect in every phenomenon – instead of it being unequivocally determined by causality in the sequence of time – is essential to the category itself' (Adorno 1983, p. 266). Adorno here indicates the internal contradiction of Kantian causality for if causality is taken seriously, as Kant intended, it will have to be extended indefinitely contradicting the finitude of Kantian conception of historical time. Lyotard demonstrates how Kant understood the sublime as both pleasure and pain, as 'conflict between the faculties of a subject, the faculty to conceive of something and the faculty to "present" something' (Lyotard 1984a, p. 77). In the case of a (visual) image, the sense of pleasure from the work of art testifies to causal connection between sensory perception and conceptual cognition; the aesthetic experience is nothing else then the confirmation that representational conduit between the mind and the body is uninterrupted and proceeds within the allocated chronological framework. The sublime however operates in a different way:

It takes place, on the contrary, when the imagination fails to present an object which might, if only in principle, come to match a concept.

(Lyotard 1984b, p. 78)

Here Lyotard is almost paraphrasing Adorno. Compare with: 'The name of dialectics says no more, to begin with, that the objects do not go into their concepts without leaving a remainder...' (Adorno 1983, p. 5). The 'remainder' is precisely the failure of representation to create a perfect match between an object and a concept. For Adorno, this failure of representation to reify a concept to such an extent that it becomes identical with the object is the very possibility of thought that can think its own condition as transformative of the world then descriptive. Lyotard goes beyond Adorno when he gets hold of the same moment when representation / reification fails as a possibility of stepping not only outside of language but also outside of subjectivity.

Positioning of representation as both aesthetic and political problem stems from the understanding of representation as grounded in logic that is externally given and chronologically prior to the objects or entities mediated by it. The double helix of representation is already discernible in this simple definition, as on the one hand representation contains within it an appeal to reason as the guarantor of the truth value of representation, and on the other hand this appeal is projected into a timeframe of causal and chronological relations.

However, Lyotard's distinction between the 'modern' and the 'postmodern' sublime should not be understood as a temporal sequence in which the postmodern comes after the modern. The modern sublime is contaminated by the unholy alliance of subjectivity and representation which treats the image as a copy or a mimetic surface. The postmodern sublime aims to restore to the image the ability to inspire respect and terror, being not a mirror of reality but an active force weaved into the fabric of the real. Lyotard's postmodern sublime has strong parallels with Heidegger's notion of *αλήθεια*. Following Heidegger, the sublime is 'rescued' from its association with subjectivity and the image from its association with representation in order to establish it as pre-visual and pre-signifying event.

4 Simulacrum

I. Original, copy, simulacrum

Positioning simulacrum within philosophical framework

Both as a branch of the visual arts and as a field of theoretical studies photography was founded since its inception on the relationship between the real and the copy. In this way photography was brought under the auspice of dialectical reasoning that dominated the study of aesthetics at least since Plato (Camille 1996, p. 31). However, as several commentators observed, photography does not fit easily within the Platonic model of original and copy because its mode of production overcomes the original-copy binary in favour of a new construct that obliterates this distinction. For instance, in *A Note on Photography and the Simulacra* Rosalind Krauss considers photography's destabilising effect on the Platonic schema by pointing to the way identical copies from the same original undermine the very notion of originality. Krauss argues that the ability of photography to produce 'fundamentally indistinguishable' prints, deconstructs the very distinction between originals and copies (Krauss 1984, p. 59).

The technological reproducibility of photography undermines the Millenia old paradigm of originals and copies and destabilises the notion of authorship by creating any number of identical copies. It is however possible to think about photography not as the generation of *indistinguishable* copies, but as the production of difference by means of reproductive technology. In the notes to *The Arcades Project* Walter Benjamin proposes an unusual way of thinking about reproduction, not as a series of indistinguishable copies but as the eternal return of difference:

The idea of eternal recurrence transforms the historical event itself into a mass-produced article. [...] The idea of *eternal* recurrence derived its luster from the fact that it was across any interval of time shorter than that provided by eternity.

(Benjamin 2002, p. 340)

As Eduardo Cadava observes, for Benjamin the main effect of technology is not the production of identical copies but the creation of a world without identity, a world of perpetual becoming in which what is being produced through repetition is not sameness but radical, a-rooted difference formed through the interplay of singularity and repetition (Cadava 1997).

Eternal return

The eternal return is the condition of modernity because modern technology sets up a regime that binds together the *logos* of production with the *Eros* of consumption. As Benjamin argues:

‘The dialectic of commodity production in advanced capitalism: the novelty of products – as stimulus to demand – is accorded an unprecedented importance. At the same time, eversame is manifest in mass production’ (Benjamin 2002, p. 331). In Cadava’s interpretation, the *eternal return* in Benjamin is related to photography. Drawing on Benjamin’s reading of Auguste Blanqui’s *L’eternite par les asters*, of which Benjamin says that it presents the idea of eternal return ten years before Zarathustra (2002, p. 25), Cadava says that his discussion of the reproducibility of the universe is throughout cast in photographic language that focuses on the questions of repetition, reproduction, images, negatives, originals, copies, translations, death, and mourning’ (Cadava 1997, p. 35). According to this understanding of reproduction, photography is not one technology among many, but the privileged mode of (re)production, which creates an *image* of the logic of the eternal return out of its inherent ability to reproduce. Unlike other mass-produced objects such as radios, jugs or light bulbs, every photo carries within it the mark of the reproductive process that never stops repeating itself. What this means is that while jugs, radios and light bulbs are produced by the eternal return of mass production as *identical* readymades, only the photo carries an indelible imprint of repetition within it which makes it an object of difference and not of identity. To say the same thing slightly differently: The reproduction of jugs, radios and light bulbs is given as part of a culture of mass production, but photographic reproduction is the way by which mass production itself is given, taken up and presented not as an image, but as the closest thing to an image (Deleuze 2004, p. 280).

Eternal return is representation

The technical process that is capable of making an infinite number of reproductions can be conceived of as analogical and representational if the emphasis is placed on the relationship between the original and the copy. However, this representational relationship can be overcome through the very same process if it is considered as the operation of displacement that produces eternal repetition. For Deleuze, the eternal return and representation are inextricably linked because representation is the first step of the return, yet after this first step, repetition takes over from representation and it is the force of repetition that introduces chance elements, noise, imperfections, and random patterns into the repeated copies. These random artifacts that are always produced, dissolve representation and allow difference to appear. As Deleuze explains:

The eternal return affirms difference, it affirms dissemblance and disparateness, chance, multiplicity and becoming. [...] The eternal return eliminates that which renders it impossible by rendering impossible the transport of difference. It eliminates the presuppositions of representation, namely the Same and the Similar, the Analogue and the Negative. For representation and its presuppositions return, but only once; they return no more than one time, once and for all, thereafter eliminated for all times.

(Deleuze 2004, p.373)

In principle, representation always creates ontological difference: either in the creation of identical copies from objects that differ or in creating difference by repeating identical copies (Deleuze 2004, p. 374). ‘Identical’ copies are always different both because the process introduces aberrations and ‘noise’ and because their place within the series of copies is different. This allows Deleuze to claim that identity is the real simulacra. However, within the context of the Western visual and philosophical traditions the difference of representation tends to be suppressed and managed by identity. This happens because representation operates within a framework of presuppositions that take as given such postulates as ‘thought’, ‘idea’ and ‘being’. Because

representation finds itself in the service of these concepts and for that reason grounded in identity, it seeks to locate similarities between disparate objects, suppressing difference and taking identity as its own true essence. In this way representation becomes the vehicle of identity (Deleuze 2004, p. 375).

Identity and difference

To begin to understand the extraordinary purchase of photographic representation on the contemporary mind-set, one might want to explore the procedure by which photography offers an idea of truth that appears so very natural – truth as the logic of visual resemblance. Deleuze has already showed resemblance to be an ethical and moral force (2004, p. 334) because it necessarily suppresses difference in favour of identity. Walking down the street one sunny day I bump into an old friend who is the parent of identical twins. My response might be to exclaim “they are so similar!”, and yet, it would be equally true to say, “they are so different!” – so why is it that we privilege identity over difference so automatically? And more pointedly, what are the political consequences of honouring identity, resemblance, and homogeneity over difference, and doing so intuitively, as a matter of common sense? In a world where similarity has the upper hand and difference is suppressed and managed by resemblance, what is it like to be different, whether this idiosyncrasy is expressed in the colour of one’s skin, sexual preference, manner of speaking, political tendencies or simply the inability to ‘fit’, ‘get along’, ‘blend in’ and ‘make sense’.

A fundamental consequence of the principle of identity is that the photograph allows the eye to break through the image surface, to extend the gaze beyond the materials of the photograph, into space (Lyotard 2011, p. 53). For as long as the photograph operates as a depiction of an external reality, it presupposes the presence of an authority that evaluates similarities between the copy and the model and passes a verdict on the accuracy of the resemblance. Consider the passport photo: it implies that someone is on hand to make a judgment about the bearer of the document, based on their similarity to the photograph. These days, a decision can be made not by a human border guard but by biometric recognition algorithm (Jain *et al.* 2004), but it changes little, as algorithms are the present-day apparatus of governance (Parisi 2014). Because resemblance presupposes the faculty of judgment, it automatically installs the notion of an external observer who assesses the correspondence between the image and the person. There can be no correspondence without a judge, as someone must compare and evaluate the resemblance between the model and the copy. In short, representation is never only a question of depiction, illustration, or aesthetics, it is a matter of constituting an authority endowed with the power to pass judgment, to stop, to detain, to examine and to arrest (Lyotard 2004, p. 11).

Whether in a passport or on a gallery wall, the photograph sets up a relationship between the subject and a governing authority, and this mechanism is founded on the notion that visual resemblance is a form of truth. ‘Representation is a sight of transcendental illusion’, Deleuze concludes in *Difference and Repetition*, ‘it is the moral vision of the world which is thereby extended and represented in this subjective identity affirmed as a *common sense*’ (2004, p. 334). What makes photographs such powerful agents of morality in the service of the state apparatus, is that they affirm that the law is just, ethical judgments are true and hierarchies of resemblance are objectively valid, and they do so from within the undeniable space of optical resemblance between images and things. It is precisely because photographic resemblance is so ‘natural’ that it acquires the rank of objective truth. In other words, considered from the perspective of representation, photographs are agents of the state because they ground truth in the logic of identity, and so they produce both the authority to evaluate this resemblance and a subject who

submits to it (Agamben 2009: 11). But when, and for what reasons did we come to consider resemblance as capable of producing true or false statements? What discursive practices, institutions and reasoning are needed to convince us that images are the visual manifestation of what is signified, i.e. of concepts such as truth, justice and knowledge and what aspects of the image have to be cancelled, ignored and forgotten for the image to assume this symbolic function?

Getting out of this transcendental illusion of representation requires revisiting the place where it was set up as the iron law of nature. As Deleuze explains it is taking place in Platonism: The primary distinction which Plato rigorously establishes is the one between the model and the copy. However, while distinguishing the model and the copy Plato also sets up a relationship of identity between them to claim that the copy is the confirmation of the logic of identity. To keep this identity Plato must draw a sharp distinction between a true copy and a false one. As Deleuze says: 'The Platonic wish to exorcize simulacra is what entails the subjection of difference' (Deleuze 2004, p. 333). Hence, representation understood as the eternal return of the different has no place in the Plato's metaphysics. It also follows that photography must find its place within the order of simulacra to recover its essence as difference at a standstill.

Arrogance of scientism

The origin of optical realism is usually attributed to the Greeks, specifically quoting the passage in Pliny the Elder about the tracing of a shadow on the wall by a young woman 'who was in love with a young man; and she, when he was going abroad, drew in outline on the wall the shadow of his face thrown by the lamp' (Pliny 1986, p. 43). The story of the making of the first shadow image is said to constitute a break with the imaging tradition of the East and mark the beginning of rational aesthetics (Gombrich 1995, pp. 78–82). But the representational image positioned itself in antagonism not only to the mythological Oriental image but also to the simulacrum and saw 'the other' in both: From its inception visual representation is in polemical opposition not only to the archaic, mythical and religious imagery but also to the visual manifestations of simulacrum: optical illusion, deception, *trompe-l'oeil* and mirage. Isabelle Stengers addressed this situation in the opening pages of *Cosmopolitics I* where she asks after the consequences of conceiving the world through a rigid scientific framework. Her concern in posing this question is that the rational discourse of scientism is leading humanity down a 'narrow path' which prohibits considering any entities that might be unknowable or ambiguous. This does not only imply ruling out myth and rhetoric, but also the exclusion of complexities and multiplicities that accommodate the co-existence of incommensurable or contradictory entities (Stengers 2010, pp. 1–3). As Stengers points out, the exclusion of everything which cannot be verified or rationally confirmed is not a recipe for avoiding being caught in ideological battles but exactly the opposite: scientific discourse is always susceptible to intolerance and arrogance whenever strands of scientific research find themselves in conflict with each other (Stengers 2010, p. 3). Stengers' diagnosis of scientism can be said to equally apply to photography and not only by analogy, but also because photographic imaging such as radiography, photo-micrography, and micro-imaging plays part in some of the key practices in a number of scientific disciplines. Equally, Stengers solution seems to apply to the problem of photography, as Stengers proposes a method that resists scientism while also resisting reaffirming the metaphysical foundations of science. Stanger argues that 'To state that the physical brain must obviously explain thought precludes one from accepting the possibility of multiplicity in which the notion of thought can have an immanence beyond being attributed to a pre-given process' (Stengers 2010, p. 16). In the case of photography, it can also be proposed that it is too static and to

limiting to suggest that photographs must obviously be explained by looking at them because such explanations are blind to the fact that phenomena have an excess that is greater than what can be rationally verified. As Stengers says: ‘Because it *exists* nature can bend to the requirements of the causal postulate only partially. It manifests itself, therefore, in its “irrationality”, in the resistance the effort at identification always runs up against’ (Stengers 2010, p. 16).

The rest of this chapter develops the question of the ‘irrationality’ of the photographic image through examining the exclusion of irrationality (in the form of sophism and the *pharmakon*) from the philosophical discourse in Plato and the parallel exclusion of simulacra from the discourse of visibility.

II. Simulacrum and Platonism

The ambiguity of the image in Plato

In Book X of the *Republic* poets and artists are banned from the ideal city because their craft (*technē*) is simulacra which deludes the audience into thinking that it can bestow true knowledge while in fact it is nothing but empty rhetoric and optical illusions (Plato 1997b, p. 597d–e). However, the banishment of painters and poets reveals an ambiguity with the Platonic discourse itself: The discourse within which the danger of images is most strongly presented is in turn based on a compelling image – the image of the cave (Plato 1997b, pp. 514–517). The image is therefore presented by Plato as ambiguous, forever changeable and capable of producing both fallacies and truths. It is precisely this ambiguity that Derrida picks up upon when he says:

In order for writing to produce [...] the opposite effect from what one might expect, in order for this *pharmakon* to show itself, with use, to be injurious, its effectiveness, its power, its *dynamis* must, of course, be ambiguous. [...] It is precisely this ambiguity that Plato [...] attempts to master.

(Derrida 2004, p. 103)

How is it possible for Plato to use an image to warn against the perils of images and imitation? The answer seems to be directly connected to the overall aim of Platonism, which is to teach the ‘idea of the good’ by means of learning to distinguish between appearance and reality in all spheres of life (Plato 1997b, pp. 504d–505b). To achieve this distinction, the so-called Socratic method has two interconnected parts. First is self-examination, for the search is for ethical or moral truths, second is the criticality of the self-examination, for the aim is to establish the truth, and not self-awareness.

As images are perceptions, they have the inherent tendency to deceive the senses, and even the most rational reasoning cannot completely overcome this. Nevertheless, some images have the ability to point towards truth, while others are inherently deceitful. The difference between these two types is in their ‘self-awareness’: those images that declare their ‘imageness’ can point towards the truth of things because they are capable of sustaining within themselves two forms of knowledge: the phenomenological knowledge of the thing they represent and the rational knowledge of themselves as representation. For instance, in using the simile of the cave, Plato declares this to be an image by framing it as a fable within the larger narrative of the dialogue. The fable is a powerful heuristic device that allows one to grasp the truth precisely because at its ground there is the knowing of knowing it as a fable (Wolff 1988). Similarly, a visual image can be effective in showing an object as it is, only if, as well as showing the object, the image also manifests itself as an image. As Nishida Kitarō explains, to know a thing through its

representation and to know representation as representation are two different forms of knowledge. The knowing of representation as representation marks the possibility of change and brings into being the notion of chronological time (Nishida 2012, pp. 37–8). Plato's objection to the poets and painters is precisely that they disguise the imageness of their images (Plato 1997b, p. 598b–c).

Simulacrum and politics

In *Aesthetics After Metaphysics* Miguel Beistegui comments that an image that disguises its own imageness lacks self-awareness because being purely phenomenological (sensual) it seeks not to point towards some truth or idea but to replace it with a fake, without however acknowledging the fakeness of the fake. Simulacra is therefore an image that repudiates the basic postulate of Plato's doctrine about the distinction between truth and appearance, for the phantasm (simulacra) maintains that all is appearances and that all appearances are truths (Beistegui 2012, p. 14).

In the context of the Platonic distinction between likeness and simulacra Beistegui stresses Plato's position as essentially ethical response to the political situation in Athens. What motivates Plato in drawing this distinction between images that are true representations and images that are simulacrum is not an aesthetic consideration, not even a purely philosophical one, he is driven by the desire to counterbalance the potential for anarchy and nihilism that in his view threatened democratic Athens. Plato seeks to establish a moral order that distinguishes between real claimants for truth and false pretenders. Beistegui quotes Deleuze in support of his argument who says that Plato's project was 'a matter of distinguishing the splendid and well-grounded Apollonian appearances from the other, insinuating, malign and maleficent appearances... the world of representation will more or less forget its moral origin and presuppositions' (Deleuze 2004, p. 333).

Two technologies of production

However, as will be discussed in some detail below, the distinction between likeness and simulacra is more nuanced and subtle than saying that likeness is Apollonian while simulacra Dionysian: an image can be both a resemblance *and* a simulacrum, both copy and difference, both idea and affect. The reason for that is that likeness and simulacra are not simply two regimes of visibility but also two technologies of production that relate to two ways of meaning construction. In this sense simulacrum is not an opposition to a true likeness, but it is a kind of image that exposes the fallacy of truth. By producing an image economy that does not relate at all to the true–false opposition, the simulacrum exposes the opposition itself as untrue. In other words, simulacrum threatens Platonism not with its 'other' but with exposing Platonism itself as simulacra.

As will be discussed below, Simulacra is not a corrupt representation, it is the rejection of representation in favour of a regime of affirmation and of similitude that multiplies affirmations instead of dividing them dialectically into true and false statements. The simulacrum is interested in (re)producing undifferentiated doubling, repetition and noncommunicable dimensions of signs. As such it destroys the opposition truth-image not to substitute it with another opposition but to make all oppositions impossible and void. In place of the binary subject–object it puts forward repetition, transgression, and rupture, what Lacoue-Labarthe calls 'generalised instability' (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 120).

This however does not imply that all meaning is being abandoned. For as Stengers suggests, simulacrum is the embodiment of instability which does not hide its rhetorical and persuasive

powers, it does not pretend to be ‘scientifically demonstrable’ or ‘objectively correct’ (Stengers 2010, pp. 28–30). Even more crucially, Stengers declines to see the simulacrum in opposition to rationality: ‘[It] refuses to be excluded, it inhabits the heart of the fortress that are supposed to protect us from instability’ (Stengers 2010, p. 30).

Sophist

In Plato’s dialogue the ‘Sophist’ the main aim is to recognise the distinction between a sophist and a philosopher, but along the way the conversation between the Visitor and Theaetetus explores the nature of imitation. The Visitor attempts to educate Theaetetus about the nature of images by demonstrating to him that there are two types of images; those that accurately copy the proportions and length, breadth, and depth of the model in order to create a faithful likeness, and those who intentionally distort the proportions of the image in order to deceive the senses (Plato 1997b, p. 236d–e). Significantly, the second type of images, which the Visitor names *phantasm*, or simulacrum in Latin, is defined as insincere and deceptive because the simulacrum is an image that has no reference in the real, organic world. Simulacrum is making us believe that ‘that which is not is’ (Plato 1997b, p. 237a).

As the dialogue goes on to show, the reason simulacrum can appear as a convincing forgery is due to the technology that receives help from the scientific advances in perspective, and foreshortening. Those artists who sculpt or draw exceptionally large works distort the true proportions ‘of their beautiful subjects’ in order to make them look harmonious, but on close inspection these images are not beautiful but monstrous. (Plato 1997b, p. 236a) The simulacrum therefore is not just the mythological dance of Dionysus, but also advanced engineering applied to the making of art. It is because simulacrum is the way by which monstrosity enters representation that images are ontologically significant to the development of philosophical thought, not as abstract aesthetic concepts but as specific technologies that articulate representation in the visual field. The distinction between truth and falsehood is not first proved philosophically and then applied to distinguish between types of images. Rather, it is articulated within the visual field in parallel to philosophical articulation. To begin teasing out this move it is essential to situate the problem of representation and simulacra in relation to the technologies of image production by outlining the way notions of subjectivity and identity are set up through regimes of visual representation.

Pharmakon

As the Sophist dialogue shows, simulacrum is closely aligned with the teachings of the sophists who openly relied on rhetoric, manipulations and word games, rather than on dialectical reasoning. According to Isabelle Stengers the sophists:

were treated with opprobrium by philosophers, and were referred to as the philosopher’s other: they were the ones who bartered the truth, who claimed to heal the city’s ills without first obtaining knowledge of good and evil, who exploited the shadows and appearances of the ‘cave’ rather than seeking the veridical light that reveals things in their proper guise.

(Stengers 2010, p. 28)

In Stengers analysis, the figure of the sophist suggests an alternative to the rationalist thought that is drawn towards positivism, perpetually battling against anything that cannot be factually

shown or experimentally proven. The question Stengers wants to pose, and to which the figure of the sophist is in part the answer, is whether scientific thought that is concerned with nothing other than facts can address the presuppositions of its own logic, and what are the ideological, political, and psycho-social consequences of such logic still being unexamined.

By drawing on the concept of the *pharmakon* as a drug that can both do damage and good, either cure or make ill, either strengthen or weaken, Stengers suggests that this kind of ambiguity is prevalent in most cultures, however the West is unique in attempting to exclude all ambiguity and to be left with either a cure or a poison, either strength or weakness (Flusser 2012).

This is also the opinion of Derrida in the essay *Plato's Pharmacy*:

The 'essence' of the *pharmakon* lies in the way in which, having no stable essence, no 'proper' characteristics, it is nor, in any sense (metaphysical, physical, chemical, alchemical) of the word, a *substance*. [...] It is rather the prior medium in which differentiation in general is produced, along with the opposition between the *eidōs* and its other; this medium is *analogous* to the one [...] which belongs neither simply to the sensible nor simply to the intelligible, neither simply to passivity nor simply to activity.

(Derrida 2004, pp. 125–6)

According to Derrida, it is precisely this ambiguity that Plato is unable to tolerate and for this reason decides to banish it from his own philosophy:

Plato decides in favor of a logic that does not tolerate such passages between opposing senses of the same word [...] and yet [...] the *pharmakon*, if our reading confirms itself, constitutes the original medium of that decision, the element that precedes it, comprehends it, goes beyond it, can never be reduced to it, and is not separated from it by a single word.

(Derrida 2004, pp. 98–9)

In Derrida's reading, the exclusion of ambiguity or irrationality from the discourse of philosophy is itself an act of covert irrationality which is brought back and installed within philosophy but only as contraband, without it being ever acknowledged as such. The problem of *pharmakon* allows to name the instant when representation enters Plato's argument. For Socrates truth is not so much discovered but *recovered* through recollection as the dialogue *Meno* illustrates. In this dialogue *Meno* is concerned with the nature of learning. Socrates argues that people are born with innate knowledge, so all that is left for the educator to do is to remind the student of things that on some level they already know (Plato 1997b, pp. 82b–89c).

This however creates an additional problem, as even though truth is already known in advance and only needs to be recalled, direct contact with it is not possible because truth in itself prohibits perception. In *Phaedo* Plato explains it thus:

I feared that my soul would be altogether blinded if I looked at things with my eyes and tried to grasp them with each of my senses. So I thought I must take refuge in discussions and investigate the truth of things by means of words.

(Plato 1997b, p. 99e)

Socrates's solution is to arrive at truth by 'discussions' and by 'means of words', i.e. through discursive reasoning. This however begs the question: How can Socrates be sure that discussions will lead him to truth? It seems that here a tension arises which, as Bell says 'is central to Plato's

thought: namely, there is both necessity of otherness, and the necessity to suppress and eliminate otherness' (Bell 2006, p. 70). In other words, discourse is Plato's chosen method to represent truth, however this means that the truth of the discourse has to be accepted as a given, as ipso facto grounded in truth. And yet, it was already shown that truth cannot be experienced directly which means that the assumed connection between discourse and truth is itself unfounded. In this way discourse is exposed as laying a claim to something it claims cannot be claimed. It is this ambiguity that allows Derrida to expose Plato's internal contradiction (Derrida 2004, p. 125).

III. A question of ethics

Expulsion of ambiguity from the Western cannon

According to Derrida, the denunciation of the pharmakon is the moment when Western metaphysical thought is being established as the thought of opposites that does not tolerate ambiguity, and undecidability yet it is also the moment when thought is being irreparably scarred by this act of driving out uncertainty (Derrida 1998a, pp. 1–42). Nevertheless, it is significant that the metaphysical foundations of Western theory of knowledge is founded on the distinction between real and copy, or essence and appearance specifically within the context of visual representation. In *Typography* Lacoue-Labarthe demonstrated that the notion of the representation (and of subjectivity) enters the Platonic dialogue through the discourse of the mirror image: 'The "paradigm of the mirror" is therefore – in fact – a paradigm of *Darstellung*' (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 89). The requirement to purify thought from ambiguity by excluding the sophist and his remedy (pharmakon) from the philosophical discourse is paralleled by the demand that the visual image be emptied of its own signs of otherness, undecidability and ambiguity. Because the simulacrum is inherently ambiguous, it is considered as an unacceptable form of visual expression (Camille 1996, p. 31). Yet, as will be shown below, it is not more possible to drive ambiguity and undecidability from the visual image than it is possible to exclude it from thought: in both instances the gesture of exclusion itself brings back the undecidable. It is precisely because simulacra and pharmakon are excluded from metaphysical thought that Richard Rorty can summarise the trajectory of Western thought as representation:

Philosophy's central concern is to be a general theory of representation, a theory which will divide culture up into the areas which represent reality well, those which represent it less well, and those which do not represent it at all (despite their pretence of doing so).

(Rorty 2009, p. 3)

Internal contradiction of Platonism

According to Lacoue-Labarthe, Plato's oversight it to consider 'truth' (*aletheia*) as the be-all and end-all of knowledge. It is Plato's adherence to truth as the highest value that makes him unable (or unwilling) to step out of dualistic and metaphysical thought. Plato's theory of knowledge is essentialist because it is taking as absolute given the priority and the rational justification of reflection, which is based in nothing else then *doxa*, i.e. the common knowledge: the unverified beliefs that were so skilfully manipulated by the rhetoricians and the sophists who explicitly reject the dialectical method and have no regard for 'truth' (*aletheia*). Plato ends up having to rely on precisely the same thing that he accuses the sophist of relying on, namely, the manipulation of common opinions for his own ends and needs. According to Deleuze, Plato is driven

to this internal contradiction because his implicit aim is to oppose the forms of immanence set up by the Greek society of his time. Plato ends up reinstalling a form of transcendence i.e., bringing back an external rule in the form of ‘truth’ or ‘thought’ with the aim of restoring some form of hierarchical order (Deleuze 1998, pp. 136–7).

A mirror mirroring itself

One way out of this impasse is hinted at by Lacoue-Labarthe in *Typography*, where he suggests that Plato’s error is that he seeks to find truth through the figure of the discourse, or – which is the same thing – to restore truth by means of mimesis (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 118). The problem that Plato is unable to overcome is that both discourse and mimesis have this in common: they institute the ‘subject’ at the centre of the question of truth which has the consequence of reducing truth to anthropology. The solution to this problem, and the way to ‘truth’ is, in the words of Lacoue-Labarthe ‘certainly difficult to confront head on, but nevertheless simple’ (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 121). What is needed, in effect, is to disentangle the question of truth from the question of the subject. Subjectivity necessarily brings with it the problem of reflection which positions truth as abstract and gives reflection the power to mediate between truth and the subject. To free truth from subjectivity means to free truth from the representational image. Truth cannot survive representation neither in a discourse nor in a painting because the moment representation appears it takes subjectivity as a given and truth then becomes the truth of the subject. The way out of the standstill of representation is shown by Lacoue-Labarthe with remarkable clarity:

[A]n unstable *homoiosis* that *circulates* endlessly between inadequate resemblance and resembling inadequation, confounding memory as well as sight, upsetting the play of *aletheia* and indeed carrying its breakdown right up to the very means of signifying its difference – so inapprehensible (imperceptible) is the agitation that this unstable *homoiosis* imparts to the Same.

(Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 121)

Instead of an image as the *reflection* of truth (as Plato would have it), Lacoue-Labarthe proposes something altogether much less binary, yet he is not proposing to discard the image completely but, in a move that is reminiscent of Deleuze he looks to recover the eternal return from within representation. In this diagram the likeness (representation) is replaced with *endless circulation* between likenesses suggesting an image economy that is based not on representation but on *mise-en-abyme*: an abyssal logic that takes repetition as the guiding principle rather than truth. This abyssal logic rejects the model of the mirror reflection with its clear-cut distinction between the reflection and the subject. Instead, it installs two mirrors that face each other, endlessly reflecting reflections but without ever creating an identical copy. In this way the representational image is overcome in favour of something altogether much more fractal, self-referential, fragmented, and unfinished. The endlessly circulating reflection creates a form of knowledge that has no purchase in either truth or mimesis. As the mirror mirroring itself creates not representations but fractals, it does not create any finished states or any fixed images, yet at any point the process can be stopped and at any point the result will be different without changing any of the elements of the set-up (Massumi 1992, p. 37). Instead of representation there is now a rhythm of reflections that establishes certain order and certain regularity or as Deleuze and Guattari say a ‘plane of consistency’ but without drawing on external authority for verification (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, pp. 70–73).

Forgetting of the pre-subjective

For Lacoue-Labarthe, the genesis of the Platonic move which places truth as the ground of philosophy and sets up subjectivity as the guarantor of truth is in his desire to forget the mythological origin of rational thought. Plato wants to make thought independent and self-sufficient, not reliant on either *doxa* or myth. For this reason, Lacoue-Labarthe can claim a direct link between the *Republic* and the Lacanian ‘Mirror Stage’: both share:

a kind of virile stiffening and anxious clenching as well as a resentment against the original maternal domination and original feminine education, these being always the sign, for the subject, of its constitutive incompleteness, of its belatedness (impossible to overcome) with respect to its ‘own’ birth, and of its natural incapability of engendering itself (or at least assisting in or attending its own engenderment).

(Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 127)

Here, in the closing paragraphs of *Typography*, Lacoue-Labarthe finds the one thing that ‘truth’, ‘subjectivity’ and ‘mimesis’ have in common: it is the forgetting of the pre-subjective without which there would be no subjective. Lacoue-Labarthe names this desire for autonomy (the forgetting of the forgotten) as the driving force of Western philosophy as a whole, up to Hegel: ‘the subject theorizing its own conception and engendering itself in seeing itself do so’ (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 127).

Politics of simulacrum

For Deleuze simulacrum does not simply undermine the Platonic distinction between essence and appearance, but suggests a different logic, one that is not based on representation:

If we say of the simulacrum that it is a copy of a copy, and infinitely degraded icon, and infinitely loose resemblance, we then miss the essential, that is, the difference in nature between simulacrum and copy [...]. The problem no longer has to do with the distinction Essence-Appearance or Model-Copy. This distinction operates completely within the world of representation. Rather, it has to do with undertaking the subversion of the world – the ‘twilight of the idols’.

(Deleuze 1990, pp. 295, 299)

The simulacrum is not a hall of mirrors or a proliferation of copies without recourse to an original, because such models are still based on a representational paradigm even if the relationship between original and copy is replaced by infinite number of identical copies without an original. Deleuze’s aim is to use the concept of simulacrum to expose the pre-philosophical ground of Platonism and of Western metaphysics as a whole: Deleuze’s analysis is that Plato is caught between two political models, that of transcendence and that of immanence. On the one hand, Plato is concerned to escape the oppressive autocratic regime of Eastern empires, which prohibits free thinking and where knowledge is decided by the authority of the king or the appointed sage, and philosophy cannot even get started. But on the other hand, Plato is also weary of the free-for-all democracy of the Athenian polity where all external authority is eliminated in favour of a flat playing field, where truth cannot be determined in advance but only fought for. Plato sees imminent danger in the premise of Athenian democracy that anyone can lay claim to anything if they can convince the peoples’ assembly that they are the best man

for the job. Plato seeks to counter this anarchic state of affairs by proposing a method of decision making that is based not on rhetorical excellence but on the clear-cut division between truth and fallacy. In effect, Plato is establishing a new transcendent order from within philosophy by situating a relationship between original and copy as the ground of the discourse and by excluding immanence (marked here by simulacra) from his ideal city (Deleuze 1998, p. 137). Transcendence snicks back in because Plato wants to have a method for telling apart a false pretender from a true one: He seeks to discover a criterion by which authority can be established and he finds it in the formally logical operation of division (Deleuze 1990, pp. 291–2). For Deleuze, this is the moment where transcendence is brought into philosophy in the guise of a criterion designed to put an end to paradoxes and aporias. The exclusion of the simulacrum is being justified because it cannot pass the test of telling the false from the true. This is because the simulacrum rejects the opposition between true and false judgements and by dint of refusing to participate in dialectical reasoning it calls logical reason into question. (Smith 2005, p. 98)

Simulacrum is non-oppositional, groundless, untimely, and non-transcendent way of thinking which opposes dialectical reasoning. Simulacrum does not seek to attach itself to any notion of truth, rather it is the movement of transition between different states. Through the figure of the Simulacrum Deleuze shows that thought can be freed from dialectical reasoning. This allows him to articulate the mandate for a different kind of logic, one that is not bound to pre-given notions of truth while at the same time maintaining coherence which is needed for the creation of philosophical concepts.

The purchase of photography on the question of simulacra can be described as the movement of infinite repetition and continuous creation in which every new copy creates a moment of difference. An image is not a repetition of an earlier image but a moment of intensity that propels towards another moment. Viewed as an intensity photography is not an accumulation of identical replicas but a force of difference that creates newness by means of mechanical reproduction. Considered in this way photography is not spreading out from a single point of origin, endlessly repeating the same gesture, it is forming a network of reproductive instances where technology, understood as the power to make copies, presents itself as an image.

5 Latent image

I. The trap of the visual

Where is the latent image?

Until recently critical approaches to photography had one thing in common: they all shared in the implicit and incontrovertible understanding that photographs are a medium that must be approached visually; they took it as a given that photographs are flat surfaces to be looked at and they all agreed that it is only through the practices of spectatorship that the secrets of photography can be revealed. Whatever subsequent interpretations followed, the priority of vision in relation to the image remained unperturbed. This undisputed belief in the visibility of the photograph has such a strong grasp on theory that it imperceptibly bonded together otherwise dissimilar and sometimes contradictory methodologies, preventing them from noticing that which is the most unexplained about photography: the precedence of looking itself. This self-evident truth of visibility casts a long shadow on philosophy of photography because it blocks the possibility of inquiring after everything that is invisible, latent, and hidden. As an example of this amnesia of the invisible consider for instance the extent to which the latent image – a prerequisite for the formation of an ordinary photograph – is all but ignored by photographic theory. However, the triumph of the digital image as the contemporary form of photography forces a reevaluation of visibility because it is making it plain for all to see that the visible cannot account for everything that is taking place with images that begin their life as binary data, then processed algorithmically and driven to various points across the network not as individual pictures but as packets of data. This chapter suggests that contrary to a deeply rooted belief, online photography is not an image of the world, rather it is the post-representational and latent image of difference as it manifests through self-replication and proliferation that characterize imaging processes online.

The latent image occurs when photographic film is exposed to light and the action of the charged light particles on the silver halide grains forms sites of metallic silver. The changes to the film are on a molecular level and require subsequent chemical development to become visible. From the moment of exposure and up to the ensuing chemical development the latent image must be kept in light-tight film canisters or dark-slides until it is ready to be developed. Developing the film destroys the latent image since it converts silver halide crystals to metallic silver grains and produces the film negative. Given the fundamental importance of the latent image to the process of taking a photograph, it is thought provoking that it is habitually omitted from the orthodoxy of photographic criticism and theory. While the latent image has very specific meaning in photographic chemistry and physics as the invisible image left on the light sensitive surface by exposure, histories and theories of photography rarely devote more than a passing

reference to it, and while its importance to the photographic process is usually acknowledged on a technical level, photographic criticism has nothing to say about it, making it doubly invisible. Michel Frizot's monumental *New History of Photography* states that the latent image 'remains fundamental to the photographic process' yet it addresses it in a single paragraph (Frizot 1998, 61). Thus, the latent image is both 'fundamental' and there is nothing to say about it. It is the invisible image that has been forgotten and made invisible. The reluctance of theory to talk about this primordial state of the image can be considered symptomatic of the desire to focus on the visible and tangible image and ignore the invisible without questioning the basic premise of the distinction itself.

However, the transition towards electronically produced and algorithmically computed images suggests that the non-visual aspects of images are at least as important to meaning creation as visual qualities. It will be a mistake to approach such an image as an abstraction, as a representation of external reality or as a *painting with light* because there is always a multiplicity of forces at play that place the image in a range of contexts, assemblages, and situations. The hyper-growth in various forms of digital imagery for screens provides a quintessential example of this multiplicity at work. The triumph of the photographic image as the internally eloquent and profoundly apt expression of networked culture also provides a new lens upon which to investigate how representation affects norms of meaning-creation, and the ethical and political consequences of the acceptance of images as purveyors of truth. For instance, the emphasis placed on the visual content of images tends to obscure the processes of dissemination, production and dispersion that contain their own intelligent messages, quite apart from the semantic content that clings to the surface of the image. Indeed, the proliferation of various forms of automatically produced, read, and distributed images disrupts the familiar understanding of the photograph as a verisimilitude that provides reliable representation of reality.

Forgetting of the forgotten

While the latent image has very specific meaning in photographic chemistry and physics as the invisible image left on the light sensitive surface by exposure, this book expands the notion of the latent image to include the ability of the image to maintain a distinction between what the image *is* and what the image *is of* insofar as this distinction is charged with a certain embryonic content which is outside of the visible image and which is inaccessible to the forms of logic that are based in ocularcentrism. It is the claim of this chapter that the forgetting of the latent image is symptomatic to an approach that deals with the image as a sign or a trace of an absent signifier, while taking for granted such conceptual entities as 'representation', 'identity', 'thought', 'image', and 'being'. This forgetting of presence is of course not limited to photography but is indicative of a way of thinking that privileges visibility, rationality, and representation. As the paradoxical structure that defies the principle of identity, the latent image is a linchpin between the non-visible visual and post-metaphysical thought.

This chapter will explore the way by which photography can recover its own materiality by putting a limit to the rights of visibility and recovering the inscrutable space of the latent image. The suggestion advanced here is that to recover the sense of immanence in photography, the image as a visible surface must be muted and the latent image, as the invisible and the unknowable *other* of representation must be tuned into. In asking of photography to turn against itself I am following Adorno who is demanding of thought to become 'self-reflection of thinking... a thinking against itself' (Adorno 1983, p. 365), and Lyotard who says that the forgotten must be remembered as something that never ceases to be forgotten (Lyotard 1990, p. 3).

When photographic film or another light sensitive surface is exposed to light the action of the charged light particles on the silver halide grains forms sites of metallic silver on the film emulsion. The changes to the film because of the exposure are on a molecular level and require later chemical development to become visible. However, the latent image must remain invisible to avoid additional exposure to light which will ruin the image by exposing the remaining silver in the emulsion. From the moment of exposure and up to the later chemical development the latent image must be kept in total darkness and protected from contact with heat and radiation (for instance X-ray). In traditional photographic practice exposed film is kept in light-tight film canisters or dark-slides until it is ready to be developed. If the exposed film is preserved in total darkness, the latent image can survive for a long time. A famous example of the durability of the latent image are the negatives exposed by Nils Strindberg during the 1897 attempt to reach the North Pole in a hydrogen balloon. These negatives remained undeveloped for over 30 years, until they were discovered together with the remains of the expedition, in 1930 (Martinsson 2004).

We must judge the aesthetic, social, historical, and political aspects of the photograph, and yet we do not have the tools and the systems to address the hidden image from which the photograph originates. It is this ignorance of its own foundation, the inattentiveness to the conditions of its own possibility which makes the symptoms of photography so closely linked with the symptoms of philosophy (Laruelle 2011, pp. 1–7).

The movement from non-identity to identity

If the essence of photography is a mark or a trace of an object that was at some point in front of the camera, then the original trace is the invisible latent image. This is the stage of the process when a mark is being made and it is being preserved only for as long as the latent image persists. All the later operations performed on this inaccessible image are designed to make it available to the human eye. They subjectivise the image by turning it into something that can be looked at, but the very process that makes the image visible also destroys the original latent trace. As was discussed in the previous chapter, the forgetting of the passage between darkness to light, between false to true, between myth to logos is characteristic of Platonism's attempt to rid philosophy of the non-binary discourse of the simulacrum and forcing photography to confirm to the template of identify. The discourse of identity requires an anthropology, it demands a criterion with which to distinguish between the essential and the non-essential, but in the latent image such metaphysical considerations are unavailable because it is prior to the construction of content, prior to the construction of subjectivity and identity. Identity does not exist in darkness; identity requires visibility because without visibility there is no recognition, and without recognition there is no identity. The 'translation' that is taking place between the latent and the visible image is not the passage from one medium to another but the movement from non-identity to identity, or from the pre-philosophical to the philosophical. Derrida names it as the transference from a non-philosopheme into a philosopheme, the very passage into philosophy (Derrida 2004, pp. 71–72).

The characteristic description of the photographic process goes from light reflected of the object, to film being exposed in the camera and to the print being made of the developed negative. What is being left out of this description is not only that before a visible image can be made there has to be an invisible image, but much more significantly and tellingly that to the extent that it makes sense to talk about indexicality as the direct, unmediated connection between the object and the image, this connection is only supported for as long as the image itself is invisible. The light that is reflected from the object changes the molecular structure of

the film and in this way the object is *present* in the film, not as a re-presentation, not as mimesis, not as reflection but as (invisible) presence. However, none of this presence is left in the later stages of processing and developing; the chemical developer destroys the silver halides in which the object kept its physical existence and replaces them with a re-presentation in metallic silver. During the development stage a visible image is formed, and the invisible image is being eradicated.

To briefly describe the difference between the latent image and the negative: the former has no substance, no information, no description of the object. It is impossible to question the latent image about its content, for the act of questioning itself destroys the content and turns it into something else: Opening the light tight container instantly destroys the image. The latent image is unobservable. There is no way to sneak a quick look, to take a measurement, or access it in any other way, as any attempt to read it instantly destroys it. For this reason, there is no knowing what the latent image *is of*, there is only the knowing that it *is*. The undeveloped, latent image is not simply a 'hidden' image but undecidable in the same sense that the Schrödinger's Cat experiment considers the fate of the cat as undecidable; undecidability that is derived from the fact that the act of measurement itself affects the measured situation. Similar to the Schrödinger's Cat experiment, the latent image introduces a requirement for isolation between the moment of inscription by light that is taking place within the camera and the moment of 'developing' that is taking place when the negative is chemically processed. In this rupture the ontological condition of the photographic image is revealed as the difference between two incommensurable states. The principle of photography is not in the indexical connection between past and present, nor is it in the representation of abstract forms, but in the presentation of visibility as fundamentally invisible.

II. The originary trace

The photograph of philosophy

As was discussed in the earlier section, the latent image is a technical term from the vocabulary of photographic chemistry and physics that never made it into the philosophical or critical discourse of photography. However, this chapter looks to propose that the evacuation of the latent image from the theoretical and critical debate is symptomatic of the tendency to entrench the discourse within oppositional and binary categories. As the invisible image and the pre-condition for the visible, the latent image has the potential to subvert the representational paradigm that underpins most theorising of photography. If taken seriously as the primordial state of the photographic image, its ontological beginning and its pre-differentiated ground, the latent image is a persistent reminder that it is the image that makes seeing possible.

Because the latent image is invisible and unknowable it comes before the subject for whom the image is a representation. Subjectivity only appears when the image becomes a visible representation, but visibility also sets up an interval between the human subject and the world, isolating him/her, keeping at a distance. Representation has a duality about it: on the one hand it grants the subject autonomy because it allows to know the world without reliance on external Archimedean points such as God, absolute or myth, yet on the other hand representation also detaches the subject from the world because the world must be taken up and re-presented back to the subject. So, while representation creates autonomy, at the same time it establishes alienation as the condition of subjectivity (Colebrook 2000).

In the case of the latent image there is another structure at work, one that is not built around vision and light and the associated discourses of ocularcentrism and truth. Rather it is a

discourse of the image in which the thing is not represented, but present as a refrain of the eternal circulation of unknowable resemblance and resembling the unknowable (Lacoue-Labarthe 1998, p. 121). Considered in this way the latent image does not need to be the product of human hands. As Peter Geimer observes, the minimal definition of photography is: 'a body inscribes its image onto another body' (Geimer 2011, p. 36). And this inscription does not even need to be a visual one: perhaps on an onto-photo-logical level the latent image is the rhythmic refrain of the image in general, of the will-to-image if such thing can be imagined. It is both a readymade and the expression of movement.

What is so critical and a-radical about the latent image is that it precedes representation and what Derrida named as 'the metaphysics of presence' (Derrida 1998b, p. 65). As the trace of the thing, the latent image is neither visible nor invisible, but it shares conceptual consistency with the form of language that Derrida names 'arche-writing': a form of language that appears before 'writing in the usual sense' (Derrida 1998b, p. 128). In *Of Grammatology* Derrida situates the 'originary trace' prior to metaphysical or logocentric thought (Derrida 1998b, p. 47). Philosophy becomes possible with the idea that an image is a reflection or representation of truth. Similarly, as Lacoue-Labarthe shows in *Typography*, this is also the unspoken assumption behind Plato's insistence that discourse can lead, by way of dialectical reasoning, from *doxa* to *aletheia*.

The importance of the 'originary trace' for Derrida is due to his conception of representation as the necessary condition needed for the emergence of philosophy. Writing is not one act of creation among many but the essential foundation that situates the idea of truth as the ground of thought (Colebrook 1999, p. 107). In her commentary on this aspect of Derrida's thought Colebrook says: 'The possibility of metaphysics – as an idea of truth, meaning, law or right that precedes representation – does open thought to what lies beyond any of its present representations' (Colebrook 1999, p. 107). The possibility of going beyond metaphysical thought hinges on the ability of thinking the origin of thought which necessarily means thinking the lack of origin. It means in other words allowing thought to become undecidable, neither true nor false, inhabiting a state of pre-identity and indeterminacy. Under such conditions thought becomes homeless: it loses its privileged and overarching relationship with truth.

However, metaphysical thought cannot get started without prior idea that constitutes ground, either objective or subjective presuppositions that form the basis of rationality, and these presuppositions in turn rely on the logocentric conception of the sign. For Derrida this means that thought can contain movement, change and fluidity but only because every sign draws its justification from other signs in an infinite chain of regression. As meaning is always pre-determined on the existence of prior meaning there can be no certain and final truth, meaning becomes '*Difference*' – the indefinable state of an utterance whose meaning is forever deferred:

Without a retention in the minimal unit of temporal experience, without a trace retaining the other as other in the same, no difference would do its work and no meaning would appear. It is not the question of a constituted difference here, but rather, before all determination of the content, of the *pure* movement which produces difference, *The (pure) trace is difference*.

(Derrida 1998b, p. 62)

The photographic latent image fits well with Derrida's description of the '*pure trace*', or '*difference*' as the 'obliterated origin of absence and presence' which, despite being obliterated can still claim some form of presence. In this sense Derrida's description of the *différance* as that

which not only precedes metaphysics but also extends beyond the thought of being seems a fitting description of photography (Derrida 1998b, p. 145).

Keeping it latent

Read through Derrida's notion of the 'originary trace' the latent image suggests a possibility of thinking about a photograph not as an image of something but as the pre-metaphysical image-less image which produces an effect which, while not in-itself *logos*, nevertheless allows for thought to begin. The latent image can be conceived as both the affirmation of *différance* and as a viable way of escaping logocentrism while avoiding the necessity of grounding thought in representation. The reason such move might be possible is because the latent image is not a form of writing but a form of technology that places reproduction, rather than representation as the foundation of meaning. However, this move away from logocentrism can be successful if, and only if, the image is allowed to remain latent, i.e. invisible, unknowable, and non-translatable. Being unknowable, the latent image is pre-representational, and yet its existence is not assumed or logically deduced but manufactured by a mechanical process, as such it is a tangible object, albeit one that cannot be seen, because seeing it destroys it.

Photography brut

According to Kant, only the representable world can be known and nothing that is unrepresentable can be grasped by a human subject. Nevertheless, Kant proposed the *noumena* to designate the non-representable world inaccessible to humans yet independently existing (Kant 2007b, pp. 258–264). The latent image does not dispose with the idea of the ground, but it shifts it from representation to production, forcing the ground to become movable, to self-replicate and to hold within it a rhythm of production. As the latent image is unknowable it has no signifying meaning, however, it does carry within it a trace of a process of reproduction that gets started by dint of one body making an imprint on another body. This process is both pre-subjective and pre-linguistic, but it stores within it a certain force of becoming.

While the latent image might be considered accidental or even marginal to the photographic process it does seem to offer an image of the way *logos* as philosophical thought can come into being: On the one hand, the latent image is nothing more than a trace left by one body upon another, but at the same time it is a unique kind of trace because it is the invisible signature of a self-replicating technology. The latent image can be the 'image of thought' for a new kind of philosophy one that is closer to the essence of technology than to human *logos*.

The most significant feature of the latent image is that it is not a metaphor for the way rational thought is actualised out of *doxa* or myth, it can be conceived in Deleuze's terms as 'pure becoming' in which the object fulfils its potential for becoming other than itself. Following this strand of Deleuze's thought it is possible to mobilise the latent image against the creation of meaning through representation. The latent image is then not a step on the way to a legible image but a movement that has no other aim than becoming for its own sake. Deleuze and Guattari call this form of becoming 'art brut':

Can this becoming, this emergence be called art? That would make the territory a result of art. [...] Territorial mars are readymades. And what is called *art brut* is not at all pathological or primitive; it is merely this constitution, this freeing, of matters of expression in the movement of territoriality – the base or ground of art.

(Deleuze and Guattari 2003, p. 316)

This form of art is not meaningful or signifying because it has no content as such and because it announces only the fact of presence, only the *quid* without the *quod* (Lyotard 1984a, p. 205). Its expression is in establishing a boundary (territorialisation) that works through repetition: ‘the refrain is rhythm and melody that have been territorialized because they have become expressive – and have become expressive because they are territorializing’ (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, p. 317).

The refrain

The refrain here is set against the idea of the subject who establishes his own territory by drawing a circle in the sand and claiming that whatever is within the circle is theirs (Rousseau 2009). The subject is not the one who creates the refrain, the refrain is pure expressive force without ground and foundation. To think of photography as a refrain is to think of repetition as a more vital force than representation.

While many other kinds of images can be copied, photographs are pictures that explicitly carry the directions for their own copying within themselves. Photography’s ability to re-produce itself sets it aside from other visual forms, but the techniques that enable continuous reproduction not only safeguard logical and rational continuity between the original and the copy, but also give photography the affective powers of sharing, disseminating, reaching-out and touching. When an image is repeated, the second iteration overlaps with the first without becoming fully dissolved in it. This results in a series of ostensibly identical images that are nevertheless distinct from each other. Prints from the same photographic negative are said to be identical, but they bring into view a ‘reality segment’ (Golding 2010a) that can be named multiplicity. The very ability of being repeated several times suggests that the logic that operates within a multiplicity is different from the logic of representation, because no matter what is denoted in the visual content, repetition puts forward a non-dualistic and non-representational logic of production, distribution, and dissemination.

Plane of repetition

Repetition is never on the same plane as the content: content inscribes the image with meaning by treating it as a signifying surface. Content is semantic denotation that orders the world as a legible structure. But repetition does not deal with signification, rather it mimics the labour vested in the production of commodities: things that are mass-produced usually don’t carry with them the legend of their own production. For instance, the smartphone does nothing to remind its owner of the way it was manufactured, on the contrary, one could say that all traces of fabrication, assembly and labour were surgically removed to impart on its user that its origin is not production but immaculate conception. As an ethical strategy, repetition strips the veil of innocence from objects, revealing their secret logic of labour, made invisible and hidden from view by mass production. Bernd and Hilla Becher (2004) have explored the productive tension between representation and repetition in a series titled ‘Typologies of Industrial Buildings’. While adhering to the formal logic of classification based on visual resemblance between industrial constructions, Bechers’ work simultaneously exposes the ideological underpinnings of any such classification, for it requires the suppression of dissimilarities and the privileging of identity over difference. Representation operates on the level of content where each single image denotes an industrial object. But repetition operates between the images themselves, pointing out differences and suggesting that industrial production is not represented in photography, but that photography is essentially an industrial process. Bechers’ achievement is in demonstrating

that photography is not a form of visual communication, rather it embodies the logic of technological production that commands all forms of aesthetic expression.

Repetition is not accidental to photography; it is the mechanical gesture that ties together discrete representations and in so doing creates its own accidental and profound meanings that use the content of images as launching pads towards the forming of new sensations. What is being repeated is the content, but repetition is not on the same plane as the content. Most classic operas, pop songs, Spaghetti Westerns and reality TV shows make skilful use of folding and re-folding content to create repetition and therefore to communicate something entirely independently from the content in its unfolded state. 'Reality' shows like *The Apprentice*, for instance, adhere to a fixed pattern of scenes, so that the story of each episode is told by identical means, with only the content changing, and the format remaining strictly the same. Here repetition is much more than an organizing device: the viewer knows exactly what to expect at each moment and anticipates the next emotional peak not due to the actions of the contestants but because there is a rhythmic sequence that marks the boundaries between acts. The rhythm itself becomes expressive of the main messages of the show as it gets tied to motifs of sexual aggression, territoriality, and domination (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, p. 315).

The industrial process that makes photocopies is nothing if not a process of repetition, even if what is being repeated is symbolic representation of space. Representations follow one after another, representing this and that part of the world, but the repetition of the action of representation itself is a rhythmic beat that flows through all the photographed spaces, establishing another, deeper murmur of noises, glitches and distortions. Because representation repeats itself it creates a rhythm, and because it is a rhythm it is temporal, which is to say, it involves a process that folds and unfolds over time. Thus, photography has an exterior body made of temporal processes of production, and internal body made of framing devices and objects that are being framed, and an additional body made of ideological investments in questions of perception, truth, and resemblance. All its three bodies are coded, which is to say, they are subject to the rules of repetition, because code is that which must be infinitely copied to ensure its operational validity.

Getting the picture

It is by differing from the object that the latent image avoids becoming a sign in a signifying chain. The latent image is 'technology brut' in which the intensity of becoming is posited on the one hand on a multiplicity of the trace that can be mechanically repeated with each repetition creating difference, and on the other hand on producing an 'image' that is not attached to the semiotics of vision.

The picture that the latent image puts forward is not a picture in the sense of a likeness or a portrayal but it is also not as abstract as the picture in Heidegger's *The Age of the World Picture* (Heidegger 1977b). For Heidegger, the 'picture' was the way by which modern subjectivity got set up through a shift that occurred in the idea of representation in the modern era, from metaphorical and pictorial to scientific. Modernity in this sense is 'The Age of the World Picture' because the modern subject is the product of Descartes' and Kant's philosophies which declared representation to be the limit and the possibility of all knowledge. In other words, Heidegger is not saying that the world is now known through pictures or that the modern subject possesses a picture of the world, rather he is concerned to show that *picturing* is the modern way of engaging with reality and with being and that this way of engagement is, to some extent, not human. Everything that is known is known though picturing it. It is further significant that this form of picturing is directly connected to Heidegger's understanding of modern technology as a particular logic of the ability to grasp the 'out there' and,

simultaneously to be grasped by it. This relation of the image to the world enframes our world and forms our picture, even if the picture in question is not particularly visual. ‘Picture Here does not mean a visual image but rather what we hear in the colloquial expression “we get the picture”’ (Heidegger 1977b, p. 129)

For Heidegger, this drawing together of thinking and nothing is the task of thinking. However, the task is not in conceptualising their fusion, but in ‘experiencing this together in terms of belonging’ (Heidegger 2002, p. 29).

It is also worthy of note that towards the end of the second part of *identity and difference* Heidegger reasons that the ‘experiencing together’ is ultimately impossible because of the metaphysical structure of language (Heidegger 2002, p. 73). However, following the earlier discussion of the latent image as *arche-trace*, it is possible to consider it in terms of the onto-photo-logical primacy of the latent image over thought. The latent image jump-starts the possibility of thought because it establishes a regime of repetition in which technology takes being (matter) and through a process of self-replication creates a repetition which *ipso facto* is difference. In the latent image the actuality of the world and the virtuality of the image are fully merged not as separate entities but in an act of mutual production and creation. On this reading, the photographic image is neither actual nor virtual, rather it is the gap that creates the actual out of the virtual (Colebrook 2010, pp. 87–8).

III. Difference at a standstill

Forgetting photography

According to the passing references in the works of Deleuze and Deleuze and Guattari they do not consider photography as a site of *percepts* capable of responding to the environment in creative way that is productive of new insights. It is likely that Mieke Bleyen is right when she says that Deleuze and Guattari are indifferent to photography because they equate it with the logic of the documentary (Bleyen 2012, p. xi). Somewhat disappointingly, in the few instances when Deleuze and Guattari mention photography they consider it squarely within representational terms of reference as can be grasped from the following extracts: ‘short term memory is of the rhizome or diagram type, and long-term memory is arborescent and centralized (imprint, engram, tracing, or photograph)’ (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, p. 16), and ‘What we must do is reach the photographic or cinematic threshold; but in relation to the photograph, movement and affect one again took refuge above and below’ (Deleuze and Guattari 2003, p. 281). In considering photography from within the representational frame of reference Deleuze and Guattari follow in the footsteps of Adorno who did not see in photography the potential for negative dialectics and for non-identity, refusing to integrate photography into his vision of radical aesthetics (Adorno 1997). It is significant that Adorno considers montage as the appropriately dialectical medium that ‘rescues’ photography from its falsifying adherence to empirical reality. It is however even more interesting to ask why Deleuze overlooked the creative potential of photography. One possible response is that photography presents the same challenge for Deleuze that cinema presented for Bergson. As Deleuze explains in the opening chapter of *Cinema 1: the Movement Image*, Bergson failed to see the creative potential of cinema because for him it was an example of the homogenization of thinking and mechanization of time which he opposed to creativity and intuition (Deleuze 1992). As Colebrook says, ‘it was precisely where Bergson appeared to have stopped thinking’ (Colebrook 2010, p. 8). Bergson failed to see cinema’s potential to move beyond representation by presenting to consciousness non-human temporalities and previously unknown points of view. According to Deleuze, Bergson failed to notice that the cinematic apparatus creates the possibility

for radically new philosophy which does not seek the eternal but rather produces the new and the singular in the pre-human unity of intellect and intuition, made possible by cinematic technology that transfigures movement into any-instant-whatever (Deleuze 1992, p. 8). For his part, Deleuze considers photography as representation and does not see its potential to create an image of difference.

An image made not by human hand

However, the difference between representation and percept acquires specific meaning within the photographic context for it suggests that the photographic process and the camera liberate the image from the sensory-motor apparatus and offer a model of vision that goes beyond a human observer. In other words, a little bit of Captain Ahab's blood runs in Fox Talbot's veins. Herman Melville's *Moby Dick* was published in 1851. Photography was officially announced in 1839. Deleuze saw the unresolvable darkness of *Moby Dick* and felt strong kinship with Melville (Crawford 1997), yet he did not recognise the power of photography to generate schizophrenic folds, rhizomes and percepts. It is the contention of this book that photography is part of the imperceptible constellation of forces – like the compass of Captain Ahab that points not towards the magnetic north but in the direction of the whale. This section aims to suggest that since its inception as modern technology photography had something unresolvable and Dionysian about it. As Deleuze says: 'It is a question of causing a little of Dionysus's blood to flow in the organic veins of Apollo' (Deleuze 2004, p. 331).

While this claim can appear fanciful to someone who is considering photography as one of the most ubiquitous representational devices, or as the manifestation of copy realism, there are good grounds to suggest that during the early days of modern photography, it had something of Herman Melville's darkness about it. Consider for instance these words by the photography pioneer, Henry Fox Talbot: 'And this I believe to be the first instance on record, of a house having painted its own portrait' (Newhall 1982, p. 20). The above quotation dated 25 January 1839, suggests that for the inventor of the negative/positive process 'photogenic drawing' was not a straightforward representation but something altogether more *becoming*. The title of the paper Fox Talbot presented to the Royal Society on 31 January 1839 reinforces the notion of an image made not by human hand (*archeïropoietoi*): 'Some account of the Art of Photogenic Drawing, or, the Process by which Natural Objects May Be Made to Delineate Themselves without the Aid of the Artist's Pencil' (Newhall 1982, p. 20). The automatism of photography was noted by several nineteenth-century practitioners (Azoulay 2010). Subsequently, automatism of the new medium became a key assurance in photography's claim for truth, as the ability of the image to self-generate appears to warrant for the objectivity of the representation. Yet, the notion of a house having painted its own portrait can also be taken to mean the possibility of expression that is beyond and outside representation. A house that contemplates itself as an image is no longer a functional object but a site of pure sensation. The image painted by the house is filled not with its own reflection but with the enjoyment of sensation and contemplation (Deleuze and Guattari 1994, p. 212).

Image of immanence

The house that paints its own image is the very image of immanence; the expression of a possibility of life as a coming-to-being of an image without any rationalist foundation or of a power of self-expression as making a mark. Deleuze explains that immanence is not the rational

force of survival, but the power of self-actualisation (Deleuze 2005a, p. 27). As an antidote to binary thinking, immanence is a way of conceiving photography not as a representational mechanism but as sensation and self-actualisation. The image that the house itself paints does not rely on the idea of representation, it is not an image that relates to some fixed and pre-given form, it is the pure force to replicate not through the biological process of replication but through the technological process of reproduction. The automatism of the photographic image shows that here the technology of repetition leaves its mark within the image. The photograph is not only an image of a past moment available in the present, but it also an answer to the question: ‘What is the condition of possibility that makes the image possible?’

To answer this question requires thinking about photography not in terms of what one sees but in terms of the forces that constantly reshape it. It means to stop paying attention to the visual without however forgetting or ignoring the visible. To be able to affect and to be affected means allowing the latent image to enter the space of thought where it can take the place of the *now*. The failure of ocularcentrism is the failure of subjectivity to grapple with the unknowable, but where identity fails, where representation flounders, depth is rising to the surface without ceasing being depth and photography becomes the study of surfaces, the work of sense (Deleuze 1990, p. 33).

Sensations out of chaos

Ontologically, both images and objects (as well as thoughts and things) belong to the same source that Deleuze and Guattari refer to as ‘chaos’. Chaos here does not mean nihilism or that anything goes, rather this is a different kind of logic, one that is not seeking to establish meaning through recognition, but to identify patterns through repetition and difference (Bell 2006).

As the ground zero of the photography, the latent image is pure difference. In any case representation cannot appear as such if it were not preceded by the latent image which inaugurates the conditions out of which representation can appear. It is still to be shown that the latent image is not accidental to the photographic but constitutes the field of expressive and dynamic multiplicity which determines the visual and yet it is inaccessible to metaphysical thought. The latent image is excluded not only from the discourse of photography but also from the philosophical discourse that takes representation as its ground because it is unable to deal with the unknowable that refuses to have ‘characteristics’ or to maintain a relationship with notions of truth (*aletheia*) and memory (mimesis). For that reason, to the extent that the latent image needs its own post-metaphysical discourse to articulate it as a form of aesthetics that draws its inspiration from difference rather than from identity and representation, post-metaphysical thought needs the latent image as the ‘image of thought’ (Deleuze 2004, pp. 164–174) that can get the post-metaphysical move started.

Given the unknowability of the latent image, it requires a non-ocularcentric logic, one that privileges the *quod* over *quid*, logic that states ‘it is happening’ before questions about what it is and about its significance (Lyotard 1984a). For this reason, the latent image is closer to what Lyotard names ‘an event, an occurrence’ while Deleuze names this kind of surface ‘singularity’. Singularities are impersonal and pre-individual; they are free from a representational baggage. In singularity the image and the non-image enter into co-presence forming a surface without meaning or depth (Deleuze 1990, p. 159). The logic at work here is not the logic of signs, signifiers, and concepts, it is the sensual logic of the percept, of which Deleuze and Guattari say that it has nothing to do with resemblance. While resemblance is concerned with meaning, the percept is the sensation of the material; the affective quality of the material that constitutes the artwork.

As percepts, sensations are not perceptions referring to an object (reference): if they resemble something it is with a resemblance produced with their own methods... If resemblance haunts a work of art, it is because sensation refers only to its material: it is the percept or affect of the material itself, the smile of oil, the gesture of fired clay, the thrust of metal, the crouch of Romanesque stone, and the ascent of Gothic stone.

(Deleuze and Guattari 1994, p. 166)

As percept, the latent image resonates with its own materiality, its own latency. Its resemblance is with itself, the sensation it evokes does not concern the eye or the mind because this is an unreadable, auto-mimetic image that works through difference, not resemblance. It is resistant to copy, imitation or representation, yet it restores the kind of presence that Lyotard connects with the anti-representational and the unnameable '*is*'. The convention that photography is light-made-legible is so pervasive that it is strange to think that the latent image has no legible signs, it carries no inscriptions, yet it is itself a kind of sign, a hieroglyph that marks the presence not of the object but of the process by which an object is being made present. The object leaves its mark not by writing itself into the picture (discourse) but by making itself into an inscription. The latent image is the 'other' of the image that makes the visible possible. In the latent image the photograph recovers its own form of writing, its photo-grammatology, its typo-photo-graphy. The evacuation of representation and truth from the image is also the evacuation of memory and subjectivity. The auto-mimetic space does not belong to the chronology of instant moments, it is alien to linear time. While photography in general is often read semi-otically though the devices of signifier, signified, absence, negation and lack, the latent image is non-discursive, pre-individual affirmation of presence.

Image or object?

The latent image delineates the one-sidedness of photographic theory that considers photography solely from the perspective of the image. Approached through the representational model, the photographic image is the universal floating signifier that mediates everything, making everything into images but fails to speak of that which lies-to-hand, of the materiality of the *now*, of which Lyotard says that it contains the possibility of nothing happening (Lyotard 1984a). This is the reason why several attempts were made to turn the tables on representation by subtracting it from the photograph. For instance, Elizabeth Edwards says:

a photograph is a three-dimensional thing, not only a two-dimensional image. As such, photographs exist materially in the world, as chemical deposits on paper, as images mounted on a multitude of different sized, shaped, coloured and decorated cards, as subject to additions to their surface or as drawing their meanings from presentational forms such as frames and albums.

(Edwards and Hart 2004, p. 7)

The aim of this turn towards the materiality of the image was to criticise the one-sidedness of the photographic discourse and to propose that the photograph has material existence as an object. However, both the representational approach that ignores the object and the object-oriented approach that ignores the image are oblivious to the consideration that an image is not only the reflection of a thing but also *a thing*. The representational approach ignores the 'thingness' of photography, treating it as an abstract signifier while the object-oriented approach ignores the image that the photograph contains focusing on the materials, processes and

histories of the photograph as an object. The representational approach is right to say that the photograph is an image, but it is wrong to say that the image is nothing but a representation, while the object-oriented approach is right to say that the photograph has material presence, but it is wrong to find it in the paper, chemicals, and frame and not in the image. In both cases something essential about photography is being forgotten or ignored. What is needed is not to forget either the object or the image but to raise the image to the level of an object by recovering the *invisible* in the image, by drawing on the perception of that which cannot be seen *in the image* and by overcoming the opposition between vision and expression. The latent image is important here because it does not detract attention from the image but demands to consider the image not in terms of the visible, not in terms of the signifier and the logic of representation but in terms of the force that imprinted itself on the image *without* making itself visible.

The image as force and becoming

Deleuze says that the nature of the immanent invisible is ‘to make visible those forces that are not visible’ (Deleuze 2005b, p. 43). The notion of the force however requires clarification, as it is key in understanding the move Deleuze initiates away from representation:

We will never find the sense of something (of a human, a biological or even a physical phenomenon) if we do not know the force which appropriates the thing, which exploits it, which takes possession of it or is expressed in it.

(Deleuze 2006, p. 3)

Deleuze is not looking to define the relationship of forces between the subject and her environment in terms of the master–slave dialectic in which the subject triumphs over the landscape or over another human, or becomes the victim, crashed by nature or by another’s will. Force here should not be understood as a zero-sum equation in which one side overpowers the other, because in this case what is being presupposed is the underlying commensurability between the two sides, a commensurability which is based on a heteronomous equation of $A=A$. In a move reminiscent of Heidegger in *The Principle of Identity*, Deleuze uses the notion of force to step out of dialectical, oppositional thinking by replacing the notion of identity or subjectivity with the notion of sensible intensities which organize pre-subjective investments. As Deleuze explains, the meaning of an event is determined not through representation but through the relation of forces (Deleuze 2005a, p. 73). For Deleuze, there is no distinction between beings and forces: ‘the object itself is force, the expression of force’ (Deleuze 2006, p. 6). This understanding of force as the sameness of beings negates the dialectical understanding of beings as distinct entities, either being-in-itself or being-for-itself (Widder 2002, p. 39). It could be said then that whenever there is a juxtaposition of two entities, such as subject and object or form and content, there is already implied a system of relations that is external to the entities in question and this system implicitly implies that the entities adhere to a law or rule that is given by an outside force. It is precisely this idea of an externally given logic that Deleuze opposes by redefining the notion of force. As there is no sovereign and externally given logic that underwrites relations between entities, there is also no hierarchical distinction between distinct kinds of things, which means for instance that material things (table, tree) and thoughts (concepts, ideas) do not belong to separate series but share parallel and mutual organisation. It also means that thoughts are not ascribed to individuals and that there is no principal distinction between thoughts and objects, rather, both thoughts and objects share the same ontological essence that Deleuze and Guattari name ‘becoming’:

We are not in the world; we become with the world; we become by contemplating it. Everything is vision, becoming. We become universes. Becoming animal, plant, molecular, becoming zero. This is true of all the arts. [...] Art does not have opinions. Art undoes the triple organization of perceptions, affections, and opinions in order to substitute a monument composed of percepts, affects, and blocks of sensations that *takes the place of language*. It is about listening [...] This is precisely the task of art.

(Deleuze and Guattari 1994, pp. 170, 177)

Becoming must be understood as the movement of translation between forces. However the translation does not take place between opposites (as dialectical logic would have) rather this translation is more like the Möbius Band where the translation between the two sides is happening on the surface that is both the inside and outside because there is only one surface and yet it has an internal and external dimensions that run around each other, curve around each other but never get into oppositional or confrontational relation. As Golding explains, *becoming* is not designed to replace an ontological beginning, but to get rid of all beginnings, starting points and other forms of telos in as much as beginnings presuppose hierarchy and a linear unfolding.

The roadmap to move beyond representation as the foundation of art requires, according to Deleuze and Guattari revisiting the basic structuralist assumptions about language. If knowledge is based on language, then any attempt to describe the structure of knowledge will have to be outside of the structure and invisible to itself.

However, in the above quotation Deleuze and Guattari also reject the possibility of basing knowledge on experience and perception because experience too presupposes the existence of something that is experienced. The strategic turn to art as a successor of both structuralism and phenomenology is motivated by art's ability to create images that do not bear on any pre-established structure but refer only to themselves. The value of art is not in its ability to commemorate the past, to reflect on situations and to stand for events, rather 'it is a block of present sensations that owe their preservation only to themselves' (Deleuze and Guattari 1994, p. 167). Deleuze and Guattari advance here an understanding of art that is both a continuation of Adorno's *Aesthetic Theory* and a radical break with Adorno's metaphysics. Adorno, like Deleuze and Guattari insists that the role of art is not to express some state of affairs. However, for Adorno art is both true and false at the same time which allows him to claim that art embodies a form of logic that is different to the dominant rationality. In this way art marks the possibility of a better word: 'Art need not defend itself against the rebuke that it is degenerate; art meets this rebuke by refusing to affirm the miserable course of the world as the iron law of nature' (Adorno 1997, p. 65). While not mimetic, art is still a form of identity even if this identity is with its own logic and not with external reality. While Deleuze and Guattari follow Adorno in rejecting mimesis, they also reject the possibility of identity. Deleuze re-defines the notion of simulacrum to propose a work of art that is expression of pure difference.

Art's transformative power lies in its ability to expose life as a force in a constant state of 'becoming'. Art is a philosophy precisely to the extent that it uses its potential to create a concept of difference. So, photography can be considered art in the Deleuze and Guattari sense only if it can offer a perception of difference in the visual field. This requires going beyond the limits of human perception, beyond the visible to the human eye. The photographic apparatus is unique in its ability to produce an image that is simultaneously concrete and yet it is marked by completely pre-human perception. The latent image offers a glimpse into what it is like to perceive as a non-human, what it is like to see with an eye that is not constrained by human psychology and biology. Derrida speaks of the requirement of absolute invisibility as a pre-condition of drawing:

To be the other of the visible, *absolute* invisibility must neither take place elsewhere nor constitute another visible, that is, something that does not yet appear or has already disappeared... This nonvisible does not describe a phenomenon that is present elsewhere, that is latent, imaginary, unconscious, hidden or past... The *aperspective* thus obliges us to consider the objective definition, the anatomico-physiology or ophthalmology of the '*punctum caecum*,' as itself a mere image, an analogical index of vision itself, of vision in general.

(Derrida 1993, p. 52)

'Absolute invisibility' allows one not to see objects, forms, shapes, and colours but to be open to the forces that work within these structures. Invisibility is not the absence of vision, rather it is the step back from visual that allows to evaluate and to interpret the forces within the visual. The stepping back from the visual is the condition under which photography becomes the visible expression of sense.

Conclusion

The outside of thought

Antidote to metaphysical thinking

This book outlined photography as the multi-dimensional, expressive, singular, and non-identical practice that frustrates static, linear, oppositional totalities and reflected subjectivities. The motivation behind this work was to rescue the image from the metaphysics of identity, from being subsumed under the aspect of representation and from being dissolved by subjectivity that seeks to find itself in its own reflection. The photographic image is worth salvaging not because of the sentimental and ruinous attachment to regimes of spectatorship, nor out of surrender to the overwhelming power of the gaze and the admission of the sovereignty of the eye.

This research is driven by frustration with the inability to see despite having these amazing eyes. For some strange reason, it is photography that can point towards a form of seeing that surpasses the visible in favour of the quasi-image that stands against the whole of the philosophical tradition of subjectivity as inaugurated by Descartes's *Cogito*, a tradition which sets one on the path of seeking truth by means of an image and it is quite prepared to sacrifice the knowledge of the image for the sake of this absolute truth. As per Flusser's pithy remark the heirs of the Greeks and the Jews have this in common: they do not tolerate any spiritualisation of matter or materialisation of spirit (Flusser 2012). Both also consider the image to be a second-rate form of reality and it is precisely this which allows the subject to depend on the image for self-knowledge (Gasché 1986, p. 20). Photography is the antidote to metaphysical thinking and the philosophy of identity because photography produces an image of being that carries within it the knowledge of being an image.

The frame: limit of visibility

The frame, the edge of the photograph is the self-referential aspect of the image. The frame seems to indicate in a simple and unambiguous manner that an image is being made. As far as the frame is concerned, there is no question of representation, only of the presence of the statement 'it is an image'. However, it also gets complicated, because the frame implies a content that constitutes the object of the image, a content around which the frame frames. Nevertheless, the object must be suspended for the frame to be articulated and come into view. The object does not come before the frame, the frame, in that sense does not frame the object but dissolves it. Vision here is faced with the almost impossible task of facing the ground zero of vision: the limit of visibility. The frame dissolves not only the object but also the dialectics of

subject and object, form and content. The photographic frame is truly ‘The Thought of the Outside’ as Foucault wished to establish, because it does not lead back into the interiority of the image but only towards the repetition of the frame. For this reason, photography is able to accomplish the break with subjectivity that language can never fully achieve, as Foucault himself admitted: ‘It is extremely difficult to find a language faithful to this thought’ (Foucault 2000, p. 151).

By force of the authorial voice language tends to lead the discourse back into the bowels of subjectivity because the moment it moves beyond deictic statements such as ‘this’, ‘here’ or indeed ‘I speak’, and engages in propositions about objects it is forced to resort to the distinction between the ‘I’ who speaks and the subject of the discourse. In short, in order to become non-metaphysical, language requires a little help from some quarters where subjectivity does not writ large and where expression is separated from authorship. Due to its inseparability from language, philosophy is perpetually under the auspice of *ratio*, unable to go forward (or backward) to the point of madness or unreason. As this book proposed, philosophy that does not want to begin from an image of thought, must begin from an image: Not an image that evokes the subject but one that awakens the unknowable within thought. What is required is not an image of something, not a reflection of pre-given reality, as this immediately brings *ratio* back in as ‘transcendental contraband’ (Derrida 1986, p. 262). Rather, the image has to be able to depict the structural undecidability of the image, the intensity of the libidinal pleasure found in continuous repetition (Lyotard 2004, p. 110).

Photography not a standpoint

Numerous attempts to escape transcendentalist thought ended up bringing the transcendental back in. Human condition might be just that: the never-to-be-fulfilled desire to get out of the metaphysical sphere. Simply stated the problem is that there is no thought without concept, but concept requires bringing into the fold the Trojan horse of *ratio*. Lyotard’s charge against Marxist dialectics is precisely that in positing the material conditions of labour as the ground of history (and of thought) it established materialism as the basis of its own metaphysics. As was suggested on the pages of this book, photography is not a standpoint, rather it points towards a way out of this impasse. It is ready to print a ticket to ride on the plane of immanence, yet above the entrance there is a sign: ‘Admittance to non-humans only’. The language of photography is the language by which immanence speaks: It is the affirmation of difference as the eternal return of the copy. Its voice is heard in the unknowability of the latent image and in the rhythmic cadence of the photographic frame. It is by paying attention to the frame of the photograph that one is able to observe productivity without labour, in other words, here is a productive process that does not establish a transcendental logic (whether materialist or idealist).

The outside of thought

Crucially, photography is not simply a manifestation of desire, of life force or of *élan Vital* because these too presuppose the presence of sensation. At its most basic state a photograph is a mark made by one body on another body. It is *art brut* in its most brutal. It is the hand-to-hand combat and the passage of one body onto the other. For this reason, photography is neither idea nor affect, rather it names the never-to-be-grasped interval between them. The latent image is precisely that: neither an idea nor a body, rather it posits the unknowable as the required third space, the pineal eye between the body and the mind (Golding 2012). There is no ‘image of’ to

speak of as the latent image has no content, it is stripped of all significations. All divisions between inside and outside, between the exteriority of the real world and the depth of the cave are abolished, and yet, it is nothing if not a sign: albeit one that signifies nothing. However, this is not to say that the latent image is a sign of the 'Great Zero', castration, negation or absence, rather it signifies nothing more than the possibility of repetition, the potential to self-replicate and multiply. It is a non-oedipal reproductive encounter that has neither an inside nor an outside. It is also a sign that a body was on hand to make a mark, that force was met with force and is now stored, accumulated in the unknowable image (Lyotard 2004, p. 66). Whether the latent image resembles something or not is a moot point, as it is unknowable, yet it is a diagram of the way the visible and the expressive belong together. Semiology cannot get started at the site of the latent image because, being unknowable, the latent image does not allow for resemblance (identity by another name). The latent image cannot be identified, individualized, or specified; it is fully virtual in Deleuze's sense of unactualized reality. The only thing that can be sensed about the latent image is the sense of there being one. There is no phenomenological content that can be processed by the nervous system, converted into categories, or data tables or used in the construction of subjectivity. Yet, this is not the absence of sense either, for what can be sensed is the presence of sensation capable of repeating itself. This form of repetition is not chronological or linear, it does not repeat what has already happened, it repeats sideways. Instead of memory it requires not exactly forgetting but a kind of memory loss that allows to move along a smooth surface that is inside one moment and outside the other. Like the protagonist of the movie *Memento* for whom the polaroid photograph is not a souvenir from the past but a point of access to a different peak of present, the photographic image points towards a-rational logic of heterogeneity and profusion that precedes the visible image and the subject-object opposition (Deleuze 1989, p. 98). Photography could be said to allow access to the visible that comes before the visual, to the image that does not stand in relation to an object, does not belong to the Cartesian perspectival schema and does not affirm that $A=A$. Instead, the self-replicating formula of photography is $A+A+A+A+\dots$. While the visible image is defined by what it is not (not an object), the photographic image constructed from unknowability and reproduction refuses negation and the communication of meaning in favour of 'the unfolding of pure exteriority' (Foucault 2000, p. 148). This raw and monstrous image is a point of entry to the outside of thought because of its resistance to cognition, consciousness, identity and *ratio*. It is an image not reduced to the human eye.

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